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[Apr 28]

- Goings On
- The Talk of the Town
- Reporting & Essays
- Shouts & Murmurs
- Fiction
- The Critics
- Poems
- Cartoons
- Puzzles & Games

Goings On

- **Oneohtrix Point Never's Sense of the Uncanny**
  By Sheldon Pearce, Dan Stahl, Leo Lasdun, Brian Seibert, Inkoo Kang, Emily Nussbaum, Richard Brody, and Sarah Larson | Also: Sarah Larson's latest podcast picks, "The Rocky Horror Show" and "The Balusters" on Broadway, the French singer Oklou, and more.
- **Cory Doctorow on the High Cost of Living with the Ultra-Rich**
  The writer and internet critic discusses books that reflect different facets of living in a society run by billionaires.

Goings On

Oneohtrix Point Never’s Sense of the Uncanny

Also: Sarah Larson’s latest podcast picks, “The Rocky Horror Show” and “The Balusters” on Broadway, the French singer Oklou, and more.

By Sheldon Pearce, Dan Stahl, Leo Lasdun, Brian Seibert, Inkoo Kang, Emily Nussbaum, Richard Brody, and Sarah Larson

April 24, 2026

You’re reading the Goings On newsletter, a guide to what we’re watching, listening to, and doing this week. ***Sign up to receive it in your inbox.***

The year 2025 presented a full distillation of the Daniel Lopatin experience. The distinguished electronic artist, who performs as **Oneohtrix Point Never**, co-produced one of the biggest pop records of that year, the Weeknd’s dark finale, “Hurry Up Tomorrow”; scored Josh Safdie’s adrenalized Best Picture nominee, “Marty Supreme”; and released his own mutative album, “Tranquilizer,” an ambient archival project that mimes since-deleted nineties sample libraries that Lopatin discovered in the Internet Archive. His music has spanned genres and mediums, with the composer filling various roles, but its through line is its sense of the uncanny and Lopatin’s understanding of how warping sonic textures can tap into surreality. His process, which bridges the neoclassical, the avant-garde, and even the kitsch, has made him one of the defining trackmasters of the twenty-first century. “I’m an amateur musician. I’m a professional recordist,” he told the Creative Independent.

Illustration by Arthur Sevestre

Lopatin's instincts serve him well across all of his creative endeavors, but chiefly in his own compositional work, which now spans eleven LPs that feel committed to creating a repository of every possible sound—from the eerie, liminal minimalism of "Replica" (2011) to the turbocharged rave-pop of "Garden of Delete" (2015) to the psychedelic collage "Magic Oneohtrix Point Never" (2020). On April 29-30, Oneohtrix Point Never opens Bang on a Can's four-day Long Play Festival, at Pioneer Works, for his only currently slated shows in America this year. His set, which follows a performance by the jazz keyboardist John Medeski, features accompanying visuals from the experimental digital artist Freeka Tet.—*Sheldon Pearce*

About Town

Broadway

As dramatic stakes go, the question of whether to install a stop sign on a picturesque block might seem low. But that's only until you meet the Vernon Point Neighborhood Association in **"The Balusters,"** a sharp comedy by David Lindsay-Abaire, for Manhattan Theatre Club. The association's newest member is Kyra (Anika Noni Rose), who joined after moving to the affluent enclave it is in charge of preserving—or policing,

depending on your perspective. Neighborhood gossip delivers revelations; seemingly minor matters involving porch railings swell into arguments about social justice. Lindsay-Abaire's multidirectional repartee gets added zip from the first-rate cast, especially Margaret Colin as the unapologetically blunt Ruth. With propulsive direction by Kenny Leon.—*Dan Stahl (Friedman; through May 24.)*

Ambient Pop

What if the birth of John the Baptist was celebrated at a black-lit basement rave? The French singer-songwriter **Oklou** conjures such a scene on "Harvest Sky"—an anthemic dance tune inspired by her memories of la Fête de la Saint-Jean—from her 2025 record, "Choke Enough." The album is full of strange, brilliant contradictions; Oklou slides masterfully between fun and eccentricity, pump and pathos. On the title track, she threatens to crash a car for a good photo, and then ponders whether her dad might appreciate an especially pretty moonlit night. Synthesizers warble and phasings range from gritty-grindy to flip-phone-keypad mellow. Oklou is taking "Choke Enough" on tour after postponing for a year to spend time with her newborn. And monolinguals needn't worry, she sings in English.—*Leo Lasdun (Terminal 5; May 2-3.)*

Dance

Parsons Dance.Photograph by Rachel Neville / Courtesy Parsons Dance

Parsons Dance has long been known for its high-energy, high-spirited style. That's also the trademark of Courtney (Balenciaga) Washington, a choreographer from the worlds of competition dance and vogue ballrooms. "Fearless," her first work for the Parsons troupe, has fun in the crossover space, demanding precision and fierceness from the dancers as they arrange themselves in one formation after another. The program also features a première by the choreographer David Parsons himself, set to the second movement of Beethoven's Ninth Symphony, and one by Mayte Natalio, a former company member who's made a name for herself as a choreographer of theatre, including "Suffs" on Broadway.—*Brian Seibert (Joyce Theatre; April 29-May 10.)*

Broadway

Even amid Broadway's queer renaissance, Richard O'Brien's **"The Rocky Horror Show"** stands out as a transgressive blast. Luke Evans is a gloriously seductive Frank-N-Furter; Josh Rivera an adorable Rocky; Amber Gray a sharp Riff-Raff; Michaela Jaé Rodriguez a sweet Columbia; and Stephanie Hsu a spicy standout as Janet, wriggling with horndog virtuosity through "Touch-a, Touch-a, Touch-a Me." Rachel Dratch is perfectly arch as the smoking-jacketed narrator, riffing effortlessly with the audience. (No one threw toast, but we yelled "asshole" and "slut.") There's no ironing out the kinky plot, thank the Lord—Frank tricks the couple into sex; gender identities remain queenily chaotic. The director Sam Pinkleton ("Oh, Mary!") uses simple, clever devices such as tiny, neon-green castles and wacky placards, lending the show a shaggy pro-am energy. Give yourself over to ultimate pleasure.—*Emily Nussbaum (Studio 54; through July 19.)*

Television

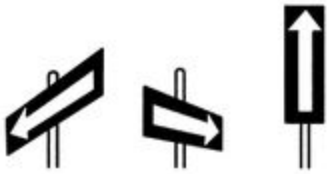
Dan Levy and Taylor Ortega.Photograph by Spencer Pazer / Courtesy Netflix

“Big Mistakes,” on Netflix, co-created by Dan Levy and Rachel Sennott, has a manic, overheated energy: Nicky (Levy), a quasi-closeted pastor, and his sister Morgan (Taylor Ortega), an elementary-school teacher, are unhappy in their jobs; when Morgan steals a necklace, they’re kidnapped by a Turkish gangster named Yusuf, who forces them to perform odd jobs. Nicky and Morgan’s narcissistic mom, Linda, is played by a wonderfully typecast Laurie Metcalf. The gangland drama is deeper and darker than the domestic one, strengthened by the unexpected portrayal of the Russian toughs as bumbling in their own way. The show comes close to making a point about criminal and family hierarchies—but it, like its characters, has a policy of shooting first, asking questions later.—*Inkoo Kang*

Movies

“Michael,” the story of Michael Jackson’s rise to fame, presents a surprisingly detailed view of the behind-the-scenes dealings on which his career depended. As a child performing with his brothers at the family home in Gary, Indiana, young Michael (Juliano Krue Valdi) is beaten by his father, Joe (Colman Domingo), who demands obedience along with musical discipline. The Jackson Five find success; then, in the late seventies, the adult Michael (played, with extraordinary flair, by Jaafar Jackson, Michael’s real-life nephew) seeks a solo career—and confronts Joe’s domineering maneuvers. The director, Antoine Fuqua, working with a script by John Logan, portrays Michael as an emotionally stunted and grievously wounded artist of historic greatness. The movie omits allegations that the

singer sexually assaulted children (which he denied).—*Richard Brody (In wide release.)*



Pick Three

Sarah Larson on podcasts in which families and mysteries converge.

1. “The Idiot,” from the journalist M. Gessen and Serial Productions, explores the case of Gessen’s “least favorite cousin” and a murder-for-hire plot. Cousin Allen, a shady-seeming braggart living in Russia, shows up to Gessen’s father’s house in Cape Cod with his young son, having apparently abducted the boy; Gessen—a wryly appealing narrator-detective—is immediately suspicious, and unspools the head-spinning details of Allen’s behavior while treating the listener like an intelligent friend.

2. In **“Passenger Seat,”** the independent journalist and first-time podcaster Tom Joudrey explores the strange case of a retired lawyer who was kidnapped at gunpoint in 2012 while walking her dog in rural Ohio. She survived, and now Joudrey wants to know why she helped her captor—and thanked him in the courtroom. The revelations get familial, psychological, and stunning, as do Joudrey’s conversations with the kidnapper, now in prison. The series’ earnestly naïve sound design (horses neighing, cars revving) only enhanced my appreciation of Joudrey’s sophisticated storytelling.

Raven Chanticleer outside Madison Square Garden, in 1971.Photograph by Don Jacobsen / Newsday RM / Getty

3. The African American Wax Museum, in Harlem, was the singular creation of the artist and eccentric Raven Chanticleer, a sharecropper's son from South Carolina who reinvented himself, spectacularly, in Manhattan. After he died, in 2002, his relatives sold the museum's building and, it was rumored, destroyed its contents. In **"Raven,"** the journalist Gavin Whitehead investigates what happened to Chanticleer's wax Harriet Tubman, Langston Hughes, and other creations, and unearths unexpected wonders galore, set to subtle background music that riffs on "Take the A Train."

P.S. Good stuff on the internet:

- *Welcome to the nineteen-nineties*

- *The magic is coming back*
- *Jay McInerney, eternal party correspondent*

Sheldon Pearce is a music writer for The New Yorker's Goings On newsletter.
Dan Stahl is a member of The New Yorker's editorial staff.
Brian Seibert has been contributing to The New Yorker since 2002. He is the author of "What the Eye Hears: A History of Tap Dancing," which won an Anisfield-Wolf Book Award. His writing appears in the New York Times and the New York Review of Books. A Guggenheim fellow, he teaches at Yale University.
Inkoo Kang, a staff writer, has been a television critic for The New Yorker since 2022.
Emily Nussbaum, a staff writer at The New Yorker since 2011, is the magazine's theatre critic. Her books include "Cue The Sun!: The Invention of Reality TV."
Richard Brody, a film critic, began writing for The New Yorker in 1999. He is the author of "Everything Is Cinema: The Working Life of Jean-Luc Godard."
Sarah Larson, a staff writer, has been contributing to The New Yorker since 2007.

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Book Currents

Cory Doctorow on the High Cost of Living with the Ultra-Rich

The writer and internet critic discusses books that reflect different facets of living in a society run by billionaires.

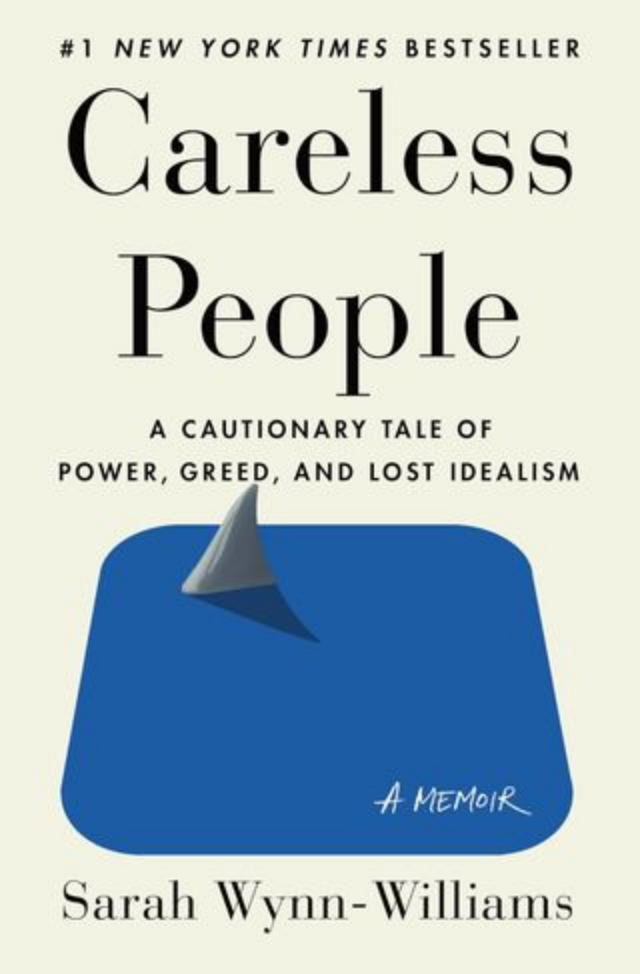
April 15, 2026

You're reading Book Currents, a weekly column in which notable figures share what they're reading. ***Sign up for the Goings On newsletter*** *to receive their selections, and other cultural recommendations, in your inbox.*

"Billionaireism," as defined by the writer and internet critic Cory Doctorow, describes "both the pathology that affects you when you are so wealthy that you're effectively above consequences and above moral consideration for others, and the pathologies that having a society dominated by such people inflicts on the rest of us." (One such pathology is the rapid decline in quality of digital platforms which Doctorow has termed "enshittification," and which was the subject of a book he published last year.) A while ago, Doctorow joined us to talk about some books that illuminate different facets of living in a highly unequal society where the richest measure their wealth in billions. His remarks have been edited and condensed.

Careless People

by Sarah Wynn-Williams



Amazon | **Bookshop**

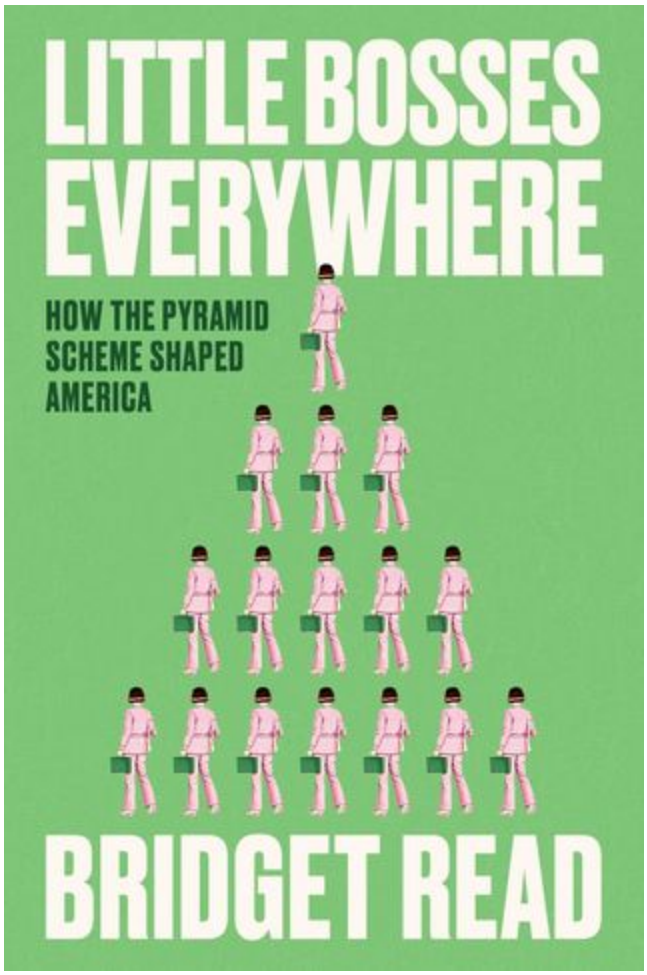
This is an extraordinary book by a woman who served as a government-relations executive at Facebook, working directly under Sheryl Sandberg, Joel Kaplan, and Mark Zuckerberg—the company's three big beasts. Wynn-Williams enters her role very enthusiastic about Facebook's possibilities, but she soon becomes disenchanted. Many of those reasons are obvious, but there is also a lot in this book that has not previously been revealed. She describes instances of horrible sexual harassment and personal cruelty, like when, in a performance review, she was chastised for being "unresponsive" during a period when she was in a coma.

The ways in which the people Wynn-Williams worked with are shown to be "careless" evolve throughout the book. At the beginning, they seem more like people who unthinkingly flick cigarette butts out of the window when it's been a dry summer. They're careless in a reckless way. But, by the end,

when Facebook has become structurally important to many governments—and much of the book is about how Kaplan sets out to accomplish this, in part through embedding with the Trump campaign—her co-workers become careless in the sense of just not giving a fuck about social duties or morality. It's a Leona Helmsley, "Taxes are for the little people" variety of carelessness.

Little Bosses Everywhere

by Bridget Read



Amazon | **Bookshop**

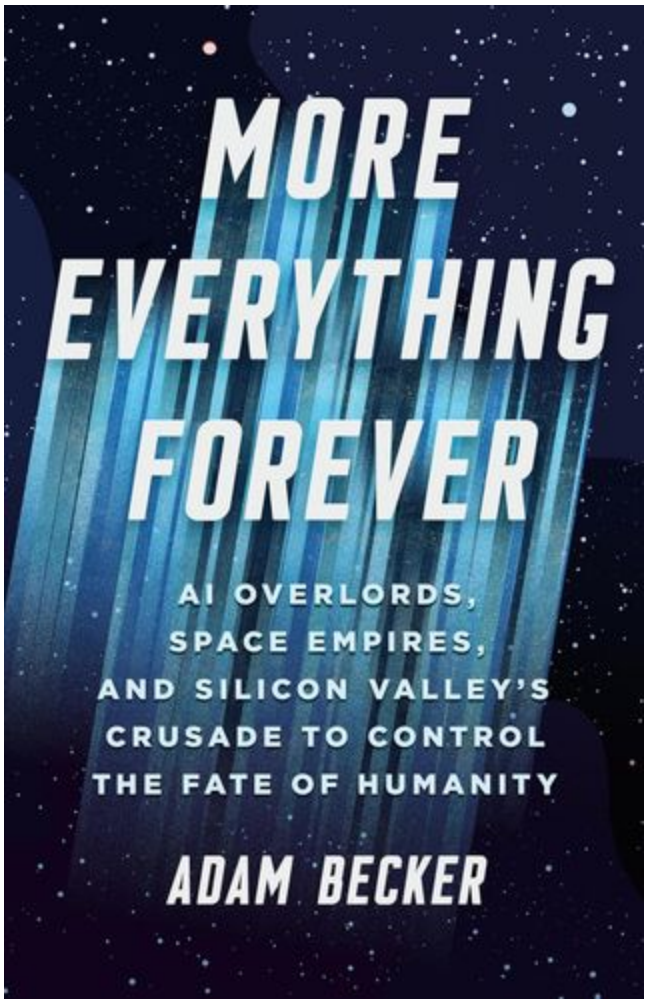
This is a book about the history of pyramid schemes, and specifically about a form of pyramid scheme known as "multi-level marketing," or M.L.M. In the schemes, people are recruited to become salespeople for companies that

sell their products directly to consumers, and then, when they fail to sell—because the products are not very good—the salespeople buy the inventory themselves to meet quotas. The M.L.M. world is also filled with people offering seminars on how to sell, preying on people who have already been scammed.

The connection between this stuff and billionaireism is that, first of all, the people at the top are very rich. They make a lot of money by basically lying about how they make money. And, second of all, the institutional support for policies that make billionaireism possible was in many ways created and financed by the M.L.M. industry. The Heritage Foundation, which laid the groundwork for so many laws that help make oligarchy possible, was bankrolled by Jay Van Andel and Rich DeVos (Betsy DeVos's father-in-law), the founders of Amway—a consumer packaged-goods M.L.M. company—when Amway was on the verge of being crushed by F.T.C. regulations. Read's book is a great explanatory account of the industry, connecting big, nebulous ideas like neoliberalism to actual concrete things.

More Everything Forever

by Adam Becker



Amazon | **Bookshop**

Becker, who has a Ph.D. in astrophysics, is a wonderful science communicator. This book repudiates the nonsense that we hear from people suffering from what we might call terminal billionaireism, about things that we can do with computers and rocket ships which are—if you know anything about the subjects—really dumb. He runs through a gamut of billionaire beliefs, from the colonization of Mars to uploading human minds into computers to A.I. waking up and turning us all into paper clips. He devastates a lot of the foundations for these arguments—the problem with the Mars idea, for example, is that there's no magnetic field around its atmosphere, the soil is poisonous, and, ultimately, even if you were to detonate every nuclear bomb on Earth, this would still be a better place for us to live. He also shows how self-serving these ideas are. Elon Musk's boosterism about Mars was part and parcel of him getting hundreds of millions of dollars from the U.S. government in space contracts.

This is less heavy than the other books—it's definitely popular science. But it's popular science with teeth. Becker interviews people from other disciplines—mathematicians, neuroscientists—and the result is a book that does a great job of showing how deluded, stupid, or in bad faith many of these billionaires' claims are, and of providing a powerful antidote to hype. As Becker points out, a lot of these futurist ideas supported by billionaires—space travel, unfettered A.I. development, carbon sequestration, and the like—they're just ways to get around decarbonization, and to avoid having to put together a muscular climate agenda where states intervene in markets to prevent them from rendering the only planet capable of sustaining human life in the known universe uninhabitable.

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The Talk of the Town

- **Donald Trump's Spring Cleaning**
  By Benjamin Wallace-Wells | The exact reasons are often left vague and the successors to be determined, but people are leaving the Administration—including three Cabinet secretaries.
- **Reverend Billy Takes On Norman Foster's New Monolith**
  By Jake Offenhartz | Fresh from opening shows for Neil Young, the street preacher Billy Talen has moved on from burning Mickey Mouse in effigy to protesting JPMorgan Chase's ties to fossil fuels.
- **Medallions, Movement, and Mamdani at MOMA PS1**
  By Emma Allen | The cab-driving Elcharfa brothers, Bilal and Salah, star in a new piece by the artist Kenneth Tam that showcases the hardships of their jobs.
- **Patrick Ball's Path to Broadway and "Becky Shaw"**
  By Rachel Syme | Before "The Pitt," the actor waited tables, made lattes, and schlepped Carrie Bradshaw's wardrobe around town.
- **Ellen Burstyn's Inner Library**
  By Michael Schulman | Kris Kristofferson told her he was a poet when they co-starred in "Alice Doesn't Live Here Anymore." Her new book tells the story of her life in poetry.

Comment

Donald Trump’s Spring Cleaning

The exact reasons are often left vague and the successors to be determined, but people are leaving the Administration—including three Cabinet secretaries.

By Benjamin Wallace-Wells

April 26, 2026

Photo illustration by Cristiana Couceiro; Source photographs from Getty

In the midst of a war, Donald Trump has started to get rid of his senior officials. The exact reasons are often left vague, and the successors to be determined, but people are leaving. On March 5th, Trump fired Homeland Security Secretary Kristi Noem; on April 2nd, it was Attorney General Pam Bondi, and, on April 20th, Labor Secretary Lori Chavez-DeRemer stepped down under pressure—three Cabinet secretaries, all women, gone in less than two months. By last week, the F.B.I. director, Kash Patel, seemed to be headed for trouble, too.

The President is also reportedly annoyed with his National Intelligence director, Tulsi Gabbard, and with his Commerce Secretary and friend, Howard Lutnick, about, as *Politico* put it, “how much Lutnick’s family has been profiting off their association with the President’s brand.” The atmosphere is one of discontent and distraction. A month into the Iran war, Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth fired the Army chief of staff, Randy George. Then, after reciting a prayer that Hegseth said was inspired by Scripture but seemed directly lifted from “Pulp Fiction,” last week he ended a vaccine mandate for soldiers—a protocol initiated by General George Washington, in 1777—and fired the Secretary of the Navy, John Phelan, during a naval blockade.

When a group of senior figures in an Administration depart, it’s natural to suspect political dark arts—that one faction has forced the exit of another. But there is no such obvious distinction now: those who have been pushed out and those who so far remain are all hard-line *MAGA*. Instead, scandals have provided rolling revelations of a general unseriousness. Noem was fired after a scorched-earth immigration-enforcement regime had alienated much of the public, and amid reports that she had spent nearly two hundred million dollars of department funds to purchase two luxury jets, and two hundred million to create an ad campaign, largely starring herself. Chavez-DeRemer is the subject of an internal investigation based on a whistle-blower complaint accusing her of having an affair with a member of her security detail, of using government funds for personal travel, and of drinking on the job; her husband was banned from department headquarters following allegations of sexual misconduct toward staffers, which he has denied. (A lawyer representing Chavez-DeRemer said that she disputed all of the allegations, and no charges have been filed against her husband.) Patel, who earlier this year was found to have assigned F.B.I. officers to protect his girlfriend, a country singer, last week sued *The Atlantic* for defamation after it reported that his security detail has often had trouble rousing him for work following nights out drinking, and on one occasion called for “breaching equipment” to break down a door and wake him.

That these staffing changes and scandals involve figures from such disparate parts of the Administration, and are coming just months ahead of the midterm elections, suggests a more generalized crisis. Sixty-seven per

cent of Americans disapprove of the job that Trump is doing, according to an A.P.-*NORC* poll published last week, and part of the story of both his plummeting numbers and the chaos in the Administration is the ongoing crisis of conservative expertise. Trump's first term was marked—and, in the view of those closest to him, limited—by its dependence on Administration officials who were, at best, skeptical of his aims. This time around, Trump has gone for loyalty. Bondi, for instance, was very willing to carry out his imperative to punish civil servants who had helped President Biden to "weaponize" the government against him; the problem was that she couldn't make it happen. "Part of the reason the weaponization work has been difficult is that you need people who are *MAGA* and who are really competent," Chad Mizelle, who was Bondi's chief of staff, told CNN recently. "Many career prosecutors are not interested in this kind of work. It's a very small group of people."

It appears that the whole government is now being run by a very small group of people. When Trump swept back into office, the sense of right-wing momentum hinged on two sources of strength: the dedication of the conservative lawyers behind Project 2025, who seemed to have planned out in exhilarating detail the transformation of a liberal state into a Trumpist one, and the commitment of a cadre of Silicon Valley investors and executives surrounding Elon Musk, who, even if they didn't know much (or anything) about government, had theories about how to deliver dramatic organizational change.

But what they produced was hype—promises of transformation far too expansive to deliver. Musk initially pledged two trillion dollars in savings from *DOGE*; when *Politico* surveyed the effects last August, it found about $1.4 billion in spending cuts, which, though devastating to a number of programs, were less than a tenth of one per cent of the original target. Trump said on the campaign trail that he would deport between fifteen million and twenty million people, and the former Border Patrol official Gregory Bovino told the *Times* that he'd drawn up plans to deport a hundred million people—which would be nearly a third of the nation's population. The government actually deported more than six hundred and seventy-five thousand people, but getting just to that number involved broad and violent sweeps and the expulsion of people who were in the

country legally, actions that led to widespread protests. On top of that, for all Hegseth's boasts of "maximum lethality" and the President's promises of a speedy resolution, the war has been a cascading mess.

Meanwhile, in Washington, the Administration is paying out refunds for tariffs that it could not convince even a very friendly Supreme Court it had the legal authority to enforce, and has spent much of the past year entangled in revelations from the Jeffrey Epstein case, the political consequences of which were another reason, apparently, that Trump turned on Bondi. Contained within all these fiascoes is a subtly different conservative movement. The theme of the first Trump Administration was an outsider revolt against the establishment; the theme of the second is its own entitlement. That perhaps explains the sordid atmosphere around the departures and the scandals—the sex, the booze—and also the disinterest in expertise and the corrosive self-certainty. The President got what he most wanted, a White House filled with loyalists. But that has turned out to be not at all what he needed. ♦

Benjamin Wallace-Wells began contributing to The New Yorker in 2006 and joined the magazine as a staff writer in 2015. He writes about American politics and society.

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Doomsday Dept.

Reverend Billy Takes On Norman Foster’s New Monolith

Fresh from opening shows for Neil Young, the street preacher Billy Talen has moved on from burning Mickey Mouse in effigy to protesting JPMorgan Chase’s ties to fossil fuels.

By Jake Offenhartz

April 27, 2026

Illustration by João Fazenda

A little after midnight on Earth Day, the street preacher Billy Talen dragged his pulpit to the new Norman Foster-designed global headquarters of JPMorgan Chase, on Madison. His self-ordained mission: deliver a twenty-four-hour sermon, calling attention to the bank’s ties to the fossil-fuel

industry. Talen, who is seventy-five, held an umbrella above his white leisure suit and silver bouffant, eying a pair of bank security guards. “Blessings upon your souls, gentlemen,” he bellowed. Members of his activist ensemble, the Stop Shopping Choir, were setting up a live stream in the rain. Savitri Durkee, who directs both the choir and Talen, who is her husband, clipped a mike to his lapel and checked her watch. “It’s go-time, Billy,” she said. “See you on the other side.”

Talen, who goes by Reverend Billy, is fond of what he calls “extreme preaching.” He began in the mid-nineties, marching around Times Square with “Antichrist” Mickey Mouse nailed to a wooden cross, in protest of the neighborhood’s creeping corporatism. In the years since, his focus has shifted to the climate crisis. Often, this involves staging musical protests in hostile venues—banks, pipeline-construction zones—until he and his flock are arrested for trespassing. But, Talen said, even that has begun to feel “predictable.” He elaborated, speaking into a camera: “The only way we’re going to start an effective movement is if each of us goes to the limit of our capabilities and claims our eccentricities. I’m a preacher, so I’m going to preach until I drop.” A choir member checked the stream, and noted that they’d just jumped from five to fourteen viewers. “Earthalujah!” Talen cried.

After decades of sneaking up on bankers and lobbyists, Reverend Billy and the choir recently booked a straight gig: touring the country as Neil Young’s opening act. (Typical song: “A Tree Is the Opposite of a Cop.”) The rock star’s fans seemed receptive to the message, relatively. “After a lifetime of being too strange, people are starting to get us,” Talen said. He’s also the religion editor for the *Times-Contrarian*, Young’s anti-corporate “digital newspaper.” “Neil is a hands-on publisher,” Talen said. “Sometimes he lets me write these really long things. Other times, he’ll say to me, ‘Billy, what do you mean here? What do you want to leave us with?,’ and we’ll e-mail back and forth on that.” Talen said that he’s learned a lot from Young as a performer: “He’s taught me to hold the rhythm, hit the rhyme. He gets what appeals to a mass audience.” Talen and Durkee were connected with the singer by Young’s wife, Daryl Hannah, whom they met at a 2009 protest against mountaintop-removal coal mining in West Virginia. Talen was later arrested, after depositing mounds of “sacred dirt”—taken from the

mountain, he claimed—at two Chase branches in the East Village. The bank has since decreased financing for companies involved in mountaintop-removal mining.

By 8 *A.M.*, dark circles had formed under Talen's steely blue eyes. "I just need to stay hydrated," he said. Behind him, a gardener was washing a living-wall installation titled "A Parallel Nature," designed for Chase by Maya Lin. "I'm finding myself mesmerized by this strange, sculpted nature wall," Talen said. "It feels like a memory." After conferring with a guard, the gardener pointed his hose at the protesters in the plaza. Talen pulled a rain slicker over his suit and glowered. Thousands of workers were now streaming into the building, mostly ignoring the doomsday preacher.

Around lunchtime, roughly two dozen choir members and other activists arrived for a 5K run around the bank. Among them was Ahmed, an asylum seeker from Guinea who had taken refuge in the choir's former headquarters, a vacant bank on Avenue C, after arriving in the United States. "It's very scary-looking," he said of Chase's sixty-story tower. Many of the runners had procured thrift-store blazers or top hats, an effort to blend in with the bankers. Durkee, who wore a pin-striped suit, led the group in some stretches, followed by twelve laps around the block. A construction worker sanding down a railing offered support—"You got this!"—but appeared confused by a runner's sign accusing Chase of ecocide. "I thought it was, like, a charity thing," he said.

As night fell, Talen huddled under a blanket with other choir members. His once thunderous voice had dropped to a rasp as he condemned the "gangsters in suits" responsible for rising global temperatures. In the final minutes of his sermon, he found himself at an unusual loss for words. "It feels like, well, extreme exhaustion, I guess," he said. "Or a long hike that got out of hand, and now I have to come down the mountain." Had the suffering been worth it? "I'm not sure we cracked the culture," he said. "But we had a vision, and we did what we could." ♦

Jake Offenhartz is a reporter for the Associated Press covering New York City.

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Here To There Dept.

Medallions, Movement, and Mamdani at MOMA PS1

The cab-driving Elcharfa brothers, Bilal and Salah, star in a new piece by the artist Kenneth Tam that showcases the hardships of their jobs.

By Emma Allen

April 27, 2026

Illustration by João Fazenda

On Election Night, Mayor Zohran Mamdani proclaimed, from a stage, “My brother, we are in City Hall now!” The remark was directed at Richard Chow, a cabdriver from Myanmar whom Mamdani had joined in 2021 on a

fifteen-day hunger strike, to demand relief for the taxi-medallion debt crisis. The crisis, in brief: the N.Y.C. Taxi and Limousine Commission sells permits ("medallions") to operate yellow cabs; the medallion—till recently a near-million-dollar investment—had its bottom drop out, owing to predatory lending and the deregulation of rideshare services. The body of Chow's brother, Kenny, who'd accrued enormous medallion-related debt, was found in the East River in 2018. Chow would later chauffeur Mamdani to Gracie Mansion.

The other day, the artist Kenneth Tam, forty-four, was in Queens, admiring his contribution to *MOMA* PS1's "Greater New York" survey of art with ties to the metropolitan area. Title: "I'm Staying Hopeful and Strong (for Bilal and Salah)." A projected video showed the sixtysomething Lebanese taxi-driver brothers Bilal and Salaheldin Elcharfa performing interpretive movements in an empty gymnasium while intoning words they wrote about the crisis ("no retirement no retirement no retirement / scared scared scared"). Also, on the floor of the gallery: wood-beaded seat covers and other car detritus.

Tam had previously worked with nonprofessional performers in his video-art projects (Craigslist-sourced fraternity brothers and cowboys). But recruiting taxi-drivers proved difficult. He tried pitching the idea from back seats, but no luck. Then a black-car driver took him to the "J.F.K. taxi hole."

"It's essentially a lot where all the yellow cabs go and take their breaks," Tam said. Rideshare drivers, too, but they have a separate zone. There's also a space for prayer. "Ostensibly, they're there to wait for the call to go to J.F.K., but I met guys that aren't even drivers anymore, who go to hang out." Tam and his producer knocked on windows and handed out flyers. Finally, he approached Bilal in the bathroom line. "I did make it clear that this was not necessarily an advocacy project: 'I'm not an activist, but I do want to tell your story, in a different way.' " A way that would eventually involve dancing with metal folding chairs—but one thing at a time.

Outside the museum, Bilal was parked by a fire hydrant in his yellow RAV4. Salah was still en route from Staten Island. Of first meeting Tam, Bilal said, "He asked me, 'Are you interested in being in a movie?' "

“A loose documentary,” Tam clarified.

Bilal was game. “When someone has anger inside them, you want to explore it with the outsider,” he said.

“Did you appreciate then that you would have to dance?” Tam asked.

“It was really interesting, to go for it,” Bilal said. “Falling down, reaching out, maybe looking for some hope. I was sitting in a box where I just felt like, I’m not able to get out of my situation by circling around, making all the moves—this way, that way, left, right, down, up.” He punched a fist into the air.

When things for the brothers turned grim, “we were always leaning on each other,” Bilal said. “Don’t give up. Keep going.” A friend died of a heart attack when the value of his medallion tanked.

“You’re not sick of each other?” Tam asked.

“I’m thinking about getting a dog and talking about dogs for the rest of my life.”
Cartoon by Bruce Eric Kaplan

“We fight. But we never really broke up. The next day, it’s as if nothing happened. That’s our attitude.”

Salah called to say that he was stuck on the Verrazzano Bridge.

Tam said that he’d learned to drive in a suburban part of Queens—“and I distinctly remember, for my road test, I didn’t even encounter a traffic

light.”

Bilal laughed. “In Lebanon,” he said, “my dad told me, ‘Just drive.’ ”

Salah was still in traffic, so Bilal decided to drive to him. Eventually, he spotted his brother and honked, yelling, “Follow that cab!”

Everyone piled into one car. Salah recounted meeting Tam: “He asked, ‘What kind of song do you like?’ ” The finished video is minimally scored, but, while shooting, Tam had the Elcharfas dance to their favorite tunes. Salah’s: Air Supply’s “Making Love Out of Nothing at All.” Bilal’s: the Scorpions’ “When the Smoke Is Going Down.”

“I’m secretly hoping Mamdani makes an appearance at PS1,” Tam said.

“He’s going to help, but he’s not going to get us back to what was before,” Salah predicted. Both brothers voted for Mamdani, though Bilal also had a laminated photo of Trump (fist raised) dangling from his rearview mirror.

The brothers’ kids recently watched Tam’s film. Bilal: “They were making fun of me—‘You’re getting old! What are you doing?’ ”

Salah: “My daughter, she’s copying me. She starts making the same movements. I said, ‘Maybe I’m going to be a movie star!’ ”

“I explained to them, ‘That’s an art project,’ ” Bilal said. “ ‘The words plus the movement, it makes a story about our situation.’ Hopefully, maybe, we educate the public.” ♦

Emma Allen is The New Yorker’s cartoon editor and edits humor pieces on newyorker.com.

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The Boards

Patrick Ball’s Path to Broadway and “Becky Shaw”

Before “The Pitt,” the actor waited tables, made lattes, and schlepped Carrie Bradshaw’s wardrobe around town.

By Rachel Syme

April 27, 2026

Illustration by João Fazenda

Two years ago, the actor Patrick Ball was thirty-four years old and working three jobs in the city, none of them glamorous. He was a server at the Fort Greene restaurant Evelina, a barista at the Chelsea café the Sleeping Cat,

and a wardrobe production assistant for the HBO series “And Just Like That . . .” (“driving the costume shoppers around to pick up Carrie Bradshaw’s outfits,” as he described it). His acting career wasn’t going as he had hoped. He’d earned his M.F.A. from Yale’s drama school, in 2022, and had done regional theatre, but he’d had no luck with Broadway. His IMDb page listed just two credits: an episode of “Law & Order” and a straight-to-streaming sci-fi flick called “ReEntry” (as “Bartender”). When he told co-workers that he was still hoping to hit the big time, he recalled, “they’d say, ‘Uh, sure. O.K., dude.’ Then they’d ask me to make an almond-milk latte.”

In 2024, Ball submitted a self-tape for an upcoming HBO Max series called “The Pitt,” which would follow the lives of several E.R. doctors at a crowded teaching hospital in Pittsburgh. It was a good fit, if a long shot; Ball grew up near Greensboro, North Carolina, with an emergency-room-nurse mother and a paramedic father. While waiting to hear back, he started filling out applications for sensible day jobs in nonprofit fund-raising.

It turned out that “The Pitt” was looking for untested talent, and Ball was cast as Dr. Frank Langdon, a resident who struggles with addiction and gets busted for stealing drugs. When Ball told his boss on “And Just Like That . . .” that he was quitting his menial job on one HBO show to take a leading role in a different HBO show, “they were, like, ‘Excuse me, what?’ ” he said. “ ‘Aren’t you the guy who drives us around?’ ”

With “The Pitt” a smash success, recently renewed for a third season, its cast members—many of them, like Ball, previous unknowns—are suddenly in demand. Ball is finally on Broadway, starring in “Becky Shaw,” a dark comedy about a blind date gone wrong. He plays a character he describes as “a toxically nice guy.”

These days, Ball can’t walk down the street without people noticing his cut-glass jawline and chin dimple, and he has taken to wearing a medical mask to hide. On a recent morning, he strapped on the mask and strolled into an office tower near Penn Station; he took the elevator up to Pearl Studios, a warren of rehearsal spaces and audition rooms where he logged a lot of hours during the lean years. “I was such a frequent flier in this building,” he said. “I know exactly how it feels to sit in the hallway with four other dudes

who look exactly like you, all wearing the same blue denim shirt, going up for the same part."

Ball was there to visit the casting director Pat McCorkle, who gave him his first Equity gig, in the play "Shining City" at Barrington Stage Company, in the Berkshires. He ambled through the halls, which smelled of burnt coffee and sweaty socks, until he found a small room where McCorkle sat behind a folding table in a long-sleeved black shirt, ashy blond hair skimming her shoulders. She gave Ball a hug, then exclaimed, "He returns!"

That day, McCorkle and her associates were running an open call for Barrington Stage's summer season. "I've done the high-profile Hollywood thing," she said. "I helped cast young Matt Damon and Brendan Fraser in 'School Ties.' But I far prefer this. I don't like the work of just hiring Tom Cruise."

"You were my lifeline," Ball told her. "You brought me in for everything, even things that I wasn't even remotely right for."

"Well, if I like you, I'm going to keep seeing you," McCorkle said.

"I got to do 'All My Sons' in St. Louis and 'Cat on a Hot Tin Roof' back in Greensboro," Ball said. "Here, my agents just kept putting me up for these CW shows about vampires. They just wanted me to be a generic 'hot guy.' "

"Oh, honey," McCorkle said, with a laugh. "I've cast four Hallmark movies_—_I know. I just said, 'Your time will come.' "

Ball rolled up a sleeve to show off some beaded friendship bracelets adorned with phrases like "*Da Pitt*" and "*Ball Is Life*." They were gifts from fans, bestowed at the stage door of the Hayes Theatre, where "Becky Shaw" is playing, as an homage to similar bracelets that Dr. Langdon wears on "The Pitt." The sudden rush of attention has been overwhelming. Last fall, Ball asked his "Pitt" co-star Noah Wyle, who broke out at twenty-three, on "ER," for advice on how to handle it. "And Noah said, 'You're so lucky this is happening in your thirties,' " he recounted. " 'You've had the opportunity to figure out how to be a regular person in the world.' "

Ball mentioned that this chat had happened “on the P.J., flying out from the Emmys.” “P.J.” means “private jet”; Ball is, at least, adapting quickly to the lingo. ♦

Rachel Syme is a staff writer at The New Yorker. She has covered Hollywood, style, literature, music, and other cultural subjects since 2012.

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Retrospective

Ellen Burstyn’s Inner Library

Kris Kristofferson told her he was a poet when they co-starred in “Alice Doesn’t Live Here Anymore.” Her new book tells the story of her life in poetry.

By Michael Schulman

April 27, 2026

Illustration by João Fazenda

The actress Ellen Burstyn has what she calls an “inner library” of poetry that she has memorized in the course of her long life. “I’m ninety-three now, so I probably have less in my head than I used to when it comes to poems,” she said the other day. “But some have been there for years.

Decades.” Burstyn was in her Upper West Side apartment, which was festooned with books, plants, crystals, orbs, and statues of Shiva and Buddha and Guanyin (“the goddess of compassion,” she noted). Meditative music piped in through the sound system. “I was getting a massage, so it’s left over,” she explained.

She wore green slacks, a green turtleneck, and a green cardigan (“I do like green”), with chunky metallic necklaces. In her writing room, lined with shelves of Mary Oliver and Rumi—her Oscar, for “Alice Doesn’t Live Here Anymore,” was across the hall—she showed off the desk where she wrote her new book, “Poetry Says It Better,” in which she revisits her life story through verses she has loved. “I like what metaphors set off in your mind,” she said. “I like what poetry plays with.”

She settled into a wicker chair in the living room, beneath a wooden mermaid that she got in Mexico. Her cavapoo, Kerri, sat regally on a divan. The first poem that spoke to Burstyn, she recalled, was William Ernest Henley’s “Invictus,” which she read in high school, in Detroit. “ ‘I am the master of my fate, I am the captain of my soul’—that awakened an understanding in me that life was not always going to be the way it was.” At school, she was head cheerleader, but her home life was arduous. “My mother married a man who hated her two children,” she said. “I was being punished a lot physically.” She wrote her own poem and gave it to a boy in her class. “He said, ‘Just because your name is Edna’—which was my original name—‘doesn’t mean you have to copy her style.’ I said, ‘Who?’ ” That’s how she discovered Edna St. Vincent Millay. “It was like she was my voice,” she said, and rattled off Millay’s sonnet “Love Is Not All.”

At nineteen, Burstyn married her first husband, a poet and car salesman (“In Detroit, everybody’s involved with cars”), who introduced her to Baudelaire. “When I read Baudelaire now, I go, Boy, he’s really dark!” she said. By twenty-four, she was modelling in New York and decided to become an actress. “I went around saying, ‘I’m going to do a Broadway play this fall. Do you know how I can get an audition?’ ” It worked: she made her Broadway début in 1957, in the comedy “Fair Game.” Her determination put her in mind of the poem “For Longing,” by John O’Donohue: “May you have the courage to listen to the voice of desire.”

Some years later, in Hollywood, she was acting in the Debbie Reynolds flick “Goodbye Charlie.” “I said, ‘This is it. This is the big time. Next I’ll be playing Debbie Reynolds’s part!’ And this voice in my head said, *I don’t want it*,” she recalled. Through Shelley Winters, she met the acting teacher Lee Strasberg and studied with him. “I did a scene for him, and he said, ‘I don’t know, dear. You either laugh or you cry. If you would laugh and cry at the same time, then we’d see something.’ ” She found herself doing just that in her breakout film, “The Last Picture Show.” This reminded her of what the poet Wisława Szymborska wrote about the soul: “Joy and sorrow / aren’t two different feelings for it.”

Burstyn starred in “Alice” in 1974, alongside Kris Kristofferson, who insisted that he couldn’t act or sing. “What is it you do?” she remembered asking him. “I am a poet,” he answered. In her book, she included a sampling of his lyrics. (“He’s a walkin’ contradiction, partly truth and partly fiction.”) Did any poems remind her of starring in “The Exorcist”? Not quite, she said, but the film does open with the Muslim call to prayer. In the seventies, inspired by an etching of a chanting muezzin in her copy of “The Rubáiyát of Omar Khayyám,” she began travelling the Middle East. In Iran, she visited the Tomb of Hafez. “People come reading Hafez’s poetry,” she said, recalling a path lined with roses “about at nose height, so as you’re walking you’re sniffing a different rose each step.”

In 1995, she was in “How to Make an American Quilt”; her co-star Maya Angelou would recite poems for her. “The makeup department threw up their hands, because I had to be completely re-made up after lunch every day from crying in Maya’s trailer,” Burstyn recalled. “So then I snuck in and brought Q-tips.” She leaned back in her chair and mimed holding the cotton tips to her eyes. “I would lay down in her trailer with Q-tips and go, ‘O.K., hit me!’ ” ♦

Michael Schulman, a staff writer, has contributed to The New Yorker since 2006. He is the author of “Oscar Wars: A History of Hollywood in Gold, Sweat, and Tears” and “Her Again: Becoming Meryl Streep.”

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Reporting & Essays

- **Can the E.P.A. Survive Lee Zeldin?**
  By Elizabeth Kolbert | The agency, which was founded to protect the environment and human health, has cancelled safety regulations, supported coal, and stopped caring about climate change.
- **What Happens When Someone Throws a Message in a Bottle Into the Sea?**
  By Lauren Collins | Most simply disappear. One enthusiast is on a quest to find the notes—and the people behind them.
- **Donald Trump's Pardon Economy**
  By Ruth Marcus | For some wealthy offenders, clemency is just a golf game—or a million-dollar plate at Mar-a-Lago—away.
- **Laurie Metcalf's Third Act**
  By Michael Schulman | The once cancelled producer Scott Rudin has staked his own comeback on making her the First Lady of American Theatre.

The Political Scene

Can the E.P.A. Survive Lee Zeldin?

The agency, which was founded to protect the environment and human health, has cancelled safety regulations, supported coal, and stopped caring about climate change.

By Elizabeth Kolbert

April 27, 2026

A predecessor described Zeldin's style as "move fast and break things."Photo illustration by Adam Maida; Source photographs by Anna Moneymaker / Getty; Getty

Last summer, more than a hundred and fifty staff members at the Environmental Protection Agency sent a letter to the agency's head, Lee Zeldin, outlining their concerns about his leadership. Topping the list was Zeldin's naked partisanship. The administrator often used his official communications to trash Democrats. This "politicized messaging," the letter said, was undermining trust in the agency. So, too, were Zeldin's gutting of the E.P.A.'s research division and his tendency to ignore the findings of its scientists. The missive noted that it reflected the staffers' personal, rather

than professional, opinions, and had been written on their own time. It ended by urging Zeldin to “correct course.”

“Should you choose to do so, we stand ready to support your efforts,” it said.

The employees who signed the letter did not expect it to have much effect. “I thought, Here’s a letter the staff is going to present to the administrator,” one told me. “He’s going to take a look at it and put it in the wastepaper basket. And we will go on with our work.”

That’s not how things played out. Zeldin, or at least his deputies, launched the electronic equivalent of a manhunt. In e-mails that were eventually obtained by *E&E News*, a lawyer at the E.P.A.’s Office of General Counsel told colleagues that the letter to Zeldin raised no ethical concerns, because the signatories were “simply exercising their first amendment right to express their opinions.” Another lawyer in the general counsel’s office warned against any sort of retaliatory action, because “government employee speech is protected.” The agency nonetheless kept up the pressure. It soon announced that it was placing a hundred and forty-four of the signatories on administrative leave.

“We have a ZERO tolerance policy for agency bureaucrats unlawfully undermining, sabotaging, and undercutting the agenda of this administration,” Zeldin said in a statement justifying the move. “The will of the American public will not be ignored.”

President Donald Trump has referred to Zeldin as “one of the superstars” of his second Administration and, perhaps even more glowingly, as “our secret weapon.” In a little more than a year, Zeldin has transformed the E.P.A. from an agency devoted to protecting human health and the environment into one that, more or less openly, sides with polluters. He has packed the E.P.A.’s upper echelons with former industry lobbyists, scrubbed entire databases of information from its website, and dissolved whole departments. Under his leadership, the agency has ditched a long list of rules that industries had objected to, including regulations aimed at cutting Americans’ exposure to arsenic, a known carcinogen; mercury, a potent neurotoxin; and PM2.5, a form of very fine soot that has been shown to

cause asthma and lung disease. The E.P.A. has not only abandoned its own efforts to rein in greenhouse-gas emissions; it has stepped in to prevent states from taking action. It has come out officially, if astonishingly, as pro-coal.

In early April, when Trump fired his Attorney General, Pam Bondi, reportedly for failing to prosecute his political enemies with sufficient zeal, rumors began to circulate that the President wanted Zeldin to replace her. (Todd Blanche, who took over as acting Attorney General, can serve in that capacity for up to seven months.) Zeldin's track record at the E.P.A. makes him, by Trumpian standards, a logical pick.

"Zeldin has displayed acrobatic flexibility in bending environmental laws to suit the desires of the White House," Michael Gerrard, the faculty director of the Sabin Center for Climate Change Law at Columbia University, told me. "He does not only backflips but triple loops."

Christine Todd Whitman, a former New Jersey governor who ran the agency under George W. Bush, said that if Zeldin becomes Attorney General "he'll do exactly what Trump wants him to do. That's what he's done at the E.P.A., irrespective of the damage it's done."

Zeldin, who is forty-six, is the subject of two adulatory (if slim) biographies, both published in 2024, perhaps with the aid of A.I. One states that his father was a lawyer, the other that he was a doctor. In fact, Zeldin's father was a private investigator, and his mother taught fourth grade. Zeldin's parents divorced when he was young, and he spent his elementary-school years shuttling between their homes in Shirley, a working-class town on eastern Long Island. In high school, he joined the Youth and Government club, mostly, he would later joke, "to pick up girls."

Zeldin sped through college at *SUNY* Albany in three years and through law school, also in Albany, in two. Then he enlisted in the Army. At Fort Huachuca, in Arizona, he worked in military intelligence, and later, as a member of the Judge Advocate General's Corps, he briefly deployed to Iraq. He remembers Army life fondly. "I was a paratrooper, jumped out of airplanes, did all that stuff," he said on "New York *NOW*." "Four years of

very adventurous time.” (Reporters who have looked into the matter have concluded that Zeldin spent most of his active-duty career sitting at a desk.)

At the age of twenty-eight, Zeldin made his first run for office. By this point, in 2008, he was married, with twin baby girls, and had moved back to Shirley. He challenged a Democrat named Tim Bishop, who was serving his third term in Congress. Zeldin lost to Bishop by sixteen points, but two years later, buoyed by Tea Party support, he won a seat in the New York State Senate. In 2014, he ran again against Bishop and prevailed.

As a new congressman, Zeldin voted mostly along party lines—in favor of repealing Obamacare, for example, and against limiting the sale of assault weapons. His district, which stretched from Smithtown to Montauk, was lined with beaches and wetlands, and, on a local level, he presented as green.

“We worked a lot with him on Long Island Sound issues,” Adrienne Esposito, the executive director of Citizens Campaign for the Environment, which is based in Farmingdale, recalled. “We never had any access problem.” National environmental groups, though, generally gave him lousy grades. In 2015, Zeldin received a fourteen-per-cent rating from the League of Conservation Voters, and the following year he got an eight-per-cent rating.

“On the issue of the environment, there were two completely different Lee Zeldins,” Steve Israel, a former Democratic congressman who represented a district abutting Zeldin’s, told me. “There was the Lee Zeldin who reliably voted against the environment as both a New York state senator and as a member of Congress. And there was the Lee Zeldin who’d appear at press conferences in his district touting his leadership in protecting the Long Island Sound. He literally could have debated himself.”

As is often the case with junior House members, Zeldin struggled to accomplish much. He was the primary sponsor on four bills that got enacted; two were measures to rename Suffolk County post offices. Beyond Long Island, he rarely made news, except when he screwed up. In 2018, the *Times* reported that he had sent out a campaign mailer with the wrong deadline for absentee ballots.

Then, in the fall of 2019, House Democrats launched what would come to be known as Trump's first impeachment inquiry. (The inquiry was prompted by reports that Trump had tried to pressure the Ukrainian President, Volodymyr Zelensky, into investigating Joe Biden.) Zeldin threw himself into the fight. He spent long hours grilling witnesses at deposition hearings, plotted with Republican colleagues about how best to shield the President, and publicly denounced the proceedings as, among other things, "illegitimate," a "charade," a "fairy tale," a "parody," and an "abuse of power."

"I've sat through EVERY interview so far of this so called 'impeachment inquiry' & the President hasn't done anything to possibly impeach him for," he tweeted that October. "NOTHING." Among those who noticed was the President himself. Trump took to retweeting Zeldin's comments—on one frenzied Saturday morning, nine times in three minutes. Zeldin's appearances on Fox News began to tick up.

Cartoon by Roz Chast

On January 6, 2021, just a few hours after the storming of the Capitol, Zeldin spoke to Fox News' Laura Ingraham, along with another congressman, Darrell Issa, of California. Issa, a fierce Trump supporter, condemned the attack. "Today was a bad day for the President," he said. Zeldin reserved his criticism for Trump's critics. "This isn't just about the President of the United States," he told Ingraham. "This is about people on the left and their double standards." That evening, on the floor of the House, Zeldin repeated oft-disproved claims about election irregularities. He was one of a hundred and twenty-five Republicans who voted against certifying the results from both Arizona and Pennsylvania. Later in January, when the House voted to impeach Trump a second time, for inciting the violence at the Capitol, Zeldin once again took to the floor.

"Let's be honest about the double standards that exist inside of this chamber," he said. "And let's also be honest that this President did a lot to make America greater than ever."

In the spring of 2021, Zeldin announced that he was running for governor of New York. During the campaign, he disclosed that he'd been diagnosed with early-stage chronic myeloid leukemia the previous year and had achieved full remission. "My health is phenomenal, and I continue to operate at a hundred and ten per cent," he told reporters.

After easily winning the Republican primary, Zeldin faced the incumbent, Kathy Hochul, in the general election. (She had become governor after Andrew Cuomo resigned, in the summer of 2021.) Trump was deeply unpopular in the state—in 2020, he had lost it to Biden by more than twenty points—and Hochul made much of Zeldin's fealty to the former President. She ran an ad that opened with a clip of Trump praising Zeldin—"Lee fought for me very, very hard"—and ended with the tagline "Lee Zeldin: he's extreme and dangerous."

Zeldin, for his part, campaigned on crime, which had spiked during the pandemic. He crisscrossed the state, holding press conferences at the sites of break-ins and assaults. In Rochester, he pitched up at a gas station that had recently been robbed, and in the Bronx he spoke at a subway station where someone had been pushed onto the tracks. He pledged that, if elected, he would declare a "crime emergency," which he said would allow

him to suspend several state laws, including one that limits the use of solitary confinement in New York prisons. (“Someone get this man a copy of the state’s constitution please,” Zellnor Myrie, a Democratic state senator from Brooklyn, tweeted.) To the extent that Zeldin campaigned on the environment, he was against it. In 2014, New York had banned fracking for natural gas, out of concern over the impacts on the state’s air and water. Zeldin vowed to lift the ban. In an irony that was hard to miss, his campaign got caught up in a ballot-fraud scandal. Zeldin had sought to run on the Independence Party line in addition to the G.O.P. line, but the state’s Board of Elections found that his petitions to secure the Independence listing included more than ten thousand invalid signatures.

Democrats had anticipated an easy victory; in the campaign’s final weeks, though, the polls tightened. Apparently, Zeldin’s tough-on-crime message was resonating. “He knows how to stick to an issue,” one Democratic strategist told me recently. “And, quite frankly, the Governor struggled to answer him.”

“Lee is a very skilled politician,” the former New Jersey governor Chris Christie said. “When you think about how tough New York is for Republicans, to come as close as he did tells you a lot.” Hochul’s margin of victory—six points—ended up being the narrowest of any New York gubernatorial candidate in the past thirty years.

Out of office, Zeldin, in time-honored Washington fashion, founded a consulting firm. (Among its clients was the America First Policy Institute, which employed so many officials from the first Trump Administration that it was sometimes referred to as the “White House in waiting.”) He also took to writing opinion pieces. In an op-ed for *Newsday*, Zeldin blasted investment policies that took environmental considerations into account. “It wasn’t long ago that Wall Street and special interests thought they could force environmental, social, and governance, or ESG, policies into our workplace, retirements, and lives,” he wrote. Fortunately, “conservatives and other everyday people have fought back.” In another op-ed, which appeared on the website *RealClearPolicy*, Zeldin compared E.S.G. investing to the shady maneuvers used by the cryptocurrency entrepreneur Sam Bankman-Fried. Eventually, Zeldin revealed in a financial-disclosure

form that he'd been paid by P.R. firms for both of the opinion pieces—in the case of the *RealClearPolicy* op-ed, he received twenty-five thousand dollars—though which of the firms' clients had commissioned them he never divulged.

When Trump appointed Zeldin to run the E.P.A., some at the agency hoped—or, perhaps, hoped against hope—that he would prove a moderating influence on the President. "We felt like, He's from New York, this is probably not his last gig, maybe he doesn't want to set himself up to be scorched earth," one scientist who was working at the agency at the time told me. It didn't take long for Zeldin to disabuse them of this notion.

Within a week of his confirmation, Zeldin announced that the agency would be guided by a new set of priorities—five in all—which he labelled "pillars." Pillar No. 2 was restoring "American energy dominance." No. 4 was making the United States "the artificial intelligence capital of the world." No. 5 was "protecting and bringing back American auto jobs." Zeldin termed the initiative Powering the Great American Comeback. The E.P.A. began publishing "Call It a Comeback," a newsletter featuring shots of Zeldin paying friendly calls on big emitters—a coal-fired power plant in West Virginia, a plastics-recycling facility in Texas—and clips of interviews with him on Fox News. When the right-wing activist Charlie Kirk was killed, on September 10, 2025, that week's newsletter was entirely given over to mourning his death. "In Loving Memory," it said, over a photo of Kirk raising his fist.

Though it may be difficult these days to imagine such a moment, the E.P.A. was established at a time when protecting the environment enjoyed broad, bipartisan support. On April 22, 1970, after a string of high-profile ecological disasters, including an oil spill off Santa Barbara that fouled Southern California beaches and a fire on Ohio's highly polluted Cuyahoga River, some twenty million Americans—almost ten per cent of the country's population—turned out to participate in what organizers had dubbed Earth Day. A few months later, President Richard Nixon proposed creating a new federal department devoted to the environment. Senator Ed Muskie, a Maine Democrat who was preparing to run against Nixon, enthusiastically supported the idea, and the E.P.A. was born. On the very

last day of 1970, Nixon signed the Clean Air Act, which had been approved unanimously in the U.S. Senate and by a vote of 374–1 in the House.

To run the infant E.P.A., Nixon chose an Assistant Attorney General named William Ruckelshaus. Ruckelshaus—Ruck to his friends—was the sort of moderate Republican once common in Washington. He rushed to come up with an organizational plan for the agency and, at the same time, to establish its authority—a task he compared to “trying to run a hundred-yard dash while undergoing an appendectomy.” Just a few weeks after Ruckelshaus became its leader, the E.P.A. initiated a string of headline-grabbing enforcement actions, including one against a steel company that was spewing cyanide into the Houston Ship Channel and several against major cities—Atlanta, Cleveland, Detroit—that were dumping raw sewage into their own waterways.

“It will be our job in the Environmental Protection Agency to be an advocate for the environment wherever decisions about our common future are made, whether it be in the councils of government, in the boardrooms of industry, or the living rooms of our citizens,” Ruckelshaus said.

In the decades that followed, even as control of the White House flipped between parties, most E.P.A. administrators continued to see their role as advocating for the environment. An exception was Anne Gorsuch, the mother of the Supreme Court Justice Neil Gorsuch. Appointed by President Ronald Reagan in 1981, Gorsuch cut the agency’s budget, reduced the number of enforcement actions, and inspired loathing at E.P.A. headquarters, where she was called the Ice Queen. In her second year on the job, allegations surfaced that, in an attempt to influence a California gubernatorial election, she had withheld funds from a toxic-waste cleanup near Los Angeles. Gorsuch refused a House committee’s requests to hand over documents related to the claims, thereby becoming the first Cabinet-level official in U.S. history to be charged with contempt of Congress. When she resigned, in 1983, Reagan was so concerned about the damage she had done to the E.P.A.’s reputation—and, by extension, his own—that he brought Ruckelshaus back to rebuild the agency. (After his first stint at the E.P.A., Ruckelshaus had become known as Mr. Clean, for refusing to do Nixon’s bidding during Watergate.) At Ruckelshaus’s swearing-in

ceremony, Reagan praised the once and future administrator for his integrity and said, “You have my total support in your difficult job of enforcing and administering our nation’s environmental-protection laws.”

In Trump’s first term, the E.P.A. took another hit, in the form of Scott Pruitt. Pruitt had served as Oklahoma’s attorney general and, in that capacity, had sued the agency many times, in one instance for ordering Oklahoma utilities to cut their sulfur-dioxide emissions. Nominating him to run the E.P.A. was, the Sierra Club complained, like “putting an arsonist in charge of fighting fires.” During his tenure as administrator, Pruitt tried to rescind a host of Obama-era regulations, including a proposed ban on chlorpyrifos, a pesticide linked to neurological problems in children. But his effectiveness was limited, in part by the courts and in part by his own behavior. By the time he was forced to resign, in 2018, Pruitt was being investigated for, among many other things, using taxpayer money to fly first class to Morocco, living in the home of lobbyists whose clients had business before his agency, and spending more than forty thousand dollars on a soundproof phone booth for his office.

Trump tapped Zeldin to run the E.P.A. on November 11, 2024, less than a week after his reëlection. At Zeldin’s confirmation hearing, two months later, Senator Sheldon Whitehouse, a Rhode Island Democrat, pressed him to clarify his views on climate change.

“As a matter of law, is carbon dioxide a pollutant?” Whitehouse asked.

“As far as carbon dioxide emitted from you during that question, I would say no,” Zeldin responded, smirking slightly.

Whitehouse tried again: “Briefly and in layman’s terms—I know you’re not a scientific expert—what effects are carbon-dioxide emissions from fossil-fuel combustion having in the atmosphere?”

“I am someone who believes strongly that we should work with the scientists, leaving the science to the scientists, the policy to the policymakers,” Zeldin said.

Whitehouse put the question to him yet again: “Just generally and in layman’s terms, what effects do these carbon-dioxide emissions have when they enter the atmosphere?”

“Trapping heat, Senator,” Zeldin finally acknowledged.

Unlike Trump, who has referred to global warming as a “hoax” and a “con job,” Zeldin is not a climate-change denier. In his first term in Congress, he signed up for the Climate Solutions Caucus—a group that, at the time, consisted of ten Democratic and ten Republican lawmakers. (“I am proud to join,” Zeldin said when he became a member.) In his third term, he voted against a Republican-led effort to block the E.P.A. from curbing carbon emissions. And at his confirmation hearing, after Whitehouse held up a map illustrating the effects of warming-induced sea-level rise on the Rhode Island coast, Zeldin said that he could commiserate.

“I represented the district on the East End of Long Island, and rising sea levels are concerns where I’m from as well,” he noted. He offered the example of the Montauk Lighthouse: the U.S. Army Corps of Engineers recently spent thirty million dollars to prevent it from “collapsing into the ocean.”

But whatever concerns about climate change Zeldin might have once harbored, he has, post-confirmation, set them aside. As E.P.A. administrator, he has called worries about global warming a “religion” and efforts to combat it a “scam.”

“When he was in Congress, Zeldin knew he had hundreds of thousands of constituents who cared about the environment,” Steve Israel, the former congressman, observed. “But now he has only one constituent, and his name is Donald Trump.”

During the Biden Administration, the E.P.A. took a number of important steps to rein in carbon emissions. It imposed new regulations on power plants, set tailpipe standards aimed at accelerating the shift to electric cars, and attempted to cut methane releases from oil and gas operations. Zeldin has cancelled, or has announced plans to cancel, all of these.

Most significantly, Zeldin has rejected the very premise of the E.P.A.'s efforts to limit global warming—the so-called endangerment finding. In 2007, a Supreme Court case compelled the agency to determine whether climate change represented a danger to the public, and, if so, to take action to reduce that danger. In 2009, under President Barack Obama, the E.P.A. administrator Lisa Jackson signed the finding, which said that greenhouse gases threatened the "welfare of current and future generations." All her successors, including Pruitt, accepted the matter as settled. Until Zeldin.

"There are people who, in the name of climate change, are willing to bankrupt the country," Zeldin said on "Ruthless," a bro-y conservative podcast, on the day the E.P.A. released a draft version of a plan to revoke the endangerment finding. Initially, the agency tried to justify its position on scientific grounds: climate change wasn't really all that dangerous. Later, when this counterfactual position proved untenable, it fell back on a hermeneutical argument: the endangerment finding was based on a misinterpretation of the Clean Air Act.

"Today, we dismantle the tactics and legal gymnastics used by the Obama and Biden Administrations," Zeldin declared in February, when the final version of the repeal was released. At a press conference with Trump at the White House, he said that revoking the finding would save Americans $1.3 trillion, mostly in the form of lower car prices. He neglected to mention the costs of the move, which, by the E.P.A.'s own estimates, could top $1.4 trillion, and this is not even counting the expenses associated with greater warming. Twenty-four states, along with a broad coalition of environmental and public-health organizations, quickly sued to block the repeal, and this case, too, appears bound for the Supreme Court. Zeldin's bet, it seems, is that the composition of the Court has changed enough that a majority of the Justices—three of whom are Trump appointees—will be willing to overturn the 2007 decision. If the Court reverses the ruling, no future E.P.A. will be able to regulate CO_2 emissions without an act of Congress.

"This is one of those things where you shake your head and say, 'How low can you go?' " Christine Todd Whitman told me. "I mean, how much damage do you really want to do?"

“On the endangerment finding, you can see that their legal rationale is absolutely ludicrous,” Gina McCarthy, who led the E.P.A. during Obama’s second term, said. “But that doesn’t mean that it won’t go all the way to the Supreme Court, and it doesn’t mean that this Supreme Court might not uphold it.”

Whitehouse told me, “Zeldin has been the most ardent stooge of the fossil-fuel industry that there is. The E.P.A. can now say, ‘We took down the endangerment finding.’ And their willingness to do this, despite so much evidence to the contrary, despite all of the difficulties they are going to face defending this—it’s almost like an act of tribute.”

Environmental regulations are full of technical terms that get compressed into acronyms. “Maximum achievable control technology,” for instance, becomes *MACT*; “mercury and air toxics standards” goes by *MATS*. A hazardous air pollutant is a *HAP* and, as such, is regulated by “national emissions standards,” which are called, for short, *NESHAP*s (pronounced nee-shaps).

Ethylene oxide is a *HAP* that is widely used to sterilize medical equipment. The compound is extremely reactive, which makes it useful for killing microbes and also makes it dangerous to humans. A decade ago, the E.P.A. discovered that the hazards posed by ethylene oxide were at least thirty times greater than it had previously estimated. People who regularly breathed in even tiny amounts had an elevated risk of, among other diseases, breast cancer, lymphoma, and leukemia. In 2024, the agency published a new, more restrictive *NESHAP* for commercial sterilization plants that use the gas. This spring, just before the new standard was scheduled to take effect, Zeldin pulled the plug.

Many sterilization plants are situated near schools and day-care centers. One such plant, on the outskirts of Richmond, is run by a company called Sterilization Services of Virginia. Not long ago, a pair of attorneys from the Southern Environmental Law Center travelled to Richmond to meet with people who live close to the plant, and I decided to join them.

The meeting took place at a community center with a rich history. In 1777, a Quaker family freed its slaves and granted land for some of them to settle

on, including the spot where the center now stands. A part of the building serves as a miniature museum, tracing the history of the area, which became known as Gravel Hill. The main room holds chairs for fifty people; by the time the session started, they were full.

One of the attorneys, Irena Como, began by presenting a slide of the nearby plant, in the district of Varina. It showed a long, low-slung brick building fronted by truck bays. “A lot of these commercial sterilizers are sited in residential areas,” Como said. “They look like warehouses. They’re very nondescript. And a lot of them are in predominantly Black and brown communities.” It’s estimated that, of the roughly hundred thousand people who live within five miles of the Sterilization Services of Virginia facility, only about a quarter are white.

“Why do I always have to pick between work and family? Why can’t I avoid both?”
Cartoon by Benjamin Schwartz

The E.P.A., Como went on, had been moving to reduce the risks for communities like Varina. But then it changed course. Last spring, Trump invited companies that couldn’t—or didn’t care to—meet the latest *NESHAP* to apply for exemptions. All they had to do was send an e-mail to the agency. (The Administration described the waivers as necessary for “national security interests.”) Some forty commercial sterilizers received exemptions, including the Sterilization Services plant. Next, the E.P.A. replaced the 2024 regulations with a less stringent set. It justified this action by saying that it had been wrong to reëvaluate the risks of ethylene oxide in the first place, because it lacked the authority to do so. Coincidentally or not, the sterilizer industry’s trade group had made this same argument in a 2024 legal filing.

When it came time for questions, a woman in the audience asked why the E.P.A. would want to reduce protections for a neighborhood like hers. “What is the real reason?” she pressed.

“That is a great question,” Como said.

The fact that polluting facilities are disproportionately located in communities of color is an inequity that the E.P.A. has recognized for decades. In 1990, under President George H. W. Bush, Administrator William K. Reilly created an environmental-justice working group, which led to the formation of a new division at the agency. In 2010, the E.P.A. developed a mapping tool, called EJScreen, that combined information on demographics and pollution levels on a census-tract level. In 2022, the agency expanded its environmental-justice division and granted it the same status as larger offices, like the divisions of air and water. Just days after Zeldin was confirmed, the agency removed the EJScreen from its website and placed more than a hundred and fifty staff members from the environmental-justice office on administrative leave. A few weeks later, Zeldin did away with the office entirely. He also cancelled hundreds of millions of dollars in grants from an environmental-justice fund which had already been awarded to community groups and local governments. Democratic members of the Senate Committee on Environment and Public Works accused him of violating federal appropriations law by terminating the grants.

“President Trump was elected with a mandate from the American people,” Zeldin said in a statement. “Part of this mandate includes the elimination of forced discrimination programs.”

Zeldin followed up the environmental-justice purge with an even more breathtaking assault, this one on the Office of Research and Development, the division that had flagged the risks posed by ethylene oxide. The O.R.D., often referred to as the E.P.A.’s scientific arm, employed more than fifteen hundred people. It was responsible for providing the analyses that guided a wide range of E.P.A. actions, from setting air-quality standards to establishing targets for cleaning up Superfund sites. It also assisted state and tribal governments, which often lack the resources to conduct their own research and risk assessments. When, in the spring of 2025, word began to

leak out that Zeldin was planning to eliminate the O.R.D., Democratic lawmakers accused him of handing environmental regulation over to the regulated industries. “Stripping EPA of its independent research capacity would transform the agency into a rubber stamp for corporate interests,” Chellie Pingree, a Democratic congresswoman from Maine, and Jeff Merkley, a Democratic senator from Oregon, wrote in a joint letter.

That summer, in an official announcement of the closing, Zeldin said that he was replacing the O.R.D. with a new science department that would insure “the agency is better equipped than ever before.” Apparently unconvinced by this claim, the Senate subcommittee that oversees E.P.A appropriations, which is headed by Lisa Murkowski, a Republican from Alaska, said in a report that it was “appalled” by the plan to shutter the O.R.D. The move, the group warned, could result in “immeasurable risk to our health and environment.” Zeldin went ahead and eliminated the office anyway.

Zeldin rarely engages with his critics, be they lawmakers, E.P.A. employees, or his predecessors at the agency. There is, however, one exception: the so-called *MAHA* moms, a subset of the Make America Healthy Again movement. The group is made up of women who, in the last Presidential race, backed Robert F. Kennedy, Jr., before switching their allegiance to Trump. Some are fervent anti-vaxxers; others are more worried about their kids’ exposure to harmful chemicals. Many are independents, and they could play a critical role in the midterm elections.

Last year, Zeldin got on the wrong side of the *MAHA* moms by hiring several former lobbyists to oversee the E.P.A.’s division of chemical safety. (Two used to work for the American Chemistry Council, a chemical-industry trade group.) “President Trump and Bobby Kennedy said we were going to make America healthy again, and we are going to be ending the revolving door of special interests,” Alex Clark, a wellness podcaster associated with Turning Point USA, the organization founded by Charlie Kirk, told me. “In the E.P.A., you see this massive gap where the revolving door seems to still be shuffling people in.”

The moms were also ticked off by Zeldin’s approach to PFAS compounds, or, as they’re more commonly known, “forever chemicals.” Last fall, after

the E.P.A. approved the use of several pesticides containing PFAS-adjacent compounds, a prominent *MAHA* mom named Kelly Ryerson drafted a petition calling for Zeldin's ouster.

"Administrator Zeldin has prioritized the interests of chemical corporations over the well-being of American families and children," it said. The petition urged Trump to replace Zeldin with "a leader who will genuinely defend public health and truly put America First." Posted online, it soon garnered thousands of signatures.

Zeldin responded with a charm offensive. Shortly before Christmas, he invited several *MAHA* moms to meet with him at the E.P.A.'s headquarters. Ryerson, who blogs about glyphosate, a widely used and potentially carcinogenic herbicide, was among the attendees. "Zeldin brought most of the senior members of the E.P.A. to this meeting, so it was eight to ten of them, all sitting there, just wanting to listen," she told me. "And that has never happened in all the years that I've been doing this. So I was, like, This is really something." (In an e-mail, Mike Bastasch, an agency spokesman, said, "Any claim that EPA's relationship with the *MAHA* grassroots is 'damaged' is flatly false.")

Following the meeting with the moms, the E.P.A. announced that it was beefing up regulations on phthalates, chemicals that are used in countless consumer products and are suspected endocrine disrupters. Zeldin, on X, portrayed the move as a "massive *MAHA* win." The next week, he said that the agency would reassess paraquat, an herbicide that's been linked to Parkinson's disease. "More *MAHA* progress!" he declared. In the case of phthalates, the E.P.A.'s move had nothing to do with children's exposure to the chemical—the new regulations will apply only to workers—and, in the case of paraquat, it wasn't a move at all: the decision to reassess the pesticide had, it turned out, been made fours years earlier, during the Biden Administration. Nathan Donley, the director of environmental-health science at the Center for Biological Diversity, coined a term to describe Zeldin's tactic for dealing with the moms: *MAHA*-washing.

"Much like the greenwashing you see at the grocery store, with terms like 'eco-friendly' or 'green' advertising chemical-laden products on store shelves, Zeldin's *MAHA*-washing paints the same rosy picture to distract

from decisions that harm public health," Donley wrote in an online post. In February, an E.P.A. spokeswoman said that the agency was "in the final stages of completing" a new *MAHA*-friendly agenda. But, if that agenda is indeed in its "final stages," it has yet to be released.

Practically every action that the E.P.A. has taken since last January has been challenged in court or soon will be. In this way, Zeldin's rule-bending style could prove self-defeating.

"To go back and unwind the scientific arguments that were made during the previous Administration, that's tough," Michael S. Regan, who served as the E.P.A. administrator under Biden, observed. "For many of these rollbacks, you have to have a replacement rule. And, when you put forth the replacement rule, not only is the rollback going to be litigated, the replacement will be litigated as well. So this gives me hope that a lot of these rollbacks will not stand." A Brookings Institution analysis of the E.P.A.'s major deregulatory efforts during Trump's first term found that a sixth of them were blocked by the courts, another sixth were blocked in part, and the remainder were still wending their way through the legal system when Regan took over the agency.

Meanwhile, a future E.P.A. administrator—one who cared more about the future—could seek to reverse many of Zeldin's decisions. She could, for example, reimpose the standards that he scrapped for mercury, arsenic, and ethylene oxide.

But much of the damage that Zeldin has done is, as one former E.P.A. official put it to me, "generational." Since Zeldin took over, the agency's staff has been cut by twenty-five per cent. A disproportionate number of those who left (or were forced out) were longtime employees and team leaders. Seven hundred held doctoral degrees. The institutional knowledge that these experts took with them isn't coming back.

"They had a very shrewd strategy," William K. Reilly, the former E.P.A. administrator, told me. "It was a little like Zuckerberg: move fast and break things. It will take a while for the courts to catch up. And, by the time they do, the scientists, the lawyers, the engineers—they will have gone somewhere else. They will no longer be recoverable."

And much the same goes for the additional pollutants that get spewed into the air and water. According to a report by the Environmental Defense Fund, the E.P.A.'s many recent rollbacks—in concert with the repeal of key clean-energy tax credits—will send some 1.5 billion extra tons of carbon dioxide into the atmosphere by 2030 and some twelve billion extra tons by 2040. This extra CO_2 will still be contributing to hotter temperatures and higher sea levels centuries from now. Forever chemicals will last, if not actually forever, certainly for the foreseeable future. It is impossible at this point to say how many premature deaths Zeldin's deregulatory campaign will lead to, but the numbers could easily run to the tens of thousands.

Trump's Cabinet has been described as a "telegenic clown show," and the antics of its members, not to mention those of the President himself, have proved endlessly, if unedifyingly, absorbing. In this company, Zeldin has stood out mostly for not standing out; he doesn't work out shirtless with Kid Rock, or send federal agents to accompany his girlfriend to the hair salon, or pass around top-secret information on Signal. He isn't even particularly telegenic. But, as the Administration's "secret weapon," he has been strikingly successful in furthering Trump's wind-is-dangerous, coal-is-beautiful world view, with effects that will linger long after a new administrator takes over and the E.P.A. returns—or doesn't return—to its original mission. ♦

Elizabeth Kolbert, a staff writer at The New Yorker since 1999, won the 2015 Pulitzer Prize for general nonfiction. Her books include "Life on a Little-Known Planet" (2025).

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Our Far-Flung Correspondents

Signed, Sealed, Delivered

What happens when someone throws a message into the sea?

***By** Lauren Collins*

April 27, 2026

Some six million messages in bottles have been sent since the mid-nineteen-hundreds.Illustration by Joana Avillez

Reiko Hiroyama lives on Ishigaki, a subtropical island in Japan. One morning, she went out to comb the beach near her house. Beachcombing conjures up a leisurely world of sand dollars and Daiquiris, but Hiroyama's practice was actually about bringing in the trash. Over the years, she'd retrieved flip-flops, jerricans, hairbrushes, toothbrushes, fishing nets, and a seemingly endless array of bottles—jugs, flasks, milk bottles, beer bottles, water bottles, detergent bottles, baby bottles, motor-oil bottles. Yet that day a turquoise glass bottle caught her eye. Its neck was sticking out of the sand. There was a scroll-like object inside. "The sunlight shining on it gave it a strong presence," Hiroyama recalled. "It seemed to say, 'I'm here!' "

The cap was so thoroughly rusted that she couldn't twist it off, so she decided to break the bottle open on a rock. "My heart was pounding," she said. She extracted the scroll: a sheet of white paper covered in cursive handwriting. Hiroyama's spirits sank when she realized that the letter was written in French. She put it in a desk drawer, hoping that, one day, someone would come along who could read it. Hiroyama told me recently,

“I felt a deep affection for the bottle that had drifted all the way to this island from a distant land.”

One day, she showed the letter to a German woman who had recently moved to Ishigaki. The woman noticed that the letter contained a man’s name, Jean-Paul Sundström, and an address on Île de Ré, an island off the west coast of France. A couple the woman knew had vacationed there a few years earlier, and she got in touch with the owner of their Airbnb, who volunteered to find Sundström. No one answered at the address, but a neighbor suggested leaving a note at a nearby hair salon. Contacted by his hairdresser, Sundström called the Airbnb owner, who called the tourists, who called the German woman living on Ishigaki, who walked over to Hiroyama’s place.

“The circle was complete,” *Ré à la Hune*, a newspaper based on Île de Ré, reported. “We can only be amazed and say that many things that we do not think are possible are indeed possible.” The article featured a photograph of a smiling Hiroyama, standing in front of a banana tree. She was holding Sundström’s letter, dated May 8, 2009:

> My name is Jean-Paul Sundström. I am a sailor aboard a merchant marine vessel traveling from Punta Arenas (Chile) to Yeosu, South Korea.
>
> Let us all try, together, to build a better future and a better world—without war, without poverty—where each of us opens our heart to others. . . . The miracles of life are more frequent than we think—this is the key that opens the door to hope.

Six and a half thousand miles away, in rural Utah, two nearly identical letters, dated 2011 and 2012, hang in frames on a wall of Clint Buffington’s home office. The first was sent on a voyage from Venezuela to Gibraltar; the second, between Rotterdam and Montreal. It turns out that Sundström was something of a maritime spammer. Between 1995, when he began working as a cabin boy, and 2020, when he retired as a master pumpman, he sent more than two thousand bottles into the ocean. He always included some money or cigarettes, and, per maritime tradition, he chucked one into the water for good luck each time he passed through a strait. Buffington told

me that both Sundström bottles were “in excellent condition” and “sealed with some kind of rock-hard caulk or glue-like substance.” He found them in 2015, somewhere “in the southern region of the Lucayan Archipelago,” which encompasses the Bahamas and Turks and Caicos—he won’t say more.

Clint Buffington is one of the world’s most prolific hunters of messages in bottles. Since 2007, he has recovered nearly a hundred and fifty specimens, ranging from love letters to promotional stunts, science projects, pleas for help, and drunken ramblings.Photograph by Michael Friberg for The New Yorker

Buffington is one of the world’s most prolific hunters of messages in bottles. Since 2007, when he found his first M.I.B., as they’re known, he has recovered nearly a hundred and fifty specimens, ranging from love letters to promotional stunts, science projects, pleas for help, and drunken ramblings. “I have been taken prisoner by a grumpy old man,” read one letter, written by a son who apparently wasn’t having a great time vacationing with his father. Another author confessed, “As we have no more wine on board for the apéritif, we try to pass the time as we can.” (This writer, too, was French.) A man named Frank immortalized his holiday with a woman named Brenda on a sheet of paper from a Princess Cruises

notepad: “It’s been interesting, it’s the end of a 8 year relationship. We are both putting messages in a bottle. . . . Brenda, hope you find what you are looking for. Love, Frank.”

Buffington’s home office recalls a museum exhibition on Mesopotamian material culture crossed with a frat house the morning after a blowout party. There are empty bottles everywhere—crammed onto shelves, catching the light on a windowsill. A bar cart overflows with bottles that Buffington has yet to open, or “solve,” as he likes to say. “I would describe this place as a chaotic nightmare,” Buffington told me cheerfully. He keeps the tools of his trade in a garage workshop that he calls the Lab: a spray bottle (for hydrating flaking paper), a U.V. black light (for reading faded lettering), Channellock pliers (for wrenching off aluminum caps), a rotary tool with a diamond drill bit (for slicing into recalcitrant ones), laparoscopic needle drivers (for removing messages without the risk of shattering or breakage). Buffington’s wife, a surgeon, suggested the last tool after watching him struggle with bamboo skewers and bits of tape. A lone aluminum can among the bottles contained the dregs of a Bell’s Two Hearted I.P.A.

Buffington’s exploits are particularly impressive given that he’s the default parent of two young kids and lives in a landlocked state. He is forty-one and has a master’s degree in English literature; for some years, he did technical writing for a nuclear-waste-removal company. As his LinkedIn profile notes, he is also a musician, playing “guitar, harmonica, and mandolin across genres.” Basically, he’s an earnest and chipper guy, given to recording himself yearningly singing Paul Simon’s “Slip Slidin’ Away,” and to crunching on apples while saying things like “Cool beans!” He is quick to make a friend, and maintains relationships with dozens of people whose bottles he’s retrieved. He once found a bottle with a note and an eight-year-old piece of wedding cake inside and traced it back to Ed and Carol Meyers, a Virginia couple who were celebrating their first anniversary. Buffington himself got married several years later and wrote on Instagram, “So, naturally, Ed & Carol came to our wedding & it felt like a blessing.”

“A lot of people think of messages in bottles as being sort of flippant or silly or whatever,” he told me. “My experience has shown me quite the

opposite. I don’t know exactly what the impulse is, but it’s deep, it’s fundamental, and it’s foundational. I think it’s core to being human.”

“They call horse racing the sport of kings, but that’s because no one has seen us play air hockey.” Cartoon by Joe Dator

The oceanographer Curtis Ebbesmeyer has estimated that six million M.I.B.s have been tossed into the ocean since the mid-twentieth century. Hunting for them combines the suspense of metal detecting with the thrill of opening a present. Even if you’re lucky enough to find something, the question remains: Will it be any good? Or will you tear open the long-awaited parcel only to discover that it’s filled with pornography or cigarette butts? A pen pal writes to someone. The sender of a message in a bottle writes to anyone. The wish, sometimes granted, is that the trajectory of the note is as ineluctable as the tides that carry it; that, sucked into currents and pounded by the surf and tossed onto rocks and scorched by the sun, the message ends up exactly where it ought to be.

I first contacted Buffington in 2016. I’d been intrigued by his blog: “A message in a bottle can make friends out of strangers, lovers out of the lonely, or give the dead a final chance to speak.” I hoped to join him on one of his expeditions, but he was on an involuntary hiatus, owing first to the Zika outbreak, then to the *COVID* pandemic.

Eight years later, an e-mail from Buffington popped up in my inbox. “Hi Lauren, It’s been a minute!” he wrote, explaining that he was ready to begin far-flung bottle-searching missions again. Months passed as he pored over tide charts, satellite maps, and airline schedules, trying to determine the perfect location for our hunt. Finally, he settled on one: “I really think Mayaguana is where the magic is going to happen :)”

Mayaguana, the easternmost island of the Bahamas, is a hatchet-shaped spit of land about a hundred nautical miles north of the Windward Passage, the channel separating Cuba from Haiti. The island's name comes from the Lucayans, its original inhabitants. In the early sixteenth century, Spanish colonization wiped out the local population; the land was sparsely populated until the early eighteen-hundreds, when settlers arrived from Turks and Caicos. In 1890, the future British statesman Neville Chamberlain visited the island with his brother to see if it would make a good sisal plantation. The latter was "in ecstasies over the flamingoes," but the Chamberlains ultimately abandoned the project.

Mayaguana remains one of the least developed and most difficult to access Bahamian islands. Around two hundred people live there. The island is home to frigate birds, gnatcatchers, bananaquits, boobies, and a rare rodent called the hutia, which looks like a rat and comes out at night to feed. It has no hospital, grocery store, or A.T.M. Every ten days, a boat comes to deliver mail and to stock the island's mini-marts. From Nassau, the capital, you can fly to Mayaguana on Monday or Friday. If you want to leave, you have to be at the airport when the plane comes in. Otherwise, you wait.

Buffington warned that Mayaguana would be no Margaritaville. "We are not talking about a 'stroll' here," he wrote. "A typical day of hunting involves hiking maybe 8-15 miles on a beach: soft sand sucking energy from every footstep; relentless sun hammering you on exposed, shadeless shores." He recommended that I come equipped with trekking poles, fingerless sun gloves, a multipurpose tool that included "pliers and a knife at minimum," and "one 3-liter water reservoir with hose." He also suggested packing provisions, including canned chicken, for "suitcase burritos," and powdered Pedialyte.

There was one last thing Buffington wanted me to know: I shouldn't mention what we were doing there. "It's a paranoia born of finding footprints on desolate beaches that I have busted ass to reach (always a vibe-killer!), and so I take every wacko precaution to avoid tipping off anyone," he explained. "Lest it inspire someone to get there before me."

Unlike many trends, the fad for putting messages in bottles can be traced to a specific source. Sure, the Vikings, invading Iceland, hurled objects

overboard and followed the currents toward resources like whales and driftwood. Yes, a twelfth-century Japanese epic tells of a banished poet who wrote a thousand verses on slabs of wood, called stupas, and threw them into the sea, hoping that they would reach his parents. But the modern era of M.I.B.s began in 1833, when the Baltimore *Saturday Visiter* published "MS. Found in a Bottle," a short story by a fledgling writer named Edgar Allan Poe. The work's narrator is travelling from the port of Batavia to the Sunda Islands on a ship filled with ghee, opium, and jaggery. As a "whirlpool of mountainous and foaming ocean" threatens to swallow the ship whole, the narrator attempts to tell the tale of his fateful voyage by sending a manuscript into the ocean. "At the last moment I will enclose the MS. in a bottle and cast it within the sea," he vows.

As Curtis Ebbesmeyer and Eric Scigliano write, in "Flotsametrics and the Floating World," the story helped launch a craze for messages in bottles, speaking "powerfully to an age obsessed with long-distance communication, from clipper ships and the telegraph to the soon-to-emerge penny post." In 1860, Charles Dickens published his own M.I.B. fiction, "A Message from the Sea," about an American captain's discovery of an oilskin-covered, glass-stoppered "strong square case-bottle" and his attempts to fulfill the charge of the message inside: "Whoever finds this, is solemnly entreated by the dead to convey it unread to Alfred Raybrock." By the late eighteen-eighties, M.I.B.s had gained popularity with naval researchers and amateur oceanographers, including Prince Albert I of Monaco, who launched 1,675 bottles into the North Atlantic.

Buffington came to flotsam via fungi. He grew up outside Carbondale, Illinois, as the youngest of three children. The Buffingtons were the kind of tight-knit family that is fond of games, larks, and long-running japes. On weekends, they would go rooting around in the forest, searching for natural bounty—wildflowers, arrowheads, fossils, icicles to launch from the tops of cliffs. "We were always looking for mushrooms," Buffington recalled. "And not just any mushrooms. The only ones we went after were morels, which are notoriously elusive."

Every day was a treasure hunt, and the hunt was often more gratifying than the treasure. "Just because you go out in the woods doesn't mean you're

going to find something, right?” Buffington said. “But there was always this element of anything could happen.”

The champagne bottle Buffington found on the island of Mayaguana had a perfect little cigarette of a scroll inside, secured with a Band-Aid.Photograph by Michael Friberg for The New Yorker

When Buffington was around ten, his family started vacationing in the Caribbean. On one trip, his parents stumbled across a dark-brown embossed bottle filled with several long, thin objects. “They thought they were sticks or something,” Buffington recalled. The bottle, in fact, contained three documents: a certificate from the “Office of King Neptune,” a Guinness label, and a set of instructions for making the bottle into a lamp. The bottle was one of a hundred and fifty thousand that the brewing company had dropped into the Atlantic to celebrate its two-hundredth birthday, in 1959. The bottles are still being found as far away as Tahiti, Mexico, and the Canadian Arctic, where Inuit locals reportedly refer to one particularly fertile stretch of land as Beer Bottle Beach.

Buffington found his first M.I.B. on a rainy day in Turks and Caicos. “I was carrying a piece of Styrofoam on my back to shield me, like a turtle,” he recalled. The beach was full of empty bottles, but suddenly Buffington snapped to attention, without quite knowing why. “I get about ten feet away and feel this little electric charge—almost like a snakebite,” he said. There it was: a cobalt-colored glass bottle with a rubber cork stopper, lying on top of the sand, as though the tide had deposited it there just for him. The message inside, printed on bright-orange paper and tied with a piece of string, was written by Larry and Ruth, Canadians travelling to St. Maarten

aboard a ship. “If you get this message, we would greatly appreciate a reply,” they wrote, thoughtfully enclosing two dollars for postage.

“There was no going back,” Buffington told me. “I knew if I could do it once, I could do it again.”

The Monday flight to Mayaguana arrives in the insistent light of early afternoon. Earnel (Shorty) Brown, the proprietor of the Baycaner Beach Resort, one of the island’s few guest houses, met Buffington and me at the airport. Brown grew up on Mayaguana, where his father was a fisherman. He and Buffington had already started discussing which otherwise inaccessible beaches he might take us to by boat. “We have to see what the wind does,” Brown said.

The Baycaner turned out to be gleaming and empty. In the wood-panelled bar, a vinyl banner attested to rowdier times: “Reality is an illness that occurs due to: insufficient alcohol, saltwater, and fly fishing.” It had been a long journey, but Buffington wanted to get in some bottle-hunting before the sun set.

I piled on my goofy gear—cop sunglasses, basset-hound earflap hat—and met Buffington on the beach. The sand stretched as far as we could see in either direction, overlaid by lanes of sargassum. The algae stunk, but Buffington was pleased: “To me, that’s a good sign, because it tells me that this drifted in from somewhere out there, and, along with it, all this other stuff.” He bent down to pick up a pink plastic bottle from the debris, aiming it down the beach. “The technique is mileage,” he said. “It all comes down to mileage.”

Buffington assigned me to trawl the wrack line. It was teeming with non-organic matter, including a red plastic piggy bank. I could see dozens of bottles, many of them opaque, wedged into the sand, or otherwise partially obscured. I picked up a rubber boot.

“This is one of the iconic beach finds,” Buffington said. “Let’s see if there’s a foot in there!”

We continued, scanning the beach with darting eyes, the way they teach you to monitor the road in a defensive-driving course. There were more red plastic piggy banks—Buffington deduced that there must have been a cargo spill. “I always tell people the ocean writes a story on the beach,” he said. “My job is to read it.” At one point, I spotted a clear plastic vessel with a gold-colored cap, and my pulse quickened: was that a piece of paper? Indeed it was, but further inspection revealed that it was only the label of a Turkish fabric softener.

By the time we finished, the sky had turned to orangeade. I’d found three bottles tied together with a light-blue ribbon, a mesh bag full of bottles, a handbag, a conch shell, and many single shoes. Buffington had found three glass fishing buoys, including an unusual one the color of an amethyst. Despite the dearth of messages in bottles, Buffington was feeling optimistic.

“Those floats are harbingers of M.I.B.s,” he said. “Anywhere you find one, you find the other.”

Collectors hone their interests according to some combination of location and whimsy. A sheller on Sanibel Island amasses Scotch bonnets, while a London mudlark scoops up shards of ancient pottery. A beachcomber was traditionally a deserter or a wayfarer: “a vagrant seaman, usually of low character, who loiters about seaports,” per the 1913 edition of Webster’s Dictionary. Today, beachcombing is a hobby practiced by countless adults and children around the world. People collect shells, coral, sea glass, driftwood, egg cases, fossils, agates, pumice. There is even a subset of beachcombers who scour for “sea beans”—seeds and fruits carried on ocean currents. Last year’s International Sea-Bean Symposium, held in Cocoa Beach, Florida, featured a sea-bean-identification event and a talk called “Sea-Bean Hoarding, When Is Enough Enough?”

M.I.B.s are distinguished by their air of romance and mystery. “The thing about messages in bottles is that there’s a *person* behind the reason this is in the water,” Kirsti Scott, the editor of *Beachcombing* magazine, told me. “There’s truly a purpose.” Buffington believes that the ocean inspires a certain spiritual expansiveness, unlike freshwater, whose M.I.B.s often contain jokes or pranks. “I guarantee you I could go find bottles on the Mississippi, but why would I?” he said. “On the river, you’re thinking

downstream thoughts. But on the wide open sea you're thinking wide-open-sea thoughts."

Cartoon by Paul Noth

The Poeian tradition of the M.I.B. in extremis persists—"We are torpedoed, one in front and one in back," an unlucky passenger wrote from the Lusitania, in 1915. More recently, crew members on an Italian container ship pushed an M.I.B. through a porthole, successfully alerting authorities that they had been hijacked by Somali pirates. Deathbed M.I.B.s have a particular allure as emanations of the soul at its most desperate, and thus, putatively, its most honest. But M.I.B.s are as various as their writers, conveying all manner of existential unburdening. One of the most moving messages Buffington has found acted as a sort of roving memorial to a lost pregnancy. "Will never forget you, my angel," it read. "Sorry we never got to meet. Love, Mommy."

In 1972, the seven-year-old Amor Towles chucked an M.I.B. into the water off Martha's Vineyard, writing that he hoped it made it to China. Within weeks, he got a reply from an editor at the New York *Times*. Towles, now a best-selling novelist, credits the encounter with instilling in him a sense that "the world is a place where anything can happen." This sensation must have been shared by the person who picked up a bottle one day and discovered inside an original Charles Schulz cartoon, sent by the artist on a whim from an Alaskan cruise.

The ultimate providential M.I.B. may be a note that a Swedish sailor named Åke Viking stuffed into an empty flask of aqua vitae and threw into the sea

in 1955. “To Someone Beautiful and Far Away,” he wrote. “Write to me, whoever you are.” He included a photograph of himself along with his home address. The bottle washed ashore in Syracuse, Sicily, where it was found by the father of Paolina Puzzo, a fifteen-year-old girl. Three years later, Viking and Puzzo got married. They were together for more than forty years.

At 7:01 *A.M.*, Buffington stood in the yard of the Baycaner, loading gear into a truck. He was wearing an outfit of rubber sandals, swim trunks, and a bubblegum-pink T-shirt with Barbie-style lettering: “*MY JOB IS BEACH*.” Brown, scrutinizing the weather, had determined that this was the day to visit a typically unreachable stretch of coastline. The plan was for him to ferry us there in a twenty-eight-foot powerboat and then pick us up six hours later, at the end of what would amount to—if all went well—an approximately ten-mile march.

Buffington was projecting Ken-like levels of enthusiasm, but anxiety was setting in. The trip so far had been a bust. The day before, nearly twenty thousand steps in unrelenting heat had yielded nothing of interest but an old Swedish Coke bottle and a fragment of a Space X heat shield. Meanwhile, another renowned bottle hunter, an elderly Dutchman named Wim Kruiswijk, has racked up some twelve hundred bottles foraging the shores near his home, in Zandvoort. “I have all the time in the world, and, instead of talking to other old people, I love to walk on the beach and see the surprises,” Kruiswijk once told a documentarian. He has observed that M.I.B.s are less plentiful than they once were, and that the decline coincided with the introduction of smartphones. The instant gratification of social media has largely destroyed both the culture of letter-writing and the patience required to wait for a message to be found.

Buffington endeavored to stay in high spirits. “I always have to remind myself that that’s what I do ninety-nine per cent of the time—*not* finding bottles,” he told me. We climbed into Brown’s boat and headed out into the deep, choppy blue. The vessel heaved while Buffington and I clung to the guardrails. Within a few minutes, we were all soaked.

“I always tell people the ocean writes a story on the beach,” Buffington said. “My job is to read it.”Photograph courtesy Bob Buffington

After an hour of brain-joggling transit, we made it to the beach—something out of a shipwreck novel, devoid of any trace of human presence. Dropped onshore, Buffington and I walked and walked some more. There was no cell service, and Brown would be out of walkie-talkie range until we approached the pickup spot. For most of history, an island was a place of real isolation. Now a message could reach you practically anywhere—you had to find an island within an island to get off the grid. The experience of being totally incommunicado was liberating, but I also felt a sense of dread: What if I got heatstroke, or broke an ankle? Or, worse, what if Buffington did?

On the horizon, I noticed a blob. It looked like a rock with a sword stuck into it, but it turned out to be an actual shipwreck: the remains of a fibreglass-hulled yacht. Buffington was in the dunes, rifling through some trash. He picked up a bottle, round and brown, that looked like it contained a brochure or a wrapper. Then he found another, with some white stuff inside, its consistency somewhere between confetti and ash.

“It doesn’t look like much, but it’s definitely a message in a bottle,” Buffington said, wiping his brow. “Unfortunately, whoever made it sealed it with a rubber cork, and rubber just really doesn’t do a good job of sealing.”

We kept going. The hours and miles melted into one another, still and silent, until, in the distance, we could make out Brown’s skiff. Just before we left, Buffington, a touch desperately, picked up a final bottle, a brown squarish one that looked like it might have held rum. We couldn’t even tell if there

was anything inside. “I just hope this isn’t the only trip of my life where I don’t find a bottle,” he said.

On the final morning of my visit, Buffington and I met on the porch of the Baycaner to open our bottles. The first—the one that looked like it contained a brochure—was the least promising. Still, Buffington slipped it into a gallon-sized ziplock, to catch any shards. Next, he took a hammer-shaped piece of coral and started tapping the bottle until the body separated from the neck. Buffington extricated the paper. It was surprisingly dry and perfectly legible, but the content was distinctly uninspiring: a user’s guide to various lines of LifeStyles condoms, including the Rough Rider, “seductively studded up and down.” The second bottle, with confetti-ish contents, was equally useless—whatever had been inside had broken down into a friable mess.

Buffington had warned me that the opening process could be unpredictable. “Each bottle creates a sealed environment,” he explained. “And once you breach that everything changes, and it usually changes quickly.” With one chance left, he picked up the squarish bottle and held it close to his chest, gingerly screwing off the cap. Then he raised it to his eye, like a telescope.

“There’s definitely paper inside,” he said excitedly. “And it has blue lines!”

Buffington broke the bottle open. Out came a wad of white material that resembled a soggy tissue. Buffington placed it on a binder and tried to separate the paper’s furls. Despite his caution, his fiddling provoked several rips.

“This would be much better to do in the Lab at home,” he muttered. “Take it slow, Clinty, take it slow.”

He got out a Swiss Army knife and began poking at the layers with a blade. The paper was indeed notebook paper, bearing handwriting. Letters were beginning to emerge.

“R-A-V-A!” he called out, with the edgy energy of a “Wheel of Fortune” contestant on the verge of solving a puzzle. “L-O-V!”

This was finally, undoubtedly, an M.I.B. There was no mistaking the trace of a human hand. But much of the paper was impossible to smooth out, and even where it was flat it was impossible to read. We couldn't discern a single complete word. The message had found us, against steep odds, but the meaning was irretrievable.

Curtis Ebbesmeyer, the oceanographer, has calculated average reply rates to messages in bottles using data from mass M.I.B. mailings—scientific, evangelical, or promotional campaigns such as the Guinness drop, or the forty thousand "gospel torpedoes" that a Tacoma preacher sent out from the Puget Sound in the nineteen-forties. Ebbesmeyer estimates that for every ten M.I.B.s one is found and reported, three are found and ignored, three wash up but are never found, one gets buried in the sand, one drifts for years and years, and one "suffers any of a number of other fates," including getting swallowed by an animal or sunk by the weight of barnacles.

The Golden Records on the Voyager spacecrafts—documenting everything from the music of Louis Armstrong to a baby's laughter—are basically messages in a bottle, borne through space instead of water. So are time capsules, like the Crypt of Civilization, in Georgia, an airtight room filled with recordings which was sealed in 1940 and is intended to be opened in the year 8113. Ancient Romans scratched graffiti onto walls in Herculaneum; the 1974 Arecibo message aimed radio frequencies at a cluster of stars twenty-five thousand light-years away. All are examples of the abiding human desire to make contact. Closing the circle is a long shot, but such unlikeliness only intensifies the feeling of kismet when an M.I.B. hits its mark.

I was waiting at the airport when the plane came on Friday afternoon. Buffington, who was initially supposed to leave with me, had decided to extend his trip. "I'll walk over coals, man," he told me of his commitment to finding a bottle. After I left, he kayaked to even more remote points on the island. But these, too, proved fruitless.

On a whim during an Alaskan cruise, the cartoonist Charles Schulz drew an original sketch for a message in a bottle, which his wife, Jean, chucked into the ocean.Photograph courtesy © 1975 SFIPT / Charles M. Schulz Museum

Finally, he drove to the spot where we'd looked on the first day. "It was the very last place I could go," he said. He walked until he saw our footprints and then pushed a little farther. About half a mile on, he spotted a champagne bottle, green and clear, with a perfect little cigarette of a scroll inside—the real thing, at last.

A couple of weeks later, Buffington held the bottle close to his computer camera, turning it slowly for me to admire. He pointed out that whoever had written it had sealed the scroll with a Band-Aid. "The really exciting thing is you can see writing in there," Buffington said. He was right. Even at a distance, I could make out at least one full sentence, written in what looked like Sharpie: "Thanks for finding me."

"That's as legit as it gets!" Buffington exclaimed. The bottle had a screw cap, and Buffington's plan was to pry it off and dump the message out, as if pouring a drink. He gripped the cap and gave it a firm twist. I could hear a hissing sound—years' worth of air pressure being released.

"That is nuts!" Buffington said. "I don't think I even need any tools."

The message slid right out. As Buffington unwound the scroll, his hands began to shake. "Thanks for finding me," he read aloud. "I was in WV and traveled to the Frying Pan Lighthouse where a desperate lady wanted to say there is life during a pandemic. And I hope we survive the 2020 election. God bless you. JAV."

The message was dated September 20, 2020. The sender hadn't included contact information or a full name. I wasn't even sure that the first initial in "JAV" was "J" and not "L." "Let's not be discouraged," Buffington said. "We have a lot of clues. We'll find them."

The first move, obviously, was to Google "Frying Pan Lighthouse," which turned out to be a "decommissioned Coast Guard lighthouse located near the end of the Frying Pan Shoals," in North Carolina. The tower was intended to help ships navigate the shoals, part of a perilous stretch of shallow water known as the Graveyard of the Atlantic. Built in 1964, the tower looks like an oil rig topped with a Tuscan campanile.

Frying Pan Tower, as it is often called, had an impressive online presence, including a Facebook account with more than three hundred thousand followers. A man named Richard Neal, a former Oklahoma software engineer, bought the tower in a government auction for eighty-five thousand dollars in 2010 and turned it into a nonprofit environmental-research center. Adventurous souls can sleep on site and volunteer for restoration projects, in addition to enjoying such activities as golfing off the lighthouse's platform with biodegradable balls made from fish food.

Buffington recorded a video and posted it to social media. "If you know anyone who's ever been to Frying Pan Tower, and you can share this with them, that would be awesome," he announced, brandishing the letter.

In March, Joyce VanGilder was pulling into a building site when she got a text from her sister-in-law. It was a screenshot, showing Buffington with the message from Mayaguana. "I just kept looking at it," VanGilder recalled. "I was, like, 'That definitely is my handwriting. But I have no memory of this.' "

VanGilder admitted that the evidence that she had written the letter was overwhelming. She lives in Charleston, West Virginia, where she works in architectural services. Her middle name is Ann. Her sister-in-law, Vanessa, is a lighthouse fanatic, and in 2020, in the waning days of summer, the women had driven from West Virginia to visit Frying Pan Tower.

It was the middle of the pandemic, and the two were eager to get out in nature and do some manual labor. They spent three days repainting a pantry and clearing out expired foods. Evenings were festive. Vanessa had packed a kite to fly from the tower. VanGilder had brought a bottle of André Spumante. “My go-to,” she explained. “Cheap sparkling wine.”

One night after dinner, VanGilder decided to write a note—it was all coming back to her now. She had an empty bottle; she was, not unrelatedly, a little tipsy; she was on a decommissioned lighthouse in the middle of the ocean; and she and her boyfriend had recently been watching “Survivor,” in which “people were finding these little messages all around different places on the islands.” On a whim, she jotted down a few sentences. The “desperate lady” was VanGilder herself. “I had my mother staying with me during the pandemic,” she recalled. “She’s now ninety years old, and we have learned that we cannot live together.” Bottle, solved.

Confronted with her handiwork six years later, after a journey that likely took it into the Gulf Stream and around the entire clockwise circuit of the North Atlantic—a trip of several thousand punishing miles—VanGilder seemed more concerned about the bottle than about the message. “I feel like an international litterbug,” she admitted. Buffington had shown her a photograph of the site where the bottle was found. “When I saw all the stuff that was sitting around where he picked it up, I was, like, ‘Man, I guess I need to get down there and clean up some trash,’ ” she said.

VanGilder had sent the bottle with casual intentions, but I was oddly moved by receiving it. I grew up in Wilmington, not far from the Frying Pan, and, in 1988, my father had a bad accident on Bald Head, the nearest point of land. As I read about the tower, the names of local TV affiliates and the daily newspaper from my childhood kept cropping up. For almost a decade, I’d been writing a book about Wilmington. Physically, I was in France, but my head was in my home town. Somehow, it seemed, it had written me back. ♦

Lauren Collins has been a staff writer at The New Yorker since 2008. Her books include “They Stole a City: Wilmington’s White Supremacist Coup and the Families Who Live with Its Legacy” (July, 2026).

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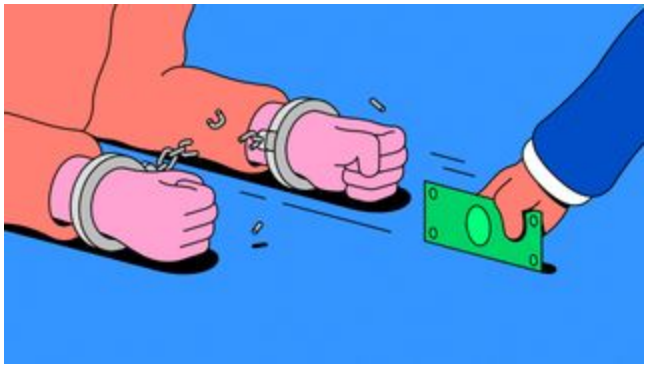
Letter from Washington

Donald Trump’s Pardon Economy

For some wealthy offenders, clemency is just a golf game—or a million-dollar plate at Mar-a-Lago—away.

***By** Ruth Marcus*

April 27, 2026



The surest strategy for obtaining a pardon is to tap into Trump’s sense of victimhood.Illustration by Till Lauer

“I have great respect for you,” Donald Trump told Rod Blagojevich. “I have great respect for your tenacity, for the fact that you just don’t give up. But, Rod, you’re fired.” It was April, 2010, week four of the third season of “The Celebrity Apprentice,” and Blagojevich, the pugnacious former governor of Illinois, had bungled the assignment: to design a promotional campaign for a new Harry Potter exhibit at Universal Studios. In truth, Blagojevich had bigger things to worry about. He was broke—hence the “Celebrity Apprentice” gig. More worrisome, he was about to stand trial on corruption charges, for, among other things, trying to profit from naming Barack Obama’s replacement in the Senate. Blagojevich was ultimately convicted and sentenced to fourteen years in prison. He served eight of them, until Trump, in his first term as President, commuted his sentence. Blagojevich, a Democrat, had launched a lobbying blitz and received support from Jesse Jackson, Rudy Giuliani, and the legal scholar Alan Dershowitz. A full pardon came later, at the start of Trump’s second term. The weekend after the Inauguration, the President “called me on a Saturday

night to say he’s gonna pardon me,” Blagojevich said. Speaking with me recently, he recalled his “Celebrity Apprentice” appearance with glee. “That’s the great miracle of the whole thing—if I don’t do that television show, then President Trump doesn’t become the only President in American history to have fired and freed the same guy,” he said.

Now, in an only-in-Trump’s-America turn, Blagojevich has become a pardon lobbyist. His client is Anne Pramaggiore, who was once one of the most prominent women in Chicago: the C.E.O. of Commonwealth Edison, the state’s largest utility; the chair of the board of the Federal Reserve Bank of Chicago; and a benefactor of the Art Institute of Chicago, the Lincoln Park Zoo, and the Chicago Urban League. In January, Pramaggiore reported to a federal prison in Marianna, Florida, to serve a two-year sentence for her role in a scheme to provide no-show jobs to associates of Michael Madigan, the long-serving speaker of the Illinois House of Representatives and, before his own conviction on corruption charges, perhaps the most influential politician in the state. At the time, Pramaggiore was appealing her conviction, and she stood a reasonable chance of winning. (A Supreme Court ruling had wiped out the basis for part of the conviction, and the foundation for the remaining charges was shaky.) But, in Trump 2.0, the courts are just one route to freedom, and not necessarily the swiftest. So Pramaggiore had also turned to lobbyists in the hope of a Presidential intervention, eventually paying them a total of nearly five hundred thousand dollars. Two hundred and thirty thousand went to Blagojevich, according to federal lobbying reports.

In several months of reporting on pardons during the second Trump Administration, I reached out to dozens of lawyers, lobbyists, pardon recipients, and Administration officials, most of whom declined to be named, if they responded at all. Not Blagojevich, who returned my phone call with alacrity. “Put me on the record, because Anne Pramaggiore is one thousand per cent innocent,” Blagojevich insisted when we first spoke, in late February. “She’s a victim of a terrible injustice, inflicted on her by a system in Illinois that’s dirty, rotten, and corrupt.” (Pramaggiore was indicted in November, 2020, during Trump’s first Administration, and his second Administration has defended the conviction on appeal.)

In pursuit of clemency for Pramaggiore, Blagojevich said, he met with multiple players in the world of pardons under Trump: Ed Martin, the Stop the Steal activist who was installed in the position of pardon attorney after his nomination to be the U.S. Attorney for the District of Columbia tanked; Alice Johnson, who was named to the newly created role of White House pardon czar a half-dozen years after Trump, during his first term, commuted her life sentence, for cocaine trafficking, at the behest of Kim Kardashian; and Sean Hayes, a former Republican congressional staffer, who oversees pardons as deputy White House counsel. The ultimate decider, of course, is Trump himself. “We’re trying to build a coalition of support to bring this to President Trump’s attention,” Blagojevich told me. “It’s not so easy. He’s the busiest person in the world.” To make the case for Pramaggiore, Blagojevich brought in Dershowitz, a Trump confidant. “The two of us, maybe, potentially, can at one point go see President Trump and talk to him about this, when the timing’s right,” Blagojevich said.

Before Blagojevich could get in to see Trump, Pramaggiore’s case took an extraordinary turn. On April 14th, it was argued before the federal appeals court in Chicago; that day the panel of judges granted Pramaggiore a new trial and ordered her released right away. For Blagojevich, though, the pardon effort isn’t over. He is hopeful that Trump will still intercede. “I would ask that he does for her what he did for me,” Blagojevich said on a phone call after Pramaggiore’s release.

Unlike his predecessors, who tended to delay dispensing pardons until their final months in the White House, Trump plunged into the process in the first hours of his second term. “Most Presidents sit there and allow injustices to linger while innocent people are stuck in prison, or people who may have done wrong, who’ve been over-sentenced, are treated mercilessly and have to sit and wait,” Blagojevich said. “President Trump is very different. He sees something wrong, and he works to get it done and undo the wrong.”

Under previous Presidents, pardon seekers were expected to wait at least five years after serving their sentences and to demonstrate remorse for their actions. With Trump, no wait—and no remorse—is required. Nor is conducting a previously standard F.B.I. background investigation. On January 20, 2025, his first day back in office, Trump made good on a

campaign pledge to pardon the January 6th defendants. Calling them “our great hostages,” Trump pardoned around fifteen hundred of them, effectively erasing the largest investigation in the history of the Justice Department. One of those pardoned was serving a twenty-year sentence for blasting bear spray into the mask of a police officer and using a crutch to bash another officer in the head. Another pardoned rioter, sentenced to twelve and a half years, stole a Taser and shocked an officer with it twice, giving him a heart attack. The next day, Trump fulfilled another campaign promise: to pardon Ross Ulbricht, the founder of the online black market Silk Road, who was convicted of distributing narcotics and conspiring to launder money, and was given two life sentences and forty years. “The scum that worked to convict him were some of the same lunatics who were involved in the modern day weaponization of government against me,” Trump posted on Truth Social.

Trump’s first-term pardons were focussed, in part, on undoing the work of the special counsel Robert Mueller, whose investigation into the Trump campaign’s dealings with Russia plagued his Presidency. Trump pardoned his former national-security adviser Michael Flynn after Flynn pleaded guilty—twice—to lying to the F.B.I. about a conversation with the Russian Ambassador during Trump’s first Presidential transition. He pardoned his former campaign chairman Paul Manafort after Manafort’s conviction for, among other things, hiding millions of dollars in offshore accounts and failing to register as a foreign agent for Ukraine. Trump pardoned his longtime ally Roger Stone, who was convicted of witness tampering and lying to Congress, and he pardoned the former White House strategist Steve Bannon before Bannon stood trial for siphoning funds from a campaign to build a border wall.

As with much else involving Trump’s two Presidencies, his first-term performance appears restrained in retrospect. During the first year of his first term, Trump granted a single pardon and commuted a single sentence. Similarly, Joe Biden, Barack Obama, George W. Bush, and Bill Clinton issued no pardons or commutations during their first year in office. Trump, in his first full year back in power, dispensed eighty-eight pardons and twenty-three commutations—not including the January 6th rioters or seventy-seven individuals preëmptively pardoned for any crimes they may

have committed during the 2020 election. The theme of the second-term pardons has been rectifying the purported weaponization of the Justice Department under Biden's Attorney General, Merrick Garland. Trump "was very clear when he came into office that he was most interested in looking at pardoning individuals who were abused and used by the Biden Department of Justice and were over-prosecuted by a weaponized D.O.J.," Karoline Leavitt, the White House press secretary, has explained.

"You can kiss a frog and turn him into a prince, but you can't stop that prince from turning into a dud who wastes two years of your twenties."
Cartoon by Daniel Kanhai

Rachel Barkow, a law professor at New York University who specializes in Presidential clemency, told me, of Trump's use of the pardon power, "It's part of his carrot-and-stick approach—you're his enemy, he's going to prosecute you. You're Jim Comey, you're Tish James, he's going to investigate your mortgage application. He's going to do everything he can to bring you down. Whereas, if you're a January 6th person, you support his family's crypto business, you do anything to support him, he will give you a pardon. We've never seen anything like this before in history."

The pardon power was intended, the Supreme Court has said, to promote "the benign prerogative of mercy." Some of Trump's pardon recipients appear worthy—the White House pointed me to, among others, a sex-trafficking victim who'd been convicted in an extortion scheme run by her

abusers—but, in one instance after another, this President has directed clemency toward political allies, celebrities, and fraudsters. Trump commuted the sentence of the former congressman George Santos ("Good luck George, have a great life!" the President wrote on Truth Social) and pardoned the reality-TV stars Todd and Julie Chrisley, who'd been convicted of bank fraud and tax evasion. Matt Gaetz, the disgraced former congressman and a failed nominee for Attorney General, used his show on One America News Network to press Trump to pardon the former Honduran President Juan Orlando Hernández, who was convicted of drug trafficking in what Trump labelled a "Biden setup." The Trump confidante Laura Loomer weighed in on behalf of Rabbi Joseph Schwartz, a New Jersey nursing-home owner convicted of defrauding the government of thirty-eight million dollars by failing to pay employment taxes. Trump pardoned both men last year. (In one astonishing twist, a lobbyist named Joshua Nass, who received a hundred thousand dollars as part of the effort to secure the Schwartz pardon, was arrested in March and charged with having "plotted the violent extortion of one of his own clients," apparently Schwartz, who Nass claimed had failed to pay him an additional five hundred thousand dollars.)

Trump has pardoned people charged by his own Justice Department. One such instance, as reported by the *Wall Street Journal*, followed a golf outing with the former congressman Trey Gowdy, who asked Trump to help him move up a meeting with Justice Department prosecutors and ended up with a full pardon for his client. In a first for any President, Trump has granted clemency to corporations, pardoning one company and commuting the sentence of another. He has even purported to have pardoned an individual convicted of a state crime: Tina Peters, a former county clerk in Colorado who was convicted of tampering with voting machines in 2020. Martin, the pardon attorney, had promised in a post on X, "Tina, we are coming for you, M'am."

Trump's chief of staff, Susie Wiles, was reportedly blindsided by the pardon of Hernández and attempted to put a pause on pardons late last year. She was said to be concerned about the haphazard nature of the process and the huge sums being paid to lobbyists and attorneys. "Susie does not like this," one person familiar with the pardon process told me. "Pardons are rarely a

good news story." The flow has slowed recently: this year, there have been eight commutations and twenty pardons but none, as of late April, since February.

For pardon supplicants, the surest way to the President's signature is to tap into his sense of victimhood. As one lawyer who works on pardon cases explained to me, "Is this a prosecutor that the President hates? Is this a judge the President hates? Everything about him seems to be personal, and so you need to take that approach and view this as personal grievances. He doesn't really care about your case, but he's happy to exercise his personal grievances through your case."

Trump's pardon spree may have happened in any event, but it was facilitated, as a political matter, by Biden's decision to pardon his son Hunter. During Biden's truncated reëlection campaign, he repeatedly promised that he would not pardon Hunter, who, in June, 2024, was convicted of illegally possessing a gun and went on to plead guilty to failing to pay income taxes. Not long after Trump was elected, Biden abandoned his pledge, asserting that his son had been "selectively and unfairly prosecuted" by Biden's own Justice Department. The pardon was remarkably broad: it covered any offenses that Hunter "may have committed" during an eleven-year period. Biden followed up with preëmptive pardons for his siblings and their spouses, who were not under investigation. He also took the unusual step of issuing preëmptive pardons to current and former officials who were potential targets of the incoming Administration, including the former chief medical adviser Anthony Fauci, the former chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff General Mark Milley, and members and staff of the House January 6th committee, including the former representative Liz Cheney. Liz Oyer, who served as pardon attorney under Biden, told me that, in her view, Biden's actions "laid the groundwork for this narrative that Trump has tried to spin—that this is just what all Presidents do." (According to the *Journal*, Trump recently promised pardons to "everyone who has come within two hundred feet of the Oval." Leavitt suggested this was a joke.)

The role of the pardon attorney is to review requests for pardons and commutations and transmit recommendations to the President. During the

Biden years, Oyer told me, the work had been “very frustrating.” Thousands of people were serving lengthy prison sentences under mandatory-minimum laws that Biden had championed during his Senate days, but Oyer found his Administration reluctant to intervene. “There was a lack of political courage in the White House,” she said.

The frustrations of working with the Trump Administration were of a different magnitude. Oyer says that she was never told, despite repeated requests, whom she should deal with in the White House counsel’s office. She recalled that she learned about the January 6th pardons from a news alert. “I started getting frantic calls from people in the Bureau of Prisons saying, ‘We’re being told we need to release four hundred people tonight, and facilities are reporting that families are coming in their cars and knocking on doors.’ ”

The Trump Justice Department assigned Oyer a task outside the office’s normal scope. It wanted her to look into restoring gun rights to individuals whose previous convictions made them ineligible to possess firearms. Oyer duly assembled a roster, which was eventually whittled down to nine people who had already been vetted and had committed nonviolent crimes. Then she was asked to add a tenth: Mel Gibson. The actor had pleaded no contest, in 2011, to a domestic-violence misdemeanor for assaulting his ex-girlfriend; she said she’d been left with two broken teeth and a black eye. According to Oyer, an aide to Todd Blanche—then the Deputy Attorney General, now the acting Attorney General—told her, “We have to grant relief to Mel.” In fact, Oyer’s assent wasn’t needed; the Attorney General has the authority to take this action. “I believe that my recommendation was sought because it would give a veneer of legitimacy to what was really a political favor for a friend of the President,” Oyer told me. In early March, she submitted a memo that included Gibson as a possible candidate but declined to recommend restoring his gun rights. That very day, she was pulled out of a meeting by her deputy and told that security officers were waiting in her office to present her with termination papers. The following month, the Justice Department announced that Gibson’s gun rights would be reinstated. (A senior Justice Department official denied that Oyer was pressured to recommend Gibson or that she was fired because of the incident.)

“Trump has totally upended the clemency system as we know it,” Oyer said. “There is no path forward for regular people who have merit-based claims to clemency. And, at the same time, there’s a booming pardon economy where—if you’ve got inside access or if you have the money to spend to get the right lawyer or lobbyist in place—you can essentially buy a pardon. If you can pay to attend one of these million-dollar-a-plate dinners at Mar-a-Lago, or if you can make a gigantic donation to Trump’s political interests, or if you can fund his crypto business, then you can get a pardon.”

Oyer notes that Trump’s pardons take a financial toll, in addition to a moral one. On her Substack, “Lawyer Oyer,” she maintains a running total of the pardons’ cost to the federal government, in fines and forfeitures, and to victims, in restitution. Trump’s pardons, Oyer estimates, have erased at least one and a half billion dollars owed by those convicted of crimes.

The White House insists that money plays no role in Trump’s pardons. The evidence suggests otherwise. “If you’re a wildly rich guy who’s looking for a pardon, giving a contribution is probably the single best way to elevate your brand,” one Republican lobbyist told me. In 2023, Trevor Milton, the founder of an electric-and-hydrogen-vehicle startup called Nikola, was sentenced to four years in prison for defrauding investors; his supposedly “fully functioning” prototype had been towed to the top of a hill and filmed rolling down the slope. Trump’s “pardon of innocence,” as Milton called it, not only excused him from serving time (he had been free on bail while appealing the conviction) but relieved him of having to pay restitution to those he defrauded, a sum that federal prosecutors claimed amounted to more than six hundred and sixty million dollars. “There was real loss to real people who listened to Mr. Milton and invested in Nikola because of what they heard from him,” the U.S. district judge overseeing Milton’s case said.

Before the 2024 election, Milton had contributed relatively small sums to political candidates. He gave fifteen hundred dollars to Trump during the 2016 campaign cycle, a thousand in the 2020 cycle, and ten thousand in 2022. In the fall of 2024, while Milton was appealing the conviction, he and his wife, Chelsey, contributed more than $3.6 million to Trump and other Republican candidates and committees, according to Federal Election Commission records. The Miltons also gave nearly a million dollars to

Robert F. Kennedy, Jr., after he endorsed Trump. Milton—who had been represented for years by Brad Bondi, the brother of the former Attorney General Pam Bondi—received a pardon from Trump in March, 2025. (A spokesman for Milton said that Brad Bondi was “not involved in any form or fashion in the pardon process.”) “They say the thing that he did wrong was he was one of the first people that supported a gentleman named Donald Trump for President,” Trump said then. When the President called Milton to inform him of the pardon, Milton recalled, Trump told him, “You’re clean, you’re cleaner than a baby’s bottom, and you’re cleaner than I am, Trevor.”

Today, Milton is the C.E.O. of SyberJet Aircraft, an Arizona-based company, which claims that a new nine-seat jet will be the fastest of its kind. (“SyberJet is pushing the limits of light jet aviation in ways no other manufacturer is,” the company’s website says.) I wrote to Milton to ask about his pardon and his ramped-up political giving. “I was never offered a pardon until I received it,” he wrote in response. “Never bought a pardon. I never offered to donate for a pardon. I was never asked to donate.” Shortly afterward, the *Journal* reported on a multimillion-dollar lobbying campaign that SyberJet was conducting, which included sponsoring the lavish SyberJet Lounge at the Kennedy Center. “I walk into meetings now, and I’ll get high fives from the most wealthy people in the world,” Milton said. “They’re, like, ‘Welcome to the club. You can withstand the fire. We can trust you now.’ ”

Another recent Trump pardon beneficiary is Paul Walczak, from Palm Beach Gardens, Florida, whose family owned nursing homes. On November 15, 2024, ten days after Trump’s reëlection, Walczak pleaded guilty to failing to pay withholding taxes for his employees. Prosecutors argued that he should face a sentence of between five and six years. According to their sentencing memorandum to the judge, Walczak “used the funds to enrich himself,” purchasing a two-million-dollar yacht and spending corporate funds at Bergdorf Goodman, Cartier, and Saks. In addition, the memorandum continued, “when the IRS persisted—refusing to allow him to simply walk away with the millions of dollars he took from his employees under the guise of complying with the tax code—the Defendant

tried to hide his personal wealth by starting a new business under the name of his then twenty-year-old daughter.”

After pleading guilty, Walczak agreed to pay the taxes and asked for leniency. But, prosecutors said, “awarding a lesser sentence to a defendant simply because he is wealthy enough to pay back millions of dollars after being caught is not justice.” Rather, they wrote, “to maintain confidence in the justice system, it must be the case that nobody can pay his or her way out of jail.”

“I prefer to walk down whichever side of the street has the most shopwindows I can admire my own reflection in.”
Cartoon by William Haefeli

Unbeknownst to prosecutors, Walczak was maneuvering to do just that. Even before Trump returned to office, Walczak’s lawyers had prepared a clemency petition that cited, among other things, the millions of dollars that Walczak’s mother, a conservative activist named Elizabeth Fago, had raised for Trump and for Republican causes. During the 2020 campaign, the petition noted, she’d hosted a Trump fund-raiser, attended by Donald Trump, Jr., where a diary stolen from Biden’s daughter Ashley was circulated. The petition highlighted support for Walczak from Trump, Jr., and his then girlfriend, Kimberly Guilfoyle. It made the argument, sure to appeal to Trump but unsupported by the evidence in the case, that prosecutors had singled out Walczak because of his mother’s Republican ties. And, to bolster Fago’s claim that her son was being punished for her

political activity, it noted Biden's assertion that he'd been compelled to pardon Hunter because of selective prosecution by his Justice Department.

As Walczak's sentencing date approached, Fago received an invitation to a million-dollar-per-person fund-raiser for *MAGA* Inc., Trump's super *PAC*. The "candlelight dinner," to be held on April 4, 2025, at Mar-a-Lago, would feature President Trump. Fago's largest previous single donation had been a hundred thousand dollars to the Republican National Committee, in 2002, and her political giving for the 2024 election cycle totalled a little more than six hundred dollars. *MAGA* Inc. reported receiving a million-dollar check from Fago on April 3rd. The next evening, she seized the moment to make her case to Trump, according to a person familiar with the event. Afterward, the President spoke to Wiles and his top fund-raiser, Meredith O'Rourke, issuing instructions: "Get it done." The following week, Walczak was sentenced to eighteen months in prison and ordered to pay more than four million dollars in restitution. But before he had to report to prison the White House announced the pardon. The White House did not respond to a detailed request for comment about the pardoning of Walczak and others. Fago, through an attorney, declined to comment, and Walczak didn't respond to an e-mail. An Instagram post by Walczak's half brother showed Walczak celebrating with family members. In one photo, Fago has wrapped her arms around her beaming son. He is wearing a red baseball cap emblazoned with the words "Make Paul Great Again."

To avoid concentrating too much power in any single branch of government, the architects of the Constitution crafted an intricate system of checks and balances. Pardons, derived from the British monarch's ancient "prerogative of mercy," represent a deliberate exception. Article II, Section 2, Clause 1 provides that the President "shall have Power to grant Reprieves and Pardons for Offences against the United States, except in Cases of Impeachment." As the Supreme Court described it in an 1866 case, the pardon power "extends to every offence known to the law, and may be exercised at any time after its commission, either before legal proceedings are taken or during their pendency or after conviction and judgment."

For a power so sweeping, the President's pardon authority received little attention during the debates over the Constitution. The first two draft

proposals did not include a pardon power; that came later, as part of a plan proposed by Alexander Hamilton. “Humanity and good policy conspire to dictate, that the benign prerogative of pardoning should be as little as possible fettered or embarrassed,” Hamilton argued in Federalist No. 74. “The criminal code of every country partakes so much of necessary severity, that without an easy access to exceptions in favor of unfortunate guilt, justice would wear a countenance too sanguinary and cruel.” He and others posited that a single individual, the President, would wield the pardon power more responsibly than if authority—and therefore blame for bad decisions—were spread more widely.

The delegates at the Constitutional Convention, well aware of abuses of pardons under the English monarchy, worried about the potential for corruption. One of them, Roger Sherman, suggested that the Senate be required to concur in grants of clemency; he received support from only his home state of Connecticut. Toward the end of debate, Edmund Randolph, Virginia’s governor, moved unsuccessfully to bar pardons in cases of treason, expressing concern that the President “may himself be guilty” and that the “Traytors may be his own instruments.” (A counter-argument was that impeachment would protect against such abuses.) In hindsight, the critics of untrammelled pardon authority had a point. The President “ought not to have the power of pardoning, because he may frequently pardon crimes which were advised by himself,” George Mason argued at the Virginia ratifying convention, in 1788. “It may happen, at some future day, that he will establish a monarchy, and destroy the republic. If he has the power of granting pardons before indictment, or conviction, may he not stop inquiry and prevent detection?”

On May 29, 1865, Andrew Johnson granted pardons to most former Confederates, an act that helped restore them to political power and frustrated the goals of Reconstruction. But thousands, including high-ranking officers, were at first excluded from the mass amnesty, so Johnson’s tenure also featured the emergence of “pardon brokers,” who promised to help desperate Confederates seeking to recover property seized by Union forces. The typical fee was a hundred and fifty dollars. The Johnson White House insisted that such services had no effect. “The President declares that

any intimation that money can assist a petition is a gross insult of his whole office," Johnson's pardon clerk wrote.

More recent Presidents have issued their own share of questionable pardons. On Christmas Eve, 1992, the departing President, George H. W. Bush, pardoned the former Secretary of Defense Caspar Weinberger and five other former officials connected to the Iran-Contra scandal. The pardons led the independent counsel Lawrence Walsh to suggest that the President, who was mentioned in Weinberger's notes, was trying to shield himself from being drawn into any court proceedings. "In light of President Bush's own misconduct, we are gravely concerned about his decision to pardon others who lied to Congress and obstructed official investigations," Walsh said.

Bill Clinton's pardons—he issued a hundred and forty on his final day in office—were even more squalid. A House investigation found that Clinton's half brother, Roger, "engaged in a systematic effort to trade on his brother's name," receiving hundreds of thousands of dollars in payments from individuals seeking pardons. Hillary Clinton's brother Hugh Rodham, a Florida lawyer, also received nearly four hundred thousand dollars from two clients for whom he obtained last-minute pardons. Most infamously, Clinton pardoned Marc Rich, a financier who'd fled the country rather than stand trial on charges of tax evasion. Rich's ex-wife Denise, who'd lobbied Clinton to grant the pardon, had contributed a million dollars to Democrats and four hundred and fifty thousand dollars to Clinton's Presidential library. "It's clear that none of these grants of clemency would have been issued on the merits," the House committee conducting the investigation concluded. "Only by capitalizing on relationships between President Clinton and individuals close to him were these petitioners able to obtain grants of clemency."

Frank Bowman, an emeritus law professor at the University of Missouri, has recently completed a book on the history of pardons. He faults Johnson for undermining Reconstruction, Clinton for his questionable eleventh-hour actions, and Biden for shielding family members. But for all the distasteful pardons of past Presidents, Bowman told me, Trump is in a sordid class by himself. "On the Trump side, you can keep going for literally dozens,

maybe hundreds, of what-abouts. And, on the other side, you're going to keep coming back and saying, 'What about Marc Rich?' 'What about Hunter Biden?' " Bowman said. "The first answer to whataboutism is one of scale. Nothing on Trump's scale has ever happened at any point in American history, period."

Trump's brazen use of the pardon power has generated a Washington growth industry—pardon lobbyists and lawyers, who tout their connections with Trump Administration officials. Some of the biggest reported payments have occurred in cases where the clemency bid has not succeeded. Keith Schiller, Trump's former bodyguard and later his director of Oval Office operations, disclosed that his lobbying firm, Javelin Advisors, was paid a million dollars to secure a pardon for Fred Daibes, a New Jersey businessman convicted in a bribery scheme in which he gave gold bars to the former senator Bob Menendez. No pardon has been granted. Robert Travers, a lawyer for Daibes, issued a statement last fall that indicated some frustration with the outcome: "Fred Daibes has not worked with Keith Schiller or Javelin since June of this year and he is no longer engaged with them." (In response to a lengthy list of questions about Trump's pardons, Leavitt, the press secretary, sent the following statement: "President Trump exercises his constitutional authority to issue pardons and commutations at his discretion. Anyone spending money to lobby for pardons is foolishly wasting their money.")

Some lawyers and lobbyists have reached out, unsolicited, to people who have been indicted or convicted, dangling the prospect of making their problems disappear. "Every one of my clients is being approached by these scumbags," one prominent criminal-defense lawyer told me. "They identify people who are under the gun, who've been convicted, who have money, and they say, 'I can make this happen.' " Another prominent criminal-defense lawyer said, "There's a category of people who just sell the connection. It's really so bald-faced—they are just so clear that they can get it done. They say who they're friends with. It's often White House counsel. And they ask for a million dollars, and another million dollars if it's successful."

Ches McDowell, a bearded, baby-faced man with a penchant for bespoke suits, chewing tobacco, and ostrich-skin boots, isn't one of those cold callers—business at his firm, Checkmate Government Relations (so named "because we win," he told me), is too good for that. McDowell, a North Carolina lobbyist who set up shop in Washington in May, 2025, reported an astonishing twenty-two million dollars in lobbying revenue last year. His clients have spanned the corporate landscape, from Fortune 500 firms such as Eli Lilly, General Dynamics, and Philip Morris to newer entrants on the Washington scene, such as the GEO Group (which operates detention centers), the Sports Betting Alliance, and Trevor Milton's SyberJet.

Most Washington lobbying shops are decorated in the style of an upscale airport lounge. McDowell's features taxidermy—a seven-hundred-pound stuffed bear that he shot himself, a snarling mountain lion—plus a plaque with the Wi-Fi password, which refers, cheekily, to Trump's claim of having won the Presidency three times. McDowell, the son of two staunchly Democratic pastors, met Trump, Jr., shortly before the 2016 election and now counts him as a close friend. But McDowell said that they do not mix business and friendship. "I've never, never once, discussed a lobbying issue that I'm hired to work on with Don," he told me.

McDowell squeezed me in for an interview while being driven, in his Cadillac Escalade, to his Georgetown tailor for a fitting. "We're burning K Street to the ground and rebuilding," he said, referring to the traditional address of Washington lobbying shops. "The model that we brought to D.C. was 'We're going to get it done whatever it takes, no matter how much political capital we have to burn.' " McDowell's team includes a nephew of Robert F. Kennedy, Jr., and the son of Trump's campaign manager Chris LaCivita.

Among McDowell's achievements is obtaining a pardon for Changpeng Zhao, the billionaire founder of Binance, a cryptocurrency exchange. In 2023, during the Biden Administration, Zhao pleaded guilty to failing to implement an effective anti-money-laundering program. The company agreed to pay $4.3 billion, one of the largest corporate penalties in U.S. history, and to subject its operations to strict monitoring; Zhao was fined fifty million dollars and served a four-month sentence. The technical-

sounding nature of these offenses belies the seriousness of the misconduct, which allegedly helped Hamas terrorists, Russian drug traffickers, and other criminals move billions of dollars. “Binance turned a blind eye to its legal obligations in the pursuit of profit,” then Treasury Secretary Janet Yellen said when the guilty pleas were reached. Binance began its formal lobbying campaign soon after Trump’s second Inauguration, hiring the law firm Baker & Hostetler. It reported being paid three hundred and thirty thousand dollars last year for lobbying on “financial services policy issues” and “executive relief”—in other words, pardons.

In the meantime, the Trump family had ventured into the cryptocurrency industry, with a company called World Liberty Financial, which launched in September, 2024. An entity owned by the Trump family controls around forty per cent of the business. “It’s one of the more successful things we’ve ever done,” Eric Trump told the *Times* last year. Binance played a key role in insuring that success. According to the *Journal*, Binance arranged for an investment firm owned by the United Arab Emirates to buy a two-billion-dollar stake in Binance—with the purchase made using World Liberty Financial’s stablecoin, USD1. This transaction gave World Liberty Financial access to an enormous new pile of cash, one that could generate an annual income of eighty million dollars. (World Liberty Financial has denied that Binance played a role in having the deal financed with USD1.)

Then, last September, Binance brought on McDowell’s Checkmate to lobby the Trump Administration for a pardon and on cyber-policy issues. Checkmate has been paid more than $1.3 million for its services. For McDowell, neither Ed Martin, the pardon attorney, nor Alice Johnson, the pardon czar, was necessary to make his case. Instead, he went to Bo Hines, a fellow North Carolinian, who had recently served as the executive director of Trump’s crypto council. McDowell’s pitch to him was simple: the President’s crypto policy required undoing the excesses of the Biden Administration. “I felt like that was an easy sell,” McDowell said.

A few weeks later, McDowell, en route to a hunting trip with Trump, Jr., joined the President’s son at the White House for a ceremony awarding the Presidential Medal of Freedom to Charlie Kirk. At some point, as the *Journal* first reported, McDowell, finding himself one on one with the

President, took the opportunity to advocate for Zhao. Trump signed Zhao's pardon seven days later. Leavitt explained that the President "has officially ended the Biden Administration's war on the cryptocurrency industry, and I think that's the message he sent with this pardon." Trump, for his part, said of Zhao, "I have no idea who he is. I was told that he was a victim, just like I was and just like many other people, of a vicious, horrible group of people in the Biden Administration."

"If you think you shouldn't make your bed because 'it will just get messy again,' I have terrible news about literally every aspect of life."
Cartoon by Asher Perlman

McDowell's colorful approach is not the only strategy for pardon lobbying. Adam Katz, an unassuming-looking man who grew up on Long Island, has a law practice that consists mostly of run-of-the-mill commercial litigation and white-collar defense work—a pharmaceutical-company employee facing an overseas bribery investigation, a chemical manufacturer accused of racial discrimination. But during Trump's first term Katz became a pardon attorney, owing to connections that have served him well in the age of Trump. After graduating from Duke, he met a fellow-alumnus, Andrew Giuliani, the son of the former New York City mayor and Trump ally. Katz went on to represent Rudy Giuliani when he was sued for defamation by two Georgia poll workers, whom he'd accused of election fraud. (A jury awarded them a hundred and forty-eight million dollars.) In law school, at Georgetown, Katz befriended Boris Epshteyn, Trump's personal senior counsel and longtime close adviser. Katz went on to play a small role advising Trump when the President was sued for defamation and sexual

assault by the advice columnist E. Jean Carroll. (In two separate cases, juries awarded Carroll a total of eighty-eight million dollars.)

Katz was on a business trip to Las Vegas, in 2019, when he happened to meet a man named Andres Camberos, a California marijuana entrepreneur. Camberos shared the story of his sister, Adriana, who was about to serve a two-year prison sentence for selling counterfeit 5-hour Energy drinks, portraying her as the dupe of her husband, who had also been convicted in the scheme. Katz offered to try to help and, in January, 2020, he filed a clemency petition on Adriana's behalf. A month later, Andres made his first significant political contributions, consisting of a hundred thousand dollars spread among Trump-campaign committees and the Republican Party. (Seven months earlier, he had donated twenty-eight hundred dollars to Biden.) Katz brought in Stefan Passantino, a former deputy White House counsel who retained strong ties to Trump world. Marjorie Taylor Greene, a client of Passantino's, also expressed support for Adriana. The day before Trump left office in 2021, he commuted Adriana's sentence; she was about halfway through her prison term.

Then, in November, 2024, both Camberos siblings were convicted in a separate fraud scheme, this one involving reselling grocery items and other household supplies. "With the money they made from the scheme, Adriana and Andres Camberos made extensive luxury purchases and investments," the Justice Department said in a news release. "They bought or financed a Ferrari F12 Berlinetta, a Lamborghini Huracan, and multiple Range Rovers; purchased multiple homes in the San Diego area; purchased a condominium at the beach in Coronado; and put the money in multiple investment accounts." Adriana said that she hadn't realized the diversion scheme broke the law; District Judge Cynthia Bashant disagreed. "Ms. Camberos knew exactly what she was doing was illegal," Bashant said at Adriana's sentencing. "She developed an elaborate scheme to hide what she was doing. To the extent she testified to the contrary, I find she testified untruthfully." Adriana was sentenced to a year in prison, Andres to home confinement.

With Trump back in office, Katz and Passantino went to work, this time with an argument tailor-made to appeal to Trump: that vengeful prosecutors

had targeted the Camberos siblings for political reasons. The case against them, the pardon petition said, represented “a grave miscarriage of justice against two established business owners who were only prosecuted because President Trump commuted Ms. Camberos’s sentence from a prior conviction in 2021 and Mr. Camberos made a donation to the Trump campaign.” The petition compared the Camberoses’ prosecution to the case brought by New York’s attorney general, Letitia James, against the Trump Organization, arguing that in both cases the supposed victims of the fraud did not suffer any financial harm. In mid-January, Trump granted clemency—and this time went beyond mere commutation. Adriana and Andres Camberos each received a full pardon.

George W. Bush wrote in his memoir, “Decision Points,” about his revulsion at the pardon process. “One of the biggest surprises of my presidency was the flood of pardon requests at the end,” Bush recalled. “I could not believe the number of people who pulled me aside to suggest that a friend or former colleague deserved a pardon. At first I was frustrated. Then I was disgusted. I came to see the massive injustice in the system. If you had connections to the president, you could insert your case into the last-minute frenzy. Otherwise, you had to wait for the Justice Department to conduct a review and make a recommendation. In my final weeks in office, I resolved that I would not pardon anyone who went outside the formal channels.”

Vice-President Dick Cheney pressed Bush to grant clemency to Cheney’s former chief of staff I. Lewis (Scooter) Libby, who had been convicted of perjury and obstructing an investigation into the leak of the identity of a covert C.I.A. officer. “We don’t want to leave anyone on the battlefield,” Cheney argued. Bush commuted Libby’s sentence shortly before Libby was to report to prison, saying that the thirty-month term was “excessive.” But, to Cheney’s great displeasure, Bush balked at granting a full pardon. (That move was left to Trump, in 2018. “I don’t know Mr. Libby,” he said, “but for years I have heard that he has been treated unfairly.”) Bush took the extraordinary step of cancelling a pardon, which he’d given the day before to a New York real-estate developer. He said he had not known that the recipient’s father had contributed more than thirty thousand dollars to Republicans. “It raises the appearance of impropriety, so the President

prudently decided not to go through with the pardon," the White House press secretary Dana Perino said at the time.

For all that, recent Presidents can be faulted as much for their stingy exercise of the pardon power as for its deployment. Oyer, the former pardon attorney, described arriving at her office at seven on the morning of Trump's second Inauguration, prepared to process Biden's final pardons and commutations, only to find a disappointingly short list of cases. "I had expected to see more names in there, people who were really deserving," she said. "It was really absolutely gutting to see how many people were left behind." Although Biden issued a record number of commutations—more than four thousand—his total of eighty pardons was the second lowest on record, according to an analysis by the Pew Research Center. Only George H. W. Bush granted fewer, seventy-four in all.

Mark Osler, a law professor at the University of St. Thomas, in Minneapolis, oversees a clemency clinic there, supervising a half-dozen law students as they pursue commutations and pardons. Osler developed an interest in clemency after serving as a federal prosecutor in Detroit during the late nineties. His caseload was heavy with crack-cocaine prosecutions that carried long mandatory minimum sentences and fell disproportionately on African American defendants. The punitive approach, he came to believe, conflicted with his Christian faith, in particular the admonition in John 8:7: "Let he who is without sin cast the first stone." He told me, "I felt the weight of the stone in my hand. I put it down and walked away and did mercy."

Osler's clinic is currently seeking a commutation for an eighty-three-year-old Texas man who was sentenced to life in prison without parole, in 1985, for helping run a drug ring. He's confined to a wheelchair and recently suffered a stroke, but his crimes occurred so long ago that he is not eligible for compassionate release. Another client, this one seeking a pardon, is a Kentucky woman who was sentenced to fifty-seven months, in 1996, for nonviolent drug crimes. She was released in 2001 and has been unable to receive licenses for several professions, including as a physical therapist and a real-estate agent, because of rules that exclude convicted felons.

Osler has watched with increasing frustration as his clients' petitions go unanswered. He described the pardon attorney as "a zombie office, in the sense that they're assigning numbers to cases that come in, but it's not clear that anything's happening beyond that." Rather than receiving good or bad news for clients, Osler said, "you simply don't hear. There's no up, and there's no down. And so, when they call from prison or they write, I have to tell them it's pending. But, really, that means it's being ignored."

When I asked Osler which pardons bothered him most, he said, "It's those that have gone to the people who are fabulously wealthy—these are the people who have been advantaged by so much. With my students, we've told the stories of people who are fabulously poor and are being ignored." Clemency, Osler continued, "has begun to take the form that the worst parts of government have already had, which is to be dominated by lobbying. It's been O.K., if you are a polluter, to hire people who are connected to the President to inveigh on your behalf and pay them tons of money. That wasn't how clemency worked. But now that kind of ugly fog has floated over to what's supposed to be about mercy." ♦

Ruth Marcus, a former columnist for the Washington Post, became a contributing writer at The New Yorker in June, 2025. She is the author of "Supreme Ambition: Brett Kavanaugh and the Conservative Takeover."

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Profiles

Attention Must Be Paid

How Scott Rudin turned Laurie Metcalf into the First Lady of American Theatre.

By Michael Schulman

April 27, 2026

“I want the characters I play to be strong,” Metcalf says. “I want them to be funny, and I want them to be mean and mad sometimes.”Photograph by Paola Kudacki for The New Yorker

Somewhere in the bowels of Lincoln Center, Laurie Metcalf was in a rehearsal room, quietly conferring with the director Joe Mantello. It was February, days before the new Broadway revival of Arthur Miller’s “Death of a Salesman” would move into the Winter Garden Theatre. Four weeks into rehearsals, the cast—led by Nathan Lane, as the delusional, doomed salesman Willy Loman—was still refining the Loman family’s implosion. Metcalf, playing Willy’s enabling wife, Linda, had read the play in high

school but had purposefully avoided ever seeing a production. “I thought maybe down the line I’d be able to play the part, so I didn’t want somebody’s performance in my head,” she explained. The same went for Martha in “Who’s Afraid of Virginia Woolf?” and Mary Tyrone in “Long Day’s Journey Into Night”—characters that Metcalf had tackled in the past decade and a half. “I stayed away from bucket-list-type roles, just in case,” she said, then let out a hearty laugh. “And now, in my dotage—here they come!”

Metcalf’s turn as a Broadway eminence was far from assured. Since the nineteen-eighties, TV audiences have known her as the rootless, rubbery Aunt Jackie, from the sitcom “Roseanne.” The more stage-savvy know her as a charter member of Steppenwolf Theatre Company, the red-blooded Chicago troupe that emerged in the seventies and launched such talents as John Malkovich, Gary Sinise, and Joan Allen. In 2017 and 2018, Metcalf won back-to-back Tony Awards, for Lucas Hnath’s “A Doll’s House, Part 2” and Edward Albee’s “Three Tall Women”; she was simultaneously nominated for an Oscar, for her role in Greta Gerwig’s film “Lady Bird.” She was hailed as the new First Lady of American Theatre, a moniker once given to Helen Hayes. In the *Times*, Ben Brantley wrote that Metcalf had attained the stage career “that Meryl Streep might have had, had she not abandoned Broadway for Hollywood.”

None of this acclamation has imbued Metcalf with grandeur. At seventy, she remains a workhorse. She excels at playing women with hardened exteriors, rough edges, and working-class muscle—salt-of-the-earth people, with extra salt. That is certainly true of her Linda Loman. At Lincoln Center, Metcalf was dressed simply, in jeans and a worn “Three Tall Women” hoodie. (“Her wardrobe is made up of merch from shows she’s done,” Mantello observed.) The cast, which that morning had sat through mandatory harassment training—“So, there’s that,” Metcalf said, flatly—included Christopher Abbott and Ben Ahlers, as Willy and Linda’s deadbeat sons, Biff and Happy. They took their places for a climactic scene in Act II in which Linda berates her sons for their shoddy treatment of their father, who is crawling in the dirt outside, his mind unravelling, planting a garden in the middle of the night. Mantello has done away with the naturalistic kitchen-sink set; in the rehearsal room, a plywood box stood in for a red

1964 Chevy that would dominate the stage. In the scene, Linda tosses aside a bouquet of flowers which her sons have bought to appease her and yells, “Get out of my sight.” Metcalf gave the line a venomous hiss, before raising her voice to a shriek. “I got too hot too fast,” she told Mantello afterward, rescoring Linda’s emotional melody.

Nathan Lane, who plays Willy Loman in “Salesman,” was eager to have Metcalf in the role of his wife, Linda: “I knew that she would find this strength and fierce protectiveness toward Willy, and that it wouldn’t be sentimental in any way.”Photograph by Emilio Madrid

The scene was interrupted when one of Lane’s prop seed bags burst, spilling everywhere, and the cast devolved into hysterics. Lane, turning hammy, bellowed, “I’m hoping to have an entire salad come the spring!” Clowning around, Metcalf and Ahlers went into a little bowlegged hop. Then it was back to work. I sat behind a table, next to a man in a brown sweater who watched intently through wire-rimmed glasses. It was the producer Scott Rudin, who, more than anyone, is responsible for Metcalf’s prolific third

act. In 2021, amid allegations that he had bullied his staff (abusive tirades, thrown office supplies), Rudin stepped back from his career as a pugnacious Broadway titan with exquisite taste. After a four-year exile, he returned, last fall, with Samuel D. Hunter's play "Little Bear Ridge Road," starring Metcalf as a hard-bitten Idaho nurse. By doing "Salesman," she was doubling down on their partnership, even though Rudin remains a controversial figure in the business.

As they continued the scene, Metcalf experimented with the grace notes of her performance: how much force to give the line "Shake his hand, Willy," whether to embrace Biff at a conciliatory moment. "As a mother, it's killing her to have to tell the oldest son to leave and never come back," she told me after the rehearsal, explaining the hug. "It was just a thought. It's like carving, chipping away, to uncover the storytelling. What are the odds that I'm going to keep it or lose it? I don't know."

Arthur Miller described Linda Loman as "a woman who looked as though she had lived in a house dress all her life." Metcalf seems more like a woman who was born wearing a sweatshirt, as she was when we met for lunch. She brought her "Salesman" script—a loose pile of hole-punched pages, with notes pencilled in the margins. Linda has traditionally been played as a soft, doting figure blinded by admiration for her husband, in all his busted braggadocio. But Metcalf has stripped the honey from Linda's denial while giving her an ornery shrewdness, especially when it comes to the family's finances. Her Linda is like the household C.F.O.: she knows where every penny goes, even as Willy's earning power has sputtered.

"The thing I remember is her being described as a doormat," Metcalf said. "I immediately thought of that as a challenge. Does she have to be? And, if she isn't, what is she? I'm dedicating myself to the opposite of that, because I want the characters I play to be strong. I want them to be funny, and I want them to be mean and mad sometimes. So it starts off with a bunch of what-ifs. What if I *don't* 'tremble with sorrow and joy,' which is a stage direction?"

“Are you sure the book has a red spine?”
Cartoon by Amy Hwang

Metcalf had disregarded all of Miller’s stage directions, not to mention his punctuation. She’d scribbled question marks at the end of the line “You called him crazy,” because it made more sense to her as a question. Her Linda, far from naïve, is frustrated by what she doesn’t know, including an incident years earlier that drove a wedge between Biff and Willy, when Biff caught his father with a mistress on the road. “The rift is so infuriating to her because she can’t figure it out, and it’s damaging the whole family,” Metcalf said. Without turning Linda into what Roseanne Barr might call a domestic goddess, she was bringing the character up to date. “I didn’t even want to come out carrying the laundry basket,” she said—but the laundry is referenced in the dialogue, so she was stuck with it.

“What Laurie has found is that this woman is not fragile. In fact, she’s formidable,” Mantello told me. “She’s not there to be deferential to Willy. She’s his equal partner, and that all came from Laurie.” The first time Mantello talked to Lane about doing “Salesman” was in the mid-nineties, when they worked on the gay drama “Love! Valour! Compassion!” “I was surprised,” Lane said, “because I was probably wearing an apron and high heels at the time.” Lane approached Metcalf about joining him after seeing her in a 2015 production of Miller’s “All My Sons” in East Hampton. “I knew that she would find this strength and fierce protectiveness toward Willy, and that it wouldn’t be sentimental in any way,” he said.

Metcalf isn't precious about her process. Mantello, who has directed her on Broadway eight times, said, "She has a Midwestern practicality and no-nonsense approach to the work. Nothing's fussy. Nothing's indulgent." Metcalf told me, "I do a lot of daydreaming in the shower. As soon as I know I'm going to play a part, as I'm learning the lines, I walk down the street talking to myself like a crazy person." Her technique is rooted in mastery of the text. Once a show is up, she'll get to the theatre early and run through the entire play by herself.

She loves props, which she'll occasionally add to a scene. In "Salesman," Biff invites Willy out to dinner at a steak house. (In her script, she wrote "so fancy" next to the restaurant's name.) Metcalf decided to deliver the message from Biff to Willy with a slip of paper—hard evidence that her son respects his father after all. Greta Gerwig, who directed Metcalf in "Lady Bird," as Marion, a hospital worker and the withholding mother of a Sacramento teen, recalled, "I have a specific memory of Laurie having an idea of Marion giving her co-workers gifts for their children all the time—that she is deeply caring and connected but can't figure out how to reach her own daughter. It wasn't in the script, but it was such a brilliant and specific flourish that made the character come alive."

In the new Netflix series "Big Mistakes," created by Dan Levy and Rachel Sennott, Metcalf plays a high-strung hardware-store owner running for mayor after her elderly mother dies of cancer. "At one point in the hospital scenes, she was saying, 'Can I have a little Tupperware container of lettuce? I just feel like I would have brought a salad,' " Levy, who plays her son, told me. "We were, like, O.K., we get Laurie Metcalf a salad. 'Do you want it dressed?' 'No, I want dry lettuce. It's funnier.' " Around the time Levy thought of casting Metcalf, he saw an old clip from "Roseanne" online: Jackie, informing relatives by phone that her father has died, winds up screaming "*Dad's dead!* " to an aunt who's hard of hearing. "The timing of that comedy and the aggression of the performance—it was lawless. It was so free," Levy said. "Big Mistakes" opens with Metcalf's character hollering at her bedridden mother,"*You had an accident. We cleaned ya up*."

In Steppenwolf's 1979 production of "The Glass Menagerie," Metcalf played Laura less as a shut-in with a limp than as a psychologically impaired young woman who, like Tennessee Williams's real-life sister, would wind up lobotomized.Photograph by Lisa Howe-Ebright

Collaborators often praise Metcalf for her "fearlessness" and "lack of vanity," which is another way of saying that she's happy being plain or prickly. Her face, lined and unprimped, can deftly reveal a character's grit or careworn fatigue. John Malkovich, one of her Steppenwolf compatriots, mentioned her willingness to "punish the audience": "People recognize their own lack of comfort or solace in the world, their own outsiderness, their own vulnerabilities and frailties—and then she can rub them in your face." The playwright Lucas Hnath worked with her on "A Doll's House, Part 2," his ballsy sequel to the Henrik Ibsen classic, and "Hillary and Clinton," his equally ballsy take on the 2008 Presidential primary, in which Metcalf played the beleaguered senator from New York. Hnath recalled her, as Ibsen's Nora, manspreading in her period frock. "She's a 3-D-printer actor. I can say how I want a moment to work, and she does it immediately," he said, then added, "Has anybody talked about her love of stage vomiting?"

A self-described hermit, Metcalf has a monastic aversion to the trappings of fame. Her house in Los Angeles, which she shares with her dog, Connie, is furnished from Target and *IKEA*. "I don't want to own anything that I have to worry about if it gets broken or peed on," she told me. "I also like my surroundings to be very sparse." After two marriages and four children, she is an empty nester. "I love being alone," she said. Despite her four Emmys—three for "Roseanne" and one for a guest role on "Hacks"—awards shows don't interest her. She usually slips out after her category and watches the rest in pajamas, as she did at the Oscars when she was

nominated for “Lady Bird.” “I do like the work, though,” she said. “The other part will come and go—the fame—but I’ll always have the work part. That’s lucky.”

At times, her modesty approaches self-denial. Her oldest daughter, Zoe Perry, who is also an actress (she and Metcalf play the same character at different ages on the sitcoms “Young Sheldon” and “The Big Bang Theory,” respectively), recalled, “I once watched her belabor a decision on whether or not to buy herself a four-dollar comb at a Duane Reade, because she was, like, ‘I just don’t know if I need it right now.’ ” This was after “Roseanne,” when she was primarily doing theatre—but nine seasons on a hit sitcom would keep her rich with residuals. Her daughter pleaded, “Are you out of your mind?” She didn’t get the comb.

Perhaps Metcalf’s one indulgence is an eighty-acre ranch in Idaho that she bought in the nineties, during “Roseanne.” “I was making money for the first time in my life,” she said, “and I thought, Geez, what do people do? Get a summer home?” At one point, she was raising goats and donkeys, and a vet showed her how to do a pregnancy check on her cow. Explaining this to me, she mimed reaching an arm into the unfazed animal and feeling for the fetal calf’s nose.

She also kept sheep, whose wool she learned to spin. One spring morning, I met her at Knitty City, a yarn store on the Upper West Side. She was starting a new knitting project, for her offstage time at “Salesman.” She likes to listen to the play in the wings while doing yoga or studying German, which she took in high school. (One of her goals is to do a play in Germany.) “It’s freezing back there, so I have two sweaters on, a heated blanket, and a German book—there’s a visual for ya!” she said. She likes to knit because “it’s very meditative and uses the senses. You have to get the tension right.”

“I need to make a baby gift,” she told the shop’s owner. (Christopher Abbott, her co-star, is having a baby with Aubrey Plaza.) “It can’t be a very detailed pattern, because I’m sitting backstage during a show.” He led her to a shelf of wool. “That’s crazy cute,” she said, eying a white yarn with flecks of color that looked like confetti. She presented her Knitty City loyalty card and bought four skeins and a pair of knitting needles.

“I know I told you the macaroni salad was gonna be your last job, but I need you to hold half a tomato for a month.”
Cartoon by Michael J. Johnson

Metcalf learned to knit from her grandmother while growing up in Edwardsville, Illinois. “I was very shy,” she recalled, over brunch around the corner. Her father was a comptroller at Southern Illinois University, and her mother was a sometime librarian who mostly stayed home to raise the kids. Metcalf is the oldest of three. I asked what her siblings do now and was surprised to see her eyes fill with tears. When Metcalf was nine, she said, her seven-year-old sister was badly injured in a car accident. She remains in assisted living in their home town, where her brother has stayed to oversee her care. How had the upheaval affected her? “I guess it made me withdraw some, protect myself,” she said, softly. She paused and added, “It probably gave me a lot of walls.” Her voice cracked on the last word, and I thought of all her characters who put up psychic walls. I also wondered whether Metcalf’s frugality had a whiff of survivor’s guilt.

Her life in Edwardsville had only glimmers of performance. As a child, she’d charge her neighbors to watch her rock on a swing set in time to “When the Red, Red Robin (Comes Bob, Bob, Bobbin’ Along).” When she was a junior in high school, the drama department was doing “Auntie Mame,” and she had a three-line part. “I accidentally got a laugh on a line, which I didn’t intend,” she recalled. “But something about my delivery, in all its innocence, I think, was funny. And then: *Boom*. Hooked.” She enrolled in Illinois State University, planning to study German and anthropology. “It was when I met kids at college that I realized there was a world out there,” she said. She’d been so sheltered that some of the students

spoke in what sounded to her like a foreign accent. They were from Chicago.

During her sophomore year, she acted in a student production of Joe Orton's "What the Butler Saw." Terry Kinney, a junior, saw it and thought that she was "otherworldly good," with the comic chops of Lucille Ball, he recounted. Kinney introduced her to his friends Gary Sinise and Jeff Perry, who had gone to high school together in the Chicago suburb of Highland Park and were staging plays under the name Steppenwolf. The group was about to move into an eighty-eight-seat church-school basement there. "They knew they needed some women," Metcalf said. That summer, she joined them for an evening of one-acts, appearing with Perry in what she called a "misguided" production of Harold Pinter's "The Lover." ("Jeff had a mustache glued on. I learned how to smoke.") The Steppenwolf guys idolized John Cassavetes and tried to channel the vitality of his films onto the stage. "We wanted the audience to fear that we might spill out on them," Kinney said. "We were in a tiny little theatre, and the action—especially violence—always got perilously close to the audience."

"We liked stuff with shock value," Metcalf recalled. "We never thought twice about doing things that were inappropriate or ugly or controversial. Maybe that couldn't happen again. We could be that way because we weren't beholden to anybody, let alone somebody's money." Steppenwolf's ethos was based on the ensemble; no one was the star, and the actors would prod one another to greatness. "We were trying to entertain each other, trying to peacock for each other," she said. Metcalf earned the nickname Mechano, because she had the quickness of "a stenographic machine," Perry said. He marvelled at her range, which ran from "unadorned dramatic work" to "Tom-and-Jerry buffoonery."

For Steppenwolf's "Balm in Gilead," Metcalf delivered a nearly twenty-minute monologue that the Times called a "tour de force."Photograph by Lisa Howe-Ebright

It was raw, do-it-yourself theatre. "Somebody had to clean the bathroom. Somebody had to take the tickets, which were three dollars," Metcalf remembered. "We went to the thrift store, made our own costumes. I still have that urge to this day—'Oh, I have a toaster at home! I can just bring it in!' " Working a secretarial job at Chicago's St. Nicholas Theatre, she swiped its mailing list so that Steppenwolf could target its subscribers. Steppenwolf's self-imposed isolation from Hollywood and New York made it an incubator where the actors could develop their own style: muscular, contemporary, risky. It also enabled a certain incestuousness; Metcalf dated Kinney, then Malkovich, then Perry. "Honest to God, we didn't know anybody else," she said.

After graduating from college with a theatre degree, in 1976, Metcalf remained with Steppenwolf, which was gaining a reputation as a theatrical answer to rock and roll. In 1979, the group staged Tennessee Williams's "The Glass Menagerie," its final play in the basement before moving to

Chicago. Their production drew from Williams's biography. Malkovich played Tom, the playwright's stand-in, as a closeted gay man. Metcalf rendered his sister, Laura, less as a shut-in with a limp than as a psychologically impaired young woman who, like Williams's real-life sister, would wind up lobotomized. She cut her hair into awkward bangs and "tried to play a shyness that was uncomfortable to other people," she said. Malkovich recalled, "I couldn't really watch her scenes. They were too sad." The production brought Steppenwolf attention, and Metcalf won Chicago's prestigious theatre award, the Jeff.

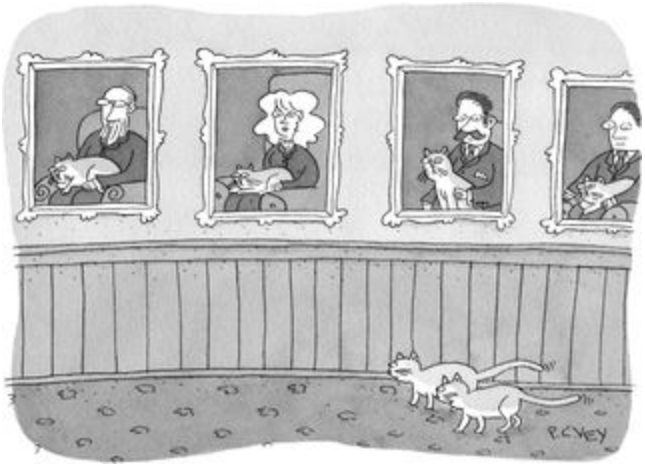
Inevitably, Hollywood started poaching the young actors. Malkovich booked the film "The Killing Fields" after he and Sinise starred in Steppenwolf's breakout production of "True West." In 1981, Metcalf was acting in the company's version of George Bernard Shaw's "Arms and the Man" when she got an offer to join "Saturday Night Live." (Tim Kazurinsky, a writer and cast member at the show, had recommended her.) This was the disastrous season in which Lorne Michaels had been replaced as producer by Jean Doumanian, who was quickly replaced by Dick Ebersol. Metcalf flew to New York—her first time on a plane—to be in one episode. "It was such a blur," she recalled. "I immediately didn't fit in." She appeared in a single, pretaped sketch, asking people on the street if they'd take a bullet for the President. (Ronald Reagan had just been shot.) After a writers' strike curtailed the season, most of the cast was fired, and Metcalf returned to Chicago.

She was back in New York in 1984, when Steppenwolf transferred its production of Lanford Wilson's "Balm in Gilead" to Off Broadway's Circle Rep. The play is set at an all-night coffee shop on upper Broadway, a way station for drifters, junkies, and prostitutes. For much of the show, the thirty-odd-person cast talks in an overlapping cacophony, to which Malkovich, who directed, added swells of Tom Waits and Bruce Springsteen. In Act II, the action settles on Metcalf's character, Darlene, a bubbly, wide-eyed transplant from Chicago, as she tells another patron an aimless story about getting a marriage license with her albino fiancé. The monologue lasts nearly twenty minutes. Toward the end, Darlene's birdbrained prattle takes a heartrending turn, as it becomes clear that the

marriage never happened and she was left, as Malkovich put it, “lost without knowing at all how lost she is.”

Steppenwolf first staged the play in 1980, in Chicago. Malkovich knew a salesgirl with an “alarming Chicago accent,” he said, and asked Metcalf to study her. “Nowadays, you’d have your dialect coach,” she told me. “I went with a little tape recorder and recorded this coat-store saleswoman.” As Malkovich recalled, Metcalf declined to rehearse the monologue until just before the first preview, and it emerged fully formed. The play was a watershed success for the company. When it moved to New York, Metcalf’s scene became a sensation. In the *Times*, Frank Rich called it a “tour de force.” Mantello, then fresh out of drama school, said that it “shifted the way I thought about acting.”

Recently, I went to the New York Public Library for the Performing Arts and watched the play on tape. Even on grainy video, I could see why the monologue was so mesmerizing. As Darlene, Metcalf happily blathers on, occasionally stirring her coffee, until the recollection of one tiny detail—finding the never-used marriage license in a drawer, a crease down its center—overwhelms her, and she sinks her head in her hand. Remembering it, Malkovich invoked Waits’s lyric about “a wound that will never heal.”



“I come from a long line of cats.”
Cartoon by P. C. Vey

By then, Metcalf was twenty-nine and had married Perry, after becoming pregnant with Zoe. While Metcalf performed the play every night, she’d leave her five-month-old daughter with a babysitting service. “Talk about

being a struggling actor," she recalled. "You're not making anything and have a newborn, but you're in a hit show." Four decades later, people still stop her on the street and talk about "Balm in Gilead." Among those who saw it were a pair of casting agents who put Metcalf in two projects. One was her first movie, "Desperately Seeking Susan," as a flashy suburbanite. The other was "Roseanne."

The executive producers of "The Cosby Show" Marcy Carsey and Tom Werner had wanted to build a sitcom around a working-class mother, and they devised "Roseanne," to bottle Roseanne Barr's winningly crude standup act. Barr played a version of herself, a wisecracking blue-collar mom named Roseanne Conner. When Metcalf auditioned, nothing had been written yet for Roseanne's sister, Jackie, so she read some of Roseanne's lines and got the part. She was initially hesitant about doing a sitcom. "I thought, Oh, my God, I'm going to be typecast for the rest of my life," she said. Yet she moved to L.A.; she and Perry had split up, but he came along to help raise Zoe. (Perry later found fame on "Nash Bridges" and "Scandal.")

Metcalf said, of meeting Barr, "I was intimidated by her, because she was self-made." But they got along well, and their onscreen chemistry was instant. Where Barr's character was deadpan and bullish, Jackie was overreactive and needy, forever bouncing among boyfriends and careers. "On the page was a very strong sister relationship, which Roseanne has in real life," Metcalf said. "So my jumping-off point was to try to show that bond and then hit the jokes." In the first season, Roseanne and Jackie work in a plastics factory. (George Clooney played their boss and Jackie's love interest. "I miss his practical jokes," Metcalf said. "He was sort of the life of the party.") Neither actress was versed in sitcoms, but Metcalf had her co-star's back. John Goodman, who played Roseanne's husband, told me, "In the beginning, she called herself a tugboat, because she pulled Roseanne onto her marks."

The show premièred on ABC in October, 1988; by its second season, it topped the Nielsen ratings. Metcalf didn't realize how big it was until she was back in Chicago and got recognized at the zoo. Behind the scenes, "Roseanne" was legendarily rocky. Barr, enraged that the writer-producer

Matt Williams was credited as the creator, stonewalled him until ABC ousted him. Showrunners would come and go. Barr installed Tom Arnold, her new husband, as a producer, and their antics filled the tabloids. At one point, Barr had “Property of Tom Arnold” tattooed on her buttocks.

Roseanne Barr and Metcalf on the set of “Roseanne,” in 1993. In 2018, a reboot of the show was cancelled after Barr issued an offensive tweet.Photograph from ABC Photo Archives / Getty

Metcalf defended Barr’s push for authority. “I saw somebody refusing to settle for anything, and it had her goddam name on it, and she knew what she wanted,” she told me. “And I saw her being right by far the majority of the time.” The cast, she insisted, was mostly insulated from the drama. Goodman said, “As many difficulties as we had on the show, Laurie was my lodestar. She was solid gravity. She just rode the waves during a lot of that shit.” As the seasons went on, the writers played to Metcalf’s strengths, including physical comedy. “She used to compare herself to Don Knotts, and she pulled these Knottsian faces,” Goodman said. But the show made a point of tackling real problems—mortgage payments, birth control, and a subplot in which Jackie has an abusive boyfriend. (The actor who played him, Matt Roth, became Metcalf’s second husband; they divorced in 2014.) Sara Gilbert, who played Metcalf’s niece, said, “She can be completely absurd, but you don’t stop believing her.”

“Roseanne” concluded in 1997, after an ill-advised final season in which the Conners win the lottery. In 2018, the cast reunited for a tenth season, with Gilbert as an executive producer. Jackie was now a Jill Stein voter in a pussy hat, while Roseanne had voted for Donald Trump. In an America riven by the 2016 election and newly fascinated with the politics of the white working class, the revival was a smash; even Trump called Barr to

congratulate her. But Barr's real-life politics had slipped into QAnon territory. A week after the finale, she came under fire for a tweet comparing Barack Obama's former adviser Valerie Jarrett to an ape, and the show was abruptly cancelled.

Metcalf learned of the cancellation from a news chyron while she was in New York starring in "Three Tall Women." She'd been on a high from the reunion and hadn't noticed a change in Barr. That fall, ABC revived the show as "The Conners," which follows the family after its matriarch dies of an opioid overdose. (The real Roseanne tweeted furiously, "I AIN'T DEAD, BITCHES!!!!") Metcalf was the last cast member to sign on. "We'd all had a personal relationship with Roseanne, and it was just not an easy decision for Laurie, or any of us," Gilbert said.

"There was just a general sadness around the whole place," Metcalf told me. Nevertheless, "The Conners" ran for seven seasons. Metcalf has not been in touch with Barr. "There's nothing controversial," she said. "We just haven't spoken since we said goodbye at the end of the reboot." Asked if she was angry at Barr for blowing up her own show, Metcalf laughed ruefully and replied, "I don't even know how to answer that."

During the original run of "Roseanne," Metcalf built up a sporadic but memorable film career, appearing in "JFK" and "Scream 2" and voicing Andy's mother in "Toy Story." But she longed to get back to theatre. She had returned to Steppenwolf during summer breaks from "Roseanne," and in 1995 made her belated Broadway début, in a flop called "My Thing of Love." The *Times* review praised Metcalf but compared the script to "the very long mid-section of a sitcom episode." Metcalf sensed a stigma. "I kind of had a target on me," she said. "Like, 'Let's see if this TV actor can do theatre'—even though I had done a lot."

Metcalf didn't return to Broadway until 2007, as a White House speechwriter in David Mamet's political satire "November," directed by Mantello and starring Nathan Lane as the President. Nearly a decade later, having played a hospital administrator on the bleak HBO comedy "Getting On," she joined a workshop of Hnath's "A Doll's House, Part 2." It was her first stage collaboration with Scott Rudin, the high-powered producer of such films as "The Social Network" and "No Country for Old Men." In

Hnath's imagining, Nora Helmer, who walks out on her family at the end of Ibsen's 1879 drama, returns years later, a successful novelist. "Internal to every sentence was a remarkable amount of buried narrative, so it needed somebody who was thinking of her own story as she was essentially describing it," Rudin told me. "I felt there was nobody but Laurie who could make a line mean so many different things."

Scott Rudin in 2025. After stepping away from his producing career amid allegations of bullying and abuse, he has staked his Broadway comeback on three productions starring Metcalf, whom he calls "the greatest actress in America."Photograph by Erik Tanner

He sent Hnath an episode of Louis C.K.'s web series, "Horace and Pete," in which Metcalf, playing Horace's ex-wife, delivers an astonishing monologue about having exposed herself to her elderly father-in-law. (C.K.'s penchant for erotic exposure was revealed soon afterward.) "I was floored," Hnath recalled. "It was really important to me to have a real theatre creature do this, because you have to move through the language relentlessly." Rudin was also producing "Lady Bird" and suggested Metcalf to Gerwig, who told me that she'd wanted the character to be funny but "fierce in her love, her morals, and her person."

The acclaim in 2017 for both projects launched a new phase for Metcalf. She starred in "Three Tall Women" the next year, and then "Hillary and Clinton" a year later. Both were produced by Rudin. Hnath had originally written "Hillary and Clinton" in 2008, but Rudin asked him to do a revision. "I sent it over, and he was, like, 'O.K., great. Let's send it to Laurie,' " the playwright recalled. The next season, Rudin mounted a revival of "Who's Afraid of Virginia Woolf?," with Metcalf as Martha and Rupert Everett as

George. Albee's fearsome antiheroine seemed like the ultimate Metcalf role, though Mantello, who directed, recalled her struggling with Martha's seductive side. It was March, 2020. Broadway's first known case of *COVID* was a "Virginia Woolf" usher. The show shut down after nine previews and never returned. By the time Broadway reopened, Rudin had been drummed out of show business.

Rudin's mistreatment of his staff was no secret. As far back as 1994, when he was producing movies for Paramount, horror stories about him partly inspired the indie revenge thriller "Swimming with Sharks," with Kevin Spacey as a nightmare Hollywood boss. But the #MeToo era cast the lore in a harsher light. In April, 2021, *The Hollywood Reporter* published a cover story headlined "*BULLY*," cataloguing tales of alleged abuse from Rudin's revolving door of young assistants. The incidents included screamed invective ("You're worth nothing!") and hurled objects: a glass bowl, a stapler, a baked potato, a teacup. After one assistant failed to get him a seat on a fully booked flight, Rudin smashed a computer monitor on the man's hand, resulting in a trip to the emergency room. "Everyone just knows he's an absolute monster," a former assistant said.

More stories came out, including that of Kevin Graham-Caso, who'd sought treatment for P.T.S.D. after assisting Rudin in the two-thousands. Years later, he died by suicide. His twin brother believed that Graham-Caso's eight months in Rudin's office had contributed to his mental-health decline. Rudin reportedly had forced him out of a car while driving, and Graham-Caso had e-mailed a friend, "I think the time at Rudin permanently fucked my nerves." Besieged by exposés, Rudin announced that he was "profoundly sorry for the pain my behavior caused" and that he would "step back from active participation" on his Broadway shows, which included the hits "To Kill a Mockingbird" and "The Book of Mormon."

Rudin retreated to Long Island. During his hiatus, it was not uncommon to hear theatre people express regret about his absence. Broadway was flailing after the pandemic, and not many producers had Rudin's knack for turning an edgy new play into a splashy, must-see event. In 2024, Rudin sent up a trial balloon, advising the media mogul Barry Diller on arts programming for Little Island, Diller's outdoor attraction on the Hudson River. Few

objected. Last March, Rudin gave a comeback interview to the *Times*, saying that he had undergone “a decent amount of therapy.” A photo showed him looking contrite in a cozy sweater. “A lot of what was said was true. Some of what was said wasn’t true,” he told the *Times*. (He acknowledged yelling at assistants but said that he threw things “very, very rarely.”) Then he laid out a slate of four planned Broadway plays, three of which would star Metcalf, whom he called “the greatest actress in America.”

When I asked Metcalf about her decision to work with Rudin again, she fumbled for words before taking a piece of notebook paper from her fanny pack. She had reread his *Times* interview and jotted down notes. “He talked about his therapy, he apologized, he owned what he said, he reflected on it,” she said, haltingly. “He was in the process of rehabilitation. So I just think that, unless we think there is no possibility of real rehabilitation, then we shouldn’t ask people to try and do it.” She sighed, unsure of herself. “I knew you would ask me at some point. It’s so touchy. It’s so hard.”

“Little Bear Ridge Road” was originally commissioned by Steppenwolf, which premièred it in Chicago in 2024, starring Metcalf. Rudin offered to bring it to New York as his first Broadway show after the self-imposed exile, but Steppenwolf declined to work with him.

“It didn’t feel in alignment with our values and mission that he would come back on Steppenwolf’s name,” someone involved with the theatre company told me. “In a precarious moment where we were rebuilding back from the pandemic, why would we partner with someone who the industry felt really harmed by? We can’t be a vehicle for someone to prove that they’ve changed.” When Steppenwolf pressed him on how he’d reformed, the person I spoke to recalled, Rudin “never made us feel that he had done the work.”

Scott Rudin compares Metcalf to "a Kazan actress—that sort of full, fleshy, remarkably bright ability to play women who would normally be overlooked but somehow elbow their way to the front of your perception."Photograph by Paola Kudacki for The New Yorker; Styling by Daniel Edley; Hair and Makeup by Taylor Levitan

At first, Metcalf was open to finding another producer to bring the play to Broadway, but none materialized. Steppenwolf, still refusing to partner with Rudin, held firm. Metcalf was distraught; she wanted the play to have a future. Caught between her longtime theatrical home and her most powerful champion, she took the extraordinary step of threatening to quit Steppenwolf unless it relinquished the rights. The theatre, facing the defection of one of its most prominent members, took this as an ultimatum. In the end, Steppenwolf agreed to release the rights, clearing the way for Rudin to make his return to Broadway. When "Little Bear" arrived in New York, last fall, Steppenwolf was acknowledged in a note in the *Playbill*, but the names above the title were Scott Rudin and Barry Diller. The play was critically admired but commercially disappointing, and it closed eight weeks early.

I asked Metcalf about her standoff with Steppenwolf. "I can't really go into that, because that's something I haven't even figured out for myself, my

relationship back there," she said, tearing up. She has not been involved in Steppenwolf's current season, its fiftieth. "I want my own celebration of that, and I want to celebrate it with some of the Old Guard," she went on, crying as she folded up the notebook paper. "I want to go back in time, and I want to be brave with the people who taught me to be brave. I don't want to worry if something is not P.C.—not to trigger people. Just to be daring. Controversial, if it wants to be. Back then, we didn't have to be so scared that we were going to step on somebody's toes and get brought down. We won't call it the fiftieth. We'll call it something else. It'll be like getting the band back together for one last tour, you know?"

When I spoke to Rudin, he was eager to praise Metcalf. "She's able to embody psychology and behavior and make them absolutely spontaneous in any moment," he said, sounding jovial. He compared her to Geraldine Page and Maureen Stapleton, mid-century performers who came out of the Actors Studio, co-founded by the director Elia Kazan: "She's like a Kazan actress—that sort of full, fleshy, remarkably bright ability to play women who would normally be overlooked but somehow elbow their way to the front of your perception." It was one of the most insightful things anyone had told me about Metcalf.

To arrange my call with Rudin, I'd exchanged e-mails with his current assistant. I brought up his name to Metcalf and asked if, given Rudin's past record with assistants, she ever felt a responsibility to check in on the guy. She didn't recognize the name at first, then said, "I don't feel the need to *check in*." Rudin was using her talent to rebuild his reputation, but it's hard to say whether she should have to answer for his sins. She was far from the only person enabling his comeback, yet she had planted her flag in the Rudin camp more definitively than anybody. She contained her tears, still crumpling the notebook page, her prop for this uneasy scene. Then, in a moment of clarity, she looked up and said, "I find it hypocritical that some people want to work with him but didn't want to be the first."

One evening in March, I went to the Winter Garden to see the final run-through of "Death of a Salesman." Looming over the marquee outside was a billboard with the play's most famous line—one of Linda's—spelled out in giant letters: "*Attention must be paid*." It was Rudin's patented prestige

bombast. The Winter Garden seats sixteen hundred people (“Cats” ran there for eighteen years), making it the largest theatre Metcalf has ever played.

Before the run-through began, I sat with Metcalf in the audience. “I don’t consider anything locked down right now,” she said. “It’s all open to experiment.” But she was fairly settled on her final speech. “Salesman” ends with Linda standing at Willy’s grave, after he has crashed his car so that Biff can get a life-insurance payout. She says:

> Forgive me, dear. I can’t cry. I don’t know what it is, but I can’t cry. I don’t understand it. Why did you ever do that? Help me, Willy, I can’t cry. . . . Why did you do it? I search and search and I search, and I can’t understand it, Willy. I made the last payment on the house today. Today, dear. And there’ll be nobody home. We’re free and clear.

In the script, Miller indicates that a sob rises in her throat, and the play ends with her overcome with tears. “I feel like I have permission as the interpreter to cross all those out,” Metcalf said, of the stage directions. She looked only at what Linda says. “I take her at her word that she can’t cry and she’s not quite sure why,” she explained. “I think there’s a lot of emotion going through her, but it doesn’t come out in the form of tears. A lot of talk about how ‘we were this close, and you do *this*?’ There’s betrayal.”

She went up to her dressing room to put on her wig, run her lines, and work on a jigsaw puzzle. The lights went down, and I watched the play from a mostly empty house. The graveyard speech, far from being plaintive, was undergirded by dumbfounded rage. And Metcalf had added a prop: she pulled the deed to the house from her purse, placed it in the dirt, and used her foot to bury it. No tears.

Afterward, I noticed Rudin nearby. That night, an Off Broadway play he was producing had opened downtown, and the raves were pouring in. “We have to get quotes out,” he said, beaming, and urged his press team to work fast. He was back in business.

Metcalf reappeared in a hoodie. “There’s still so much little detail work to be found,” she said; the audience response would tell her a lot. The deed

had been her idea. “I try to think in symbols,” she told me. “So I figured, Why not pull it out?” Throwing it on the grave would have been clichéd, she continued, “so I thought, What is about as anticlimactic as you can get? I set it on the ground and cover it up with dirt.” It was a bold choice, but true to a Linda who had put up a lot of walls. “This is *my* Linda,” Metcalf said. “And there’s no right or wrong ever in acting.” ♦

Michael Schulman, a staff writer, has contributed to The New Yorker since 2006. He is the author of “Oscar Wars: A History of Hollywood in Gold, Sweat, and Tears” and “Her Again: Becoming Meryl Streep.”

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Shouts & Murmurs

- **Ava's Life List**
  By Garry Trudeau | Spring is here, and with it sightings of the Great-Breasted Hausfrau, the Potbellied Galoot, and the Common Nanny.

Shouts & Murmurs

Ava’s Life List

By ***Garry Trudeau***
April 27, 2026

Illustration by Luci Gutiérrez

“I can’t be sure. I don’t want to cheat.”

My current mate may be a little scattered, easily distracted by squirrels, but she’s a stickler when it comes to integrity. No one in our crowd would ever know if she added a sketchy sighting, but *she* would, and she couldn’t live under a cloud of suspicion, even one of her own making. So she removed the Blue-Booted Boob from her list.

“You’re being silly,” I chirped. “You saw that telltale flash of azure . . .”

“Cobalt.”

“Whatever. What else could it have been but a boob in this habitat? Besides, life lists are personal—you don’t have to share them.”

She looked away, disappointed in my lack of support for her principled stand. I reminded her that we were seasonal bonders, that her partner next

spring almost certainly wouldn’t know about her list, but Ava refused to live a lie.

“Look!” I said. “While you’re getting all spun up over nothing, you’re missing a new arrival! As well as breakfast!”

That got her attention. Walking across the lawn carrying a hopper full of seed matter was a spectacular Great-Breasted Hausfrau, identifiable by its distinctive open bathrobe.

“Already on my list,” Ava sniffed. “And the hausfrau leaves behind only milo or red millet—filler seeds. I’m accustomed to black-oil-sunflower seeds.”

That last bit ruffled my crest. It was true that Ava was way above my station, raised as I was in the trunk of an abandoned car on a steady diet of grubs. Protein aside, larvae are gross, and I envied Ava her pampered upbringing as a fledging in a stately barn.

The hausfrau must have heard our chattering, because she peered up into our leafy blind. Ava and I froze. She tried to make us out, but stillness is our strong suit, so she finally turned away. At that moment, we heard the slam of a screen door, and a magnificent Potbellied Galoot heaved into view.

Ava gasped. The galoot had long been on her life list, but the field markings on this particular specimen left her stunned. The molting hairline, the salt-and-pepper stippling around its mandible, the drooping cargo flaps, the cryptic letterforms on his heather-gray chest (“Ask your mother”)— who knew the galoot could present such a stylish display?

Things were looking up. Ava forgot all about the boob that she may or may not have seen, and fluttered down to my branch. Within moments, we were planning the rest of our day.

“How about that rectangular patchwork of lawns we flew over on our way back from wintering?” she tweeted. “It was teeming with life.”

I'd never heard Ava use the word "teeming" before, so my curiosity was piqued.

"Lead the way," I replied, and off we flew to the rectangular patchwork of lawns. It was easily recognizable by the flocks of pigeons that such habitats attract, but it was, of course, the bipeds that made the trip worthwhile. We picked a statue with good sight lines and floated down to watch the show.

We had a field day, Ava and I. Every variety imaginable seemed to be out and about enjoying the spring weather. Ava must have added a dozen sightings to her life list, each more impressive than the last. There was the Crested Creative, resplendent with its wax-sculpted tuft of hair; the Full-Throated Jessica, known for its signature cry ("*lemme-speak-to-your-manager-ger-ger*"); and the Urban Puffer Vest, once native to the Northwest and now seemingly everywhere.

Ava had a laugh on spotting the last of these. Earlier this spring, we had feathered our nest with the down from a discarded puffer vest, and such is its softness and loft that all our chicks have refused to leave home! Hilarious.

After a while, we lost the self-consciousness of the tourists we were and glided down to the park benches, where a bonded pair of Metropolitan Mensches were distributing popcorn to the pigeons. No one seemed to mind our presence, so while I happily pecked away in the dirt Ava watched the passing parade for new additions to her life list. Among them, she later reported with throaty excitement, were the Flat-Footed Thugcatcher, the gossipy Common Nanny, and the swanning Lesser Hipster, with its distinctive slim-cut silhouette.

Later that evening, when we returned to the nest, the chicks were gone.

It couldn't have been a better day. ♦

Garry Trudeau is the creator of the comic strip "Doonesbury." He won the 1975 Pulitzer Prize for editorial cartooning.

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Fiction

- **“Process of Elimination”**
  By Saïd Sayrafiezadeh | The night the tip jar went missing, we assumed that it had been stolen by a student, or maybe a professor—an adjunct—who had taken it when we weren’t looking.

Fiction

Process of Elimination

By Saïd Sayrafiezadeh

April 26, 2026

Illustration by Jake Hollings

Someone must have been telling lies about me because when I came in for my shift this morning, I found out I was going to be fired for stealing the tip jar.

“That’s what they’re saying,” Melissa told me.

“Who’s ‘they’?” I asked.

She didn’t know. She was speaking under her breath, trying not to make eye contact, trying to look busy arranging muffins in the display case while the video camera stared down at us.

It just so happened that exactly a month had passed since the tip jar had gone missing, and next week it would be a month since a terrorist attack at the Boston Marathon, two states away, had killed three people and injured hundreds more. These events were, of course, unrelated.

What was *not* unrelated, at least for me, was that I shared the same first name, by sheer coincidence, with Tamerlan Tsarnaev, who, along with his younger brother, had carried out the deadly bombing. Other than the name, though, we had nothing whatsoever in common, including the fact that he had been born in the Soviet Union and pronounced dead in a Boston hospital after a four-day manhunt, while I, Tamerlan Thompson, was a blond-haired, blue-eyed lifelong New Englander with an uneventful backstory, named after my great-grandfather on my mother’s side (or was it my father’s?), whom I had never met, and who had immigrated to the United States from what was then Turkestan and is now Uzbekistan, and which, either way, I would be hard pressed to locate on a map.

Read an interview with the author for the story behind the story.

Now I was wiping down tables with five minutes to go before the coffee shop opened for the day, my future employment hanging in the balance as we neared the end of the spring semester. Sunshine streamed through the big bay window that was partially covered by an American flag, tinting everything red, white, and blue, behind which I could see the silhouettes of a dozen students waiting for Melissa to unlock the front door. She had been the one to train me as a barista, demonstrating how to operate the industrial-

sized espresso machine, almost as big as a dishwasher, which had a built-in grinder, a dual-boiler system, and P.I.D. temperature control, whatever that was. “Don’t worry,” she’d told me. “It’s not rocket science.” Soon I would begin serving that everlasting line of undergrads, with their backpacks and their prospects, ordering mocha this and latte that, swiping their prepaid dining cards that never reached zero. Occasionally, one of them would drop a coin in the tip jar that had replaced the tip jar that I was apparently going to be fired for having stolen.

If Melissa knew anything more about who had said what about what, she wasn’t telling me, and I couldn’t blame her; she’d been working here a year, and if she worked here another year she’d be eligible to enroll in college courses, which was one of the perks of working in a coffee shop on a college campus when you’d never been to college. As for me, I’d been here only six weeks, the first of which had been spent in the basement, surrounded by dust motes, with the sound of the Red Hot Chili Peppers filtering through the ceiling, as I checked inventory and stacked boxes, my solitude interrupted only when the owner came downstairs asking for cups, lids, sundries. He called me “boss,” which on the surface sounded chummy, but I already had the sense that he didn’t like me for some reason. “I need cups, boss,” he would say. “I need straws, boss.” By the time evening arrived, he’d be sweating from the exertion of climbing up and down the stairs, and from the razor-thin profit margins, and from the fear that Starbucks might be planning to open a store somewhere in the vicinity.

There was usually only about twenty dollars in the tip jar, if we were lucky, mostly change, to spread out on the counter and split four ways, sometimes five. Walking home across campus after my shift, my pockets would jingle with every step I took, the sound helping to distract me from the pain in my feet from standing all day. “You’ll get used to it,” Melissa had told me. I would pass the nineteenth-century architecture, even more dramatic in the twilight, and the groups of students on the lawn discussing their big ideas, the sound in my pants helping to distract me from the reality that I was earning two hundred dollars a week before taxes. The night the tip jar went missing, we assumed that it had been stolen by a student, or maybe a professor—an adjunct—who had taken it when we weren’t looking. At any rate, this was a crime that ranked no higher than a moral misdemeanor, and

we had found the intrigue entertaining—a whodunnit in a coffee shop that had given us something to gossip about while we served coffee for eight hours straight. In other words, no one had appeared to suspect me at the time, even though I was the new hire from the basement who had been working as a barista for less than a week.

Podcast: The Writer's Voice
Listen to Saïd Sayrafiezadeh read "Process of Elimination."

And then the bombing occurred and we forgot all about the tip jar, occupied now solely with the carnage in Boston, everyone in the country feeling uneasy and patriotic, but doubly so for us, because we were New Englanders, first and foremost, living on the periphery of the great city, albeit two states away. We had crowded into the owner's office to watch the coverage on his TV: the smoke, the debris, the endless scroll at the bottom of the screen, and, of course, the lack of a known culprit. The owner had sat at his desk, his head bent, his hands clasped on top of a green spiral notebook with the word "Management" scrawled in marker on the cover, which was where he logged the week's sales revenue and net profits. Beside him was a stack of business books—"Strategies for Success," "Principles of Marketing"—along with pictures of his family at the pool, at the playground, at the Red Sox game, these images now forever imbued with an indelible sense of innocence and loss. We had stood behind him, five baristas in red aprons, shaking our heads, asking, Why?, How?, and the owner had said something about Al Qaeda or *ISIS* or Iran, and we had agreed. And then he had told us to go home because we were closing early, and I had walked across campus, the lawns empty, the nineteenth-century buildings shuttered, and the sun still high in the sky.

By the following afternoon, the owner had hung an American flag in the big bay window, and he had special-ordered six boxes of red-white-and-blue coffee cups, which arrived via FedEx. He had also installed a video camera above the register to make everyone feel safe. We were slower than usual that day, five baristas with nothing to do, the mood subdued, the music off. In order to keep ourselves busy and our minds occupied, we did things like reorganize the bottles of flavored syrups—vanilla, chocolate, açai—and deep-clean the espresso machine. Later, we sat around the empty tables as if

we were at a campfire, taking turns sharing our personal reminiscences about Boston, which were bittersweet in hindsight. One of the baristas talked about visiting the Museum of Fine Arts with her father when she was a little girl, and Melissa told us how she'd kayaked down the Charles River, and everyone had something to say about the Red Sox. But I had no stories to share, because I had never been to Boston, despite living two states away my whole life. Instead, I patched together some of what had been mentioned by the others, tweaking it a bit to make it my own—beginning with the time I visited the Museum of Fine Arts and ending with the time I saw the Red Sox beat the Yankees in the playoffs—and all of it so vivid in my mind that I felt I might actually have done what I said I did.

It was a little later that same afternoon when we learned that it had been pressure cookers, of all things, filled with gunpowder and ball bearings, that had caused so much death and destruction at the marathon.

"What's a pressure cooker?" Melissa had asked.

"I don't know," the other baristas had responded.

In fact, my parents had cooked with one when I was growing up, making, in fifteen minutes or less, recipes handed down through the generations—chicken, beef, you name it. But this I did not say aloud.

I was off the next two days, my weekend falling midweek, and I slept late both days, eventually waking to music coming from the frat house down the block. "Born in the U.S.A.," "Back in the U.S.A.," "Party in the U.S.A."—variations on a theme, and the price I paid for living close to campus in cheap housing. As for the news out of Boston, nothing had changed; the trains were stopped, the planes were rerouted, the citizens were sheltering in place, and "1-800-*CALL-FBI*" was running on a loop at the bottom of the TV screen because there was still no known suspect. And so I spent my weekend with the TV off, preferring instead to succumb to the unremitting soundtrack from Sigma Sigma Something.

When I interviewed for the job, I had made a point of mentioning to the owner my proximity to campus. But he had seemed unimpressed. "I expect *everyone* to be here on time," he'd said, which was what first gave me the

sense that he might not like me for some reason. I remember that we were sitting across from each other at a table in a corner of the coffee shop, next to the milk and sugar. Apparently, this was where he preferred to conduct his interviews, never mind the commotion. “I can keep my eye on everything,” he told me, making me lean in to hear him. I had been surprised by how shabby he looked, dressed in a polyester shirt, with sweat stains and coffee stains, his stomach pressing against the middle buttons, his hair thinning and uncombed. Without knowing the context, a customer might have mistaken *me* for the owner, overdressed as I was in a suit and tie, because I had wanted to make a good first impression as someone who had potential. In the background, I could see the baristas working non-stop, no motion superfluous, no drop spilled—“Next guest,” “Next guest,” “Next guest” was the refrain—and every so often a few coins would be dropped into the tip jar.

Meanwhile, the owner had been studying my résumé, which detailed ten years of “prior experience in the retail industry,” and then he opened his green spiral notebook with the word “Management” on the cover and began to read off a checklist of standard questions I had heard so many times before, asking me if I was a self-starter, asking me if I was a problem solver, asking me if I was a team player. I said yes to everything. I said no to nothing. He was curious as to whether I would be interested in taking college courses for free—in two years—given that I had listed only a high-school diploma under “prior education.”

“Yes,” I said. “I would be interested.”

By the time I returned to work on Friday, four days had passed since the bombing, and everything had changed for the better, thanks to the F.B.I., which had finally identified two suspects: Suspect One and Suspect Two. Suspect One was dead and Suspect Two was on the run. We knew that it was only a matter of time before Suspect Two was caught, and so we spent the afternoon drifting in and out of the owner’s office, watching the coverage of Boston on lockdown, the voices of the newscasters hushed and hopeful, the neighborhoods empty and still—Back Bay, Beacon Hill, South End—like a ghost town. And, of course, there were the police officers, going from house to house, their rifles at the ready, their fingers on the

triggers, dressed as if they were soldiers in Iraq, if Iraq were comprised mostly of stately brownstones. Every once in a while, the TV would display the now ubiquitous images of Suspect One and Suspect Two, who had been caught by surveillance cameras, wearing backpacks and strolling near the finish line moments before the explosions. They could have been college students on their way to class, but they were terrorists. Their backpacks could have held books, but they held pressure cookers.

At some point, Faneuil Hall Marketplace happened to flash across the screen, with its pizzerias and seafood counters and eighteenth-century architecture—everything empty, except for the police—and the owner began to tell us about the time he had gone there when he was first trying to get his start in the coffee business. It was a funny story, the way he told it, describing how everything that could go wrong *had* gone wrong: the train was delayed, the motel had lost his reservation, the fact that he was getting a late start at being an entrepreneur at the age of thirty-five—but no matter, it had all worked out in the end for him. “Look how far I’ve come,” he had said, holding out his arms in their coffee-stained sleeves, and suddenly everyone was smiling and laughing, because now there was life after tragedy. We were slowly finding that equilibrium between heartbreak and levity. Melissa told her story once more about kayaking down the Charles River, and the baristas followed one by one, just as they had the other day, until it was my turn.

“What about you, boss?” the owner had said, turning to me.

So I jumped right in, beginning with the Museum of Fine Arts and ending with Fenway Park, and this time I included Faneuil Hall Marketplace, because why not? No, I had never been to any of those places, but I *could* have and eventually I *would*. When I finished, the owner was staring at me, as if something had finally been confirmed. He seemed to know I was lying.

And it was in that moment, between deceitfulness and discovery, that I first heard my name coming from the TV—the first of many times—thanks to the F.B.I., which had confirmed the identity of Suspect One.

“Tamerlan,” the newscaster said.

The office was silent. The small talk was over. The laughter was gone. I felt a rush of heat to my face. I felt I was back in sixth grade, when I was the new boy in class, singled out for having a strange name amid the Mikes, the Marks, and, yes, the Melissas. They had wanted to know what my name meant. They had wanted to know where I was from. “You should be proud,” my mother had said, but that was only in theory. Tambourine, the boys and girls had called me. Timberland. Wonderland. Overland. The permutations were limitless. One afternoon, I could take no more and I fled the classroom, running through the hallways and out onto the playground. Thirty minutes later, my teacher found me hiding behind the jungle gym. He knelt down. He tousled my hair. “Words can’t hurt you,” he said. We sat on the swing set, side by side, while he shared stories from his own difficult childhood, growing up with a single mom. “We all have something to overcome,” he said in conclusion. It was a warm New England day, the sky cloudless, the breeze gentle, and we swung slowly back and forth in rhythm, finding common ground on social problems.

“Have you ever thought about changing your name to Tommy?” he asked me.

But today I was twenty-six years old and three hours into what was possibly my final shift at the coffee shop, having spent the past weeks feeling like Public Enemy No. 1, cringing every time I heard my name spoken aloud. “Would you mind doing this, *Tamerlan*?” “Would you mind doing that, *Tamerlan*?” It was almost noon, but the owner had not come in yet, and it was generally understood that if the owner had not come in by noon, he would not be coming in at all. More important, if I was going to be fired, it wasn’t going to be today. Without any workplace oversight, the baristas did the obvious, padding their breaks by ten, fifteen, twenty minutes. When it was my turn, I did the same thing, taking a seat at a coffee table, my apron off, the soft sound of acoustic music coming from the speaker that was next to the video camera. Perhaps the owner’s unexpected absence was an indication that the rumors about my imminent demise were wrong and that things were not so certain. I was even beginning to get used to the job—it wasn’t so bad, all things considered. As Melissa had predicted, my feet didn’t hurt as much from standing for eight hours, and, if I managed to work here long enough, I would be able to take college classes, and the

college classes I would take would be business classes, because then I would be able to open my own coffee shop one day, just like the owner, who, at the age of thirty-five, had taken that fateful trip to Boston to visit Faneuil Hall Marketplace and had come back home inspired.

By three o'clock, our lawlessness had caught up with us; the line of students was long and our supplies were low. Cups, lids, whatnot. I was engulfed by the steam coming out of the state-of-the-art espresso machine, making me grope my way through a coffee-scented fog. I could hear the barista calling out "Next guest, next guest" with urgency in her voice, trying to scale the mountain, and Melissa was suddenly standing next to me in the mist, standing very close, speaking under her breath, asking if I wouldn't mind going downstairs to get a box of napkins. "Would you mind doing that, Tamerlan?" Of course I wouldn't mind, team player that I was, problem solver that I was. When the door clicked behind me, Hootie & the Blowfish faded into the background, the dust motes appeared, and the basement was exactly as I remembered it from six weeks before, except now the owner was waiting for me.

"I'm here for the napkins," I said, but I knew I hadn't come here for the napkins.

He was leaning against a box of straws that read "3,000 *COUNT*," his shirt damp, his green spiral notebook open.

"We're going to make today your last day," he said without preamble. Apparently, he preferred to interview people upstairs and then fire them in the basement.

"Who's 'we'?" I asked.

"What?" he said.

"What's the premise?" I said. I had somehow instinctively shifted into what sounded to me like legalese. It seemed the proper approach to take for this type of occasion.

“I think we should break up and continue watching each other’s Instagram stories forever.”
Cartoon by Jason Adam Katzenstein

The owner looked at me as if to say, You already know what premise. Instead, he said, “No premise needed.”

“I know my rights,” I said.

He was confused by this. “What rights are those?” But he didn’t wait for the answer. He closed his green spiral notebook to indicate that the meeting was officially over, the word “Management” facing me upside down.

I walked across campus, passing the nineteenth-century architecture in the spring sunshine and the groups of students sitting on the lawn, still discussing their big ideas. I wanted to tell them not to waste their time with any of their grand theories about society. Whatever principles of right and wrong they developed over their four years here would cease being applicable the day they graduated. They were in for an unwelcome surprise. They would find out the hard way.

Two weeks later, I hadn’t heard back from any of the local retail businesses where I had put in applications, so I went downtown to file for unemployment. As many times as I had passed the brick building, one story tall and windowless, with a sign that read “Department of Labor,” I had never once been inside. I might as well have entered a bus depot, with low murmuring voices and high fluorescent lights and the feeling that everyone had already been waiting for a very long time. Next stops: welfare and Section 8 housing. There were about fifty chairs, almost every one of them filled, even though the economy was supposed to be good, and behind a bank of government-issued PCs were a half-dozen civil servants, who

looked as if they were doing the best they could under the circumstances. When I took my number—ninety-three—from the ticket dispenser, it was apparent that I would be waiting for a very long time, too, but I was not going to be dissuaded from trying to recoup some of the tax money that had been cutting my paychecks in half since I was sixteen years old and working at a supermarket.

I filled out the required form with my place of residence, my employment history, and my reason for leaving. “Unlawful termination,” I wrote, which I hoped might make it sound as if I had received legal counsel. And then I watched from the back row as the numbers slowly inched upward on the L.E.D. display: forty-one . . . forty-two . . . forty-three. . . . I wondered if the coffee shop was busy this afternoon. I wondered if the owner had hired someone to take my place. I wondered who had stolen the tip jar.

Subsumed within the general malaise of the unemployment agency, I began to form an alternate narrative in my mind, at first dreamlike and then self-evident, in which it was no longer a coincidence that I had been suspected, that I had been fired, and that I shared a name with a man who had killed three and injured hundreds more. Where events had once seemed to me random and unrelated, they now followed a logical sequence, the outcome of which had been determined the moment I was hired by an owner who did not like me for some unknown reason. I did not know if this narrative was true; I knew only that it was *possible*. And I knew that I was now going to exact my retribution by way of a government-issued check, once a week for the next twenty-six weeks.

When it was finally ninety-three’s turn, I took my seat across from a civil servant, who had ink on her fingers and circles under her eyes. In this scenario, she was the barista working eight hours and I was the customer ready to place my order. But, before I could offer her my proof of residency, my employment history, and my reason for leaving, she was handing the form back to me, her expression filled with sympathy and regret.

“Honey, you didn’t work there long enough to qualify.”

Two weeks after that, I still hadn’t heard back from any of the local retail businesses where I had put in applications, so I went downtown to the

Equal Employment Opportunity Commission to file a complaint for unlawful termination. As many times as I had passed the Art Deco building, twenty stories and covered in bas-reliefs, I had never suspected that there might be government offices inside. The lobby had the quality of a library, sombre and contemplative, with a high ceiling, muted footsteps, and an elevator that rose slowly, chiming with each floor it passed, and in which I had time to consider how I was rising, too, so to speak, slowly ascending from state to federal, from wronged to revenge.

I was not going to be waiting long today. Indeed, I had an appointment with a case counsellor who was ready to see me when I arrived. He was wearing a tie, no jacket, his sleeves rolled up as if he meant business. I was impressed by his efficiency. His office was spare and no nonsense, with a poster from *OSHA* about the importance of keeping farmworkers hydrated. The case counsellor shook my hand. He looked me in the eye. “I know this isn’t easy,” he said. I hadn’t yet told him anything, but he already seemed to have empathy for me. I was impressed by this, too. He could have been my teacher from sixth grade, giving life lessons on the swing beside me.

“Let’s start at the beginning,” he said.

So I started with Day One, down in the basement of the coffee shop, stacking boxes with the dust motes. I told him everything. I told him everything from my *point of view*. I used phrases like “in my opinion” or “as I see it.” I could tell he had heard some version of this story before, many times before, and that he knew the ending, but he listened without impatience, without concern for time, while typing his notes into his computer. Occasionally, he would interrupt me to make sure he had the chronology correct or that he understood who had said what to whom when. As I made my way through those six weeks of employment, the narrative became firmer, the chain of events more certain, and I stopped bothering to include “in my opinion.” If this was speculation, it was speculation supported by *evidence*. An hour later, I had arrived at my final day in the coffee shop, back in the basement, about to be fired by the owner. “What’s the premise?” I had asked him. “No premise needed,” the owner had answered.

Then I waited while the case counsellor finished typing the last of his notes, his fingers clacking over the keyboard, the *OSHA* poster in my line of vision. I wanted to ask him if he thought I had a chance for justice. I wanted to ask him what form he thought justice might take. More to the point, I wanted to ask him how *much* justice might be worth. But before we could talk about that, there were steps that had to be taken, and this is where efficiency ended and bureaucracy began. The commission was backlogged. Never mind that the case counsellor appeared to have no other clients except for me. Justice would be coming, yes, but justice would be slow.

“I know this isn’t easy,” he said.

It was now more than two months since I had been fired. It was more than three months since the bombing. I still had not yet heard back from any of the local retail businesses where I had put in an application. As for Tamerlan’s younger brother, Dzhokhar, his case was making its way through the courts. Eventually, he would be given a fair trial by a jury of his peers. After which he would be sentenced to death.

Meanwhile, my savings dwindled. In the morning, I would be woken by music emanating from the frat house down the block. The occupants had moved on from patriotism and returned to hip-hop at full volume. “No one man should have all that power,” went the lyrics. “The clock’s ticking, I just count the hours.” As apt a sentiment as any for my present condition.

Then one afternoon I received a message from an assistant manager of a Starbucks, saying that a store was opening in the neighborhood, right off campus, full staff needed, and would I be interested in coming in for an interview tomorrow, not a moment too soon. And the next day I showed up bright and early, full of cautious optimism, wearing my suit and tie, and carrying a copy of my résumé that detailed ten years of “prior experience in the retail industry.” I was surprised by how young the assistant manager was, maybe only a year or two older than me, but so much further along in her career. She was dressed in slacks and sensible shoes and a coveted *green* apron. We sat across from each other at a table in the corner, next to the milk and sugar, just as I had done for my job interview at the other coffee shop, except now everything was new, and the bay window was bigger. She told me that there was health care, and paid time off, and a

401(k). These were the perks of working for a multinational corporation. I told her that I lived in the vicinity. She liked that I lived in the vicinity. I told her that I had experience with P.I.D. technology. She didn't know what that was. I asked her if I would have to start off in the basement. "We don't have a basement," she said. What she had was a clear path for advancement. What she had was an H.R. department.

I started the following week with five other baristas. Business was slow. Business picked up. Business was booming. Then the fall semester began and the line went out the door and around the corner, the refrain of "next guest" was endless, and the steam from the industrial-strength espresso machine engulfed me in its coffee-scented fog. If it weren't for the green apron and the twentysomething assistant manager and the fact that tip jars were not permitted, I could have been right back where I had been in April. "We don't want students to feel obligated," the assistant manager told us, meaning tip jars, which was probably for the best. And less than three months into my tenure I was promoted to shift supervisor—no higher education required. After shift supervisor would come shift manager, followed by assistant manager, followed by manager, district manager. That was the trajectory. And then came the start of the spring semester and a message from the Equal Employment Opportunity Commission, telling me that my case had finally wound its way through the government bureaucracy and it was time to come back downtown and receive justice.

It was almost seven months since I had been fired. It was almost eight months since the bombing. The coffee shop seemed so long ago now, so far away, as if something out of a dream. But here was the case counsellor shaking my hand firmly, taking me into his office, saying again, "I know this isn't easy." He told me that the other party was already there, in another room, and that soon we would meet and discuss what had happened. After which the case counsellor would weigh the facts and make his decision. But, before that, he wanted me to read a letter that he had received in advance. It was two pages long, written in cursive, in blue ink, and torn from that spiral notebook that the owner carried everywhere.

"His side of the story," the case counsellor said.

“To whom it may concern,” the letter began, and, sure enough, the first paragraph was full of an alternate narrative to compete with my alternate narrative, ultimately impossible for me to ever disprove, about how the owner had liked me, had always liked me, had hired me because he thought I was a “promising young man”—his words—but that soon it went south, for reasons that he could never fully figure out, but were entirely my fault. “I tried my best to work with him,” he wrote, “and to make him feel as if he was a part of the family that we strive to have at our coffee shop.” But, according to the owner, I had not wanted to belong and I had chosen to remain an outsider from the beginning. The baristas had felt the same. The baristas would be willing to testify to this.

That was paragraph one, the preamble, background, and context. It was not until the second paragraph that the claim of my unlawful termination was taken up, and which, apparently, had nothing whatsoever do with the tip jar being stolen, even though, yes, it had been stolen shortly after I had begun working as a barista—but that was beside the point. “I would never falsely accuse anyone of anything,” the owner wrote. The truth was that it had been the end of the school year, plain and simple, and the students were going home for the summer. “This is seasonal work,” he wrote. If the owner had decided to keep me employed, it would’ve meant having to cut the hours for his longtime staff members who were hoping to enroll in college classes. “I would never stand in the way of someone’s dream,” he explained. As to whether I had been fired because I shared a name with Tamerlan Tsarnaev, he was hurt that this was even being suggested. He said that he was sorry that I had the misfortune of being associated with terrorists, but there was nothing he could do about that. No, he did not harbor prejudice toward anyone. No, he did not call me “boss” because he had an aversion to saying my name aloud. He denied everything. He admitted nothing. By the way, he wondered why I had lied about visiting Boston. He also wondered, by the way, why I had not seemed more distraught after the news of the bombing broke. In conclusion, the owner had only care and compassion for everyone who worked for him, and the baristas would be willing to testify to this.

When I was done reading, I handed the letter back to the case counsellor.

“He said, he said,” I said. I didn’t know what else to say.

The case counsellor nodded. He folded the letter and put it back in the envelope with the coffee shop’s return address. Maybe Melissa would be willing to testify on my behalf, never mind that she was hoping to enroll in college classes, and I would be able to add “she said.”

But the case counsellor told me that he had already considered both sides of the story and, much to my surprise and relief, he agreed with my version of events. “I believe you,” he said. His advice now was that we should try to resolve this without any sort of formal hearing. “Let’s see if we can take care of this today,” he told me. Considering that I had received no severance, he would ask the owner if he would be willing to pay me four hundred dollars to settle the matter—four hundred dollars being the equivalent of two weeks’ pay.

“I can’t promise,” the case counsellor said, “but I’ll try my best.”

Then he left me alone in his office with nothing to do except stare up at the poster about the importance of letting farmworkers drink water. “The work can’t get done without them,” it read.

When the case counsellor returned, he had even better news: the coffee shop was willing to pay me *eight hundred dollars*. Would I agree to eight hundred dollars? Would I agree to eight hundred dollars and an apology? I said yes to everything. I said no to nothing. And I was led into a conference room to sit across the table from the owner whom I had not seen in more than seven months, and who was as dishevelled as ever. He had chosen to wear a suit and tie for the occasion, but his suit was baggy, his tie was tight, and his hair was even thinner. Sitting beside him was a man I had never seen before, tall and trim, half the owner’s age and weight, and whom the case counsellor introduced to me as the owner of the coffee shop. Here was a third narrative, to compete with the narratives that had come before: the man who I had thought was the owner was only the manager, and now here was the *actual* owner, who had no idea who I was, and, moreover, appeared flummoxed as to how we had arrived at this situation. No longer in the context of the coffee shop, the manager looked uncomfortable and out of place, his power diminished, an average guy in a bad suit, who had had to

take time off from his job to come downtown to a federal office in an Art Deco building.

He had brought his notebook with him, of course, “Management” written on the cover. He was not the outsized entrepreneur that I had always thought him to be, but, rather, one of those fortunate employees who had worked long enough at the coffee shop to qualify to enroll in college courses. I suddenly felt a sharp sense of remorse for having caused this ordeal in what I had considered the pursuit of justice, and I felt sorry for the manager, who, no thanks to me, had certainly not curried any favor with the real owner. I wondered if the eight hundred dollars would be coming out of the manager’s pocket. I wondered if he would be fired. But there was no turning back now, and nothing left to do except for everyone to sign the forms in triplicate saying that we were in agreement with the outcome.

And when that was done, the manager turned to me, his hands folded in front of him on the conference table, barely able to make eye contact, mumbling his compulsory apology, as if we were children in the schoolyard.

“Sorry for the misunderstanding,” he said. None of it mattered, of course. Starbucks was coming. Starbucks was going to swallow everything.

Then the case counsellor handed me the check for eight hundred dollars.

“We hope this will make you whole,” he said. ♦

Saïd Sayrafiezadeh is the author of the story collection “American Estrangement.”

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The Critics

- **The Many Forms of Marcel Duchamp**
  By Hilton Als | How the shape-shifting artist radicalized art itself.
- **A German Master's Modernist Epic of Postwar Amnesia and Hypocrisy**
  By Becca Rothfeld | Wolfgang Koeppen's "trilogy of failure," written from 1951 to 1954, is a sprawling, polyphonic portrait of a physically and morally shattered country.
- **Briefly Noted**
  "In Search of Now," "Nothing Random," "Of Loss and Lavender," and "No Way Home."
- **The Sqirl Redemption Arc**
  By Hannah Goldfield | The beloved L.A. café was brought low by a bucket of moldy jam. Now it's open for dinner.
- **How Long Can Martha Graham's Dance Revolution Last?**
  By Jennifer Homans | As the company she left behind celebrates its centenary, it finds itself caught between preservation and radical tradition.
- **"Half Man" Tests the Limits of Brotherly Love**
  By Inkoo Kang | Richard Gadd's follow-up to "Baby Reindeer" traces a decades-long quasi-familial relationship that's thornier than any other male bond on TV.

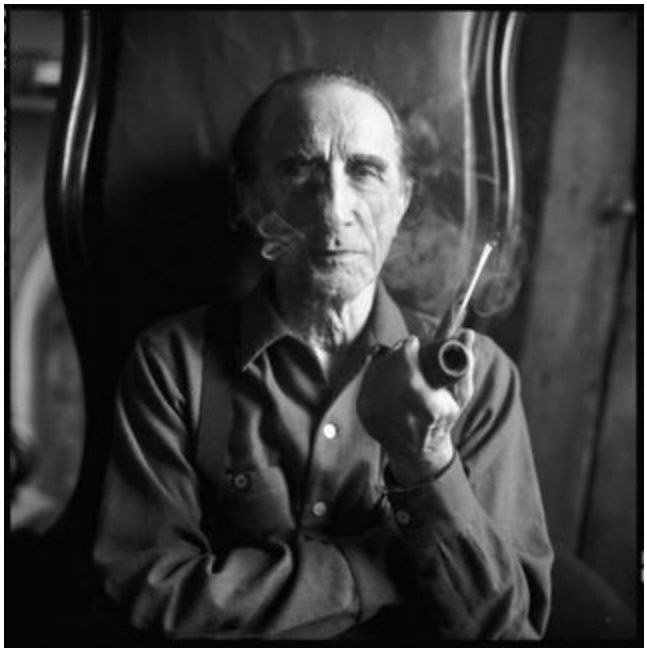
The Art World

The Many Forms of Marcel Duchamp

How the shape-shifting artist radicalized art itself.

By Hilton Als

April 27, 2026



Marcel Duchamp, in New York, in January, 1958. The world was spinning, spinning, and Duchamp couldn't help but make art that represented that evolution, that revolution.Photograph by Richard Avedon / © The Richard Avedon Foundation

Love isn't a word, or a concept, that one usually associates with Marcel Duchamp, the modernist master of irony and distance, but love—love of the mind and what it can do, love of bodies and play, love of freedom, love of what art can be, love of women, queerdom, poetry, and chance—is what makes "Marcel Duchamp" (at the Museum of Modern Art, through August 22nd) such a wonder. Curated with a respect that's never slavish by Matthew Affron, Michelle Kuo, and Ann Temkin, it's the first retrospective of Duchamp's work in North America since a 1973 exhibition, also shown

at *MoMA*, mounted by the legendary curators Anne d'Harnoncourt and Kynaston McShine. As was the case back then, the curatorial team is a collaboration between institutions: Affron works at the Philadelphia Museum of Art (as did d'Harnoncourt), whose signature Duchamp collection the artist himself helped to install, while Kuo and Temkin are at *MoMA* (where McShine was a curator). The current show works because its curators, whose interests are wide-ranging, support Duchamp's own wide-ranging interests, honoring the pieces not as relics but as possibilities.

"Nude Descending a Staircase (No. 2)," 1912.Art work by Marcel Duchamp / Courtesy Philadelphia Art Museum / Louise and Walter Arensberg Collection

The exhibition, which takes up the museum's entire sixth floor, is too vast to absorb in one go. Duchampian idea after Duchampian idea stimulates thought after thought of your own, and it's important to rest after each visit,

the better to synthesize those thoughts. The warmth you'll feel on your second or third viewing of "Marcel Duchamp" will come from the realization that Duchamp jettisoned the artist's ego—the "I" that demands attention and equates success with money—and replaced it with something more perverse, at least by art-world standards: the embrace not of one easily commodifiable style but of many. There are numerous versions of Duchamp here, but what they all share is a disregard for capital and for the way it shapes or encroaches on artistic practice, corrupting the freedom of the mind.

Duchamp, who died in 1968, did not spring from the head of Apollo fully formed. Born in Normandy in 1887, Henri-Robert-Marcel Duchamp was the fourth of seven children of Justin-Isidore Duchamp, a notary, and his wife, Marie-Caroline-Lucie Nicolle, who had been an amateur artist in her youth. The family lived near Rouen, in a splendid stone-and-brick house, where chess was a favorite pastime. (For part of his adult life, Duchamp tried to pass himself off as a chess bum who had "retired" from art-making, though he never did.) Like his older brothers, Gaston and Raymond, Marcel appreciated his father and disliked his mother. As revealed in Calvin Tomkins's searching and beautifully written 1996 biography, "Duchamp," Lucie was a remote figure to her boys, emotionally cut off and with poor hearing that further isolated her.

“Bicycle Wheel,” 1951 (third version, after lost original of 1913).Art work by Marcel Duchamp / Courtesy MOMA

The mother you can’t reach is the mother you long for, and unconsciously emulate: Duchamp’s fabled distance spoke to Maman’s own. Still, for most of his life, Duchamp’s closest cohorts were female, beginning with his sister Suzanne, who was two years his junior and shared his joyful sense of exuberance and wonder. One of Duchamp’s earliest sketches, from 1902, “Suzanne Duchamp Skating,” is a charming rendering of a figure moving freely in space. Like Suzanne and Marcel, Gaston and Raymond were

artistically inclined, but their papa wasn't happy: Couldn't they find more respectable ways to be in the world? They tried—Gaston studied law and Raymond medicine—but it was no use. By 1904, when Marcel joined them in Paris, where he aimed to become an artist, Gaston and Raymond had dropped out of school and changed their names—to Jacques Villon and Raymond Duchamp-Villon, partly in homage to the medieval poet François Villon—as a way of protecting themselves from their father's disapproval, or, more accurately, claiming the freedom that all artists need in order to develop. (Jacques made Cubist-influenced work, while Raymond built largely figurative sculptures representing human and animal forms.)

In 1905, Duchamp learned that, if he got certified as an essential "art worker," his obligatory military service would be reduced from two years to one, and he returned to Rouen to apprentice with a copperplate printer there. (The knowledge he acquired at the printing house no doubt contributed to his interest in making books, cards, and other ephemera.) Then, after a year in an infantry regiment, he returned to Paris, settling in the artistic enclave of Montmartre, in 1906. By that time, his brothers had moved to the suburbs, where he frequently visited them. Duchamp never completely distanced himself from the idea or the reality of family, and his father, despite his initial skepticism about his sons' vocation, provided a modest allowance. For most of his working life, Duchamp—who did not view art as a product and thus a means for gaining capital—was also helped by wealthy friends, former lovers, and collectors. (His second wife, Alexina, or Teeny, whom he wed in 1954, had been married to the gallerist Pierre Matisse and was a sometime dealer for Joan Miró and other artists, as well as Duchamp's most steadfast benefactor and confidante. Teeny knew the value of a dollar.)

For a time, Duchamp worked as an illustrator, and the *MoMA* show has a fair number of his satirical early drawings, ink-on-paper observations about everyday life: a couple at a skating rink, a horse-drawn cab, a woman annoyed by being stood up. The image that jumped out at me, presaging, as it did, the artist's fascination and engagement with the nonbinary, was a drawing from 1909. Titled "Ni Homme, Ni Femme, Pas Même Auvergnat" ("Neither Man Nor Woman, Not Even from Auvergne"), the drawing is a three-quarter view of someone wearing a frock coat and trousers, against a

light background—a delicate depiction of a queer person living in their own undefined space. I think that Duchamp, who, in the early twenties, created an alter ego named Rrose Sélavy—a play on "*Eros, c'est la vie*"—had a nonbinary soul. (Man Ray photographed Duchamp as Rrose, in a stylish hat and fur stole.) "In 1920, I decided that it didn't suffice [for] me to be a lone individual with a masculine name," Duchamp said in 1960. "I wanted . . . to make another personality from myself." Putting a mustache and goatee on the "Mona Lisa" for his great 1919 work "L.H.O.O.Q."—a homophone for "*elle a chaud au cul*," which Duchamp translated euphemistically as "there is fire down below"—performed the opposite feat, masculinizing the most famous female portrait in the world.

Duchamp's other drawings are more Toulouse-Lautrec than anything else, though he lacked Toulouse-Lautrec's eye—a reportorial vision that delighted in the show-biz choreography of Parisian life. Similarly, his paintings from 1910 and 1911 interested me only in that they were a bridge to something else. They're clotted with barely digested Fauvist influences, not to mention late Cézanne and early Cubism. (Duchamp later referred to one of his portraits from this period as full of "technical wishy-washiness.") His dark and somewhat confused 1910 portrait of his father gives you a glimpse less of Duchamp's mind than of his brief foray into dutifulness: painting family portraits is how you become an artist.

"I peed on them."

Cartoon by Liana Finck

But there is one piece from this time that nods toward the future. “The Bush” (1910-11) is a large oil-on-canvas work that depicts two nude women: one of whom, a brunette, stands, with her hand resting on the head of the other, a blonde, who is on her knees. (Duchamp is said to have used Jeanne Serre, who was then his mistress, as a model for the kneeling figure.) The women’s fleshiness, the roundness of their faces and bellies, is echoed in the fullness of the vegetation behind them. A note in the catalogue says that, with this painting, the artist began giving what he said was “an important role” to his titles, “which I added and treated like an invisible color.” “Bush” is a colloquial term for a woman’s pubic hair, and we can see the brunette’s pubic hair delineated in the painting. (The associations pile up when you consider that “the bush” is also, in English, a term for backwoods or hinterlands.) Is the blonde kneeling to pray? To show respect for her companion? Is Duchamp, that wonderful scrambler of ideas about gender, the brunette? And is the hand on the head a gesture of comfort or of benediction? One loses and finds things in bushes—perhaps even *la jouissance*.

But was this kind of representation of the body, or of the artist’s feelings about the human form, even worth Duchamp’s time when, all around him, the world had changed, and was changing, and the whole question of what made a person, a body, was up for grabs? The First World War, just a few years off, would unite death and patriotism. Would there be any way to avoid sentimentalizing the body? Duchamp, a lover of poetry—he considered Stéphane Mallarmé, Raymond Roussel, and Jules Laforgue, all of them disturbers of the form, his influences—needed to make his own poems, and one way he could do that was by fucking with reality.

In 1964, Calvin Tomkins spent time with Duchamp, at his home on West Tenth Street in New York, chatting about his shift from the figurative to what I call the retinal theoretical—by which I mean a process of both visual and verbal intellection—and about the fun of being a trickster. (These conversations appear in Tomkins’s lively 2013 book, “Marcel Duchamp: The Afternoon Interviews.” At one point, Duchamp tells Tomkins, “I don’t believe in talking. Here we have been talking for hours! But don’t believe what I say.”) In 1911, Duchamp said, his brother Raymond had asked a few

artists working in the Cubist style to make small oil paintings for his kitchen. Duchamp decided to paint an everyday object—a coffee mill. Measuring thirteen by five inches, “Coffee Mill” is not a particularly arresting work. But it revolutionized Duchamp’s practice by teaching him that movement could be represented by an arrow—a kind of “writing” that showed the mill turning or about to turn. “Coffee Mill” was the first line of Duchamp’s epic poem about seeing differently, being different. Tomkins asked Duchamp if he had thought about “the machine being characteristic of the time.”

> D*uchamp*: Yes, they call it the machine age, don’t they? I mean, everything is becoming mechanized in this life. All this creates a climate for my being attracted to expressing myself in the form of mechanographic . . . instead of using the old-fashioned approach of the painting. I was interested in using a mechanistic approach, if I wanted to step out of tradition.
>
> T*omkins*: And into something new?
>
> D*uchamp*: New enough.

“Coffee Mill” released something in Duchamp, and the canvases he produced after it—the astonishing “Nude (Sketch) Sad Young Man in a Train” (1911-12) and “Nude Descending a Staircase (No. 2)” (1912)—are an explosion of feeling about the work that he didn’t want to do anymore, evidence both of an artist trying to free himself from his “talent,” and of what loneliness looked like in the modern, cinema-influenced world. Duchamp described “Sad Young Man” in Pierre Cabanne’s 1967 book, “Dialogues with Marcel Duchamp”: “First there’s the idea of the movement of the train, and then that of the sad young man who is in a corridor and who is moving about. . . . Then, there is the distortion of the young man—I had called this elementary parallelism. It was a formal decomposition; that is, linear elements following each other like parallels and distorting the object. The object is completely stretched out, as if elastic.”

“Female Fig Leaf,” 1950. Electroplated copper over plaster.Art work by Marcel Duchamp / Courtesy © ARS / ADAGP, Paris / Estate of Marcel Duchamp

Critics have argued that Duchamp was influenced during this time by Italian Futurism, with its interest in speed and the mechanical. Duchamp resisted the association. By contrast, he openly acknowledged how much his friendship with the great Francis Picabia (1879-1953), who became a kind of surrogate older brother to him, meant. Picabia, who worked in a variety of mediums, including painting, drawing, and film, was also a poet, and his exuberance made a lasting impression on Duchamp. (He also fell in love with Picabia’s wife, such a clear act of displacement that one wonders if it was Picabia himself who made Duchamp feel a fire down below.) Despite his free-flowing creativity, Picabia was, Duchamp told Cabanne, “a negator. With him it was always, ‘Yes, but . . .’ and ‘No, but . . .’ Whatever you said, he contradicted. It was his game.” You could call that critical distance, but it was also a way, Duchamp realized, for Picabia to defend himself and his right to change.

The act of removing oneself from the discourse around one’s work was a tactic that Duchamp employed more and more after “Nude Descending a Staircase (No. 2)” was presented at the Armory Show in New York, in 1913. As the curators of “Marcel Duchamp” write, this work struck the “American public as an outrageous provocation.” A *Times* review likened it to “an explosion in a shingle mill.” A sister work to “Sad Young Man,” it is also executed in browns, ochres, and yellows that portray both movement and movement *in stasis*. To viewers at the time, the figure did not look nude; it did not look human. Duchamp’s genius was pushing up against the

limits of the frame. That same year, he essentially renounced painting. What painting could contain his belief in movement as a metaphor not only for progress but for continuing to develop, never accepting the limitations of a proper, socialized self and sacrificing what really counts: the expression of the conscious and subconscious mind? The world was spinning, spinning, and Duchamp couldn’t help but make art that represented that evolution, that revolution.

“Ni Homme, Ni Femme, Pas Même Auvergnat,” 1909.Art work by Marcel Duchamp / Courtesy Jack Shear Collection

Giving up painting didn’t mean that Duchamp wasn’t working; he was never not working. But he began to look for a different way to produce art, for other media in which to explore movement. His pieces about motion, or

spinning in stillness_—_such as the readymade “Bicycle Wheel” (the show includes several versions and replicas of the lost 1913 original) and the beautiful, psychedelic “Rotoreliefs (Optical Disks),” from 1935, which reminds me of the way movies once represented hypnosis or a psychological break—are also about the death of objects. What happens to the “aura” of objects when they are no longer in use? We once buried the dead with their possessions; in this way, we could make those things live in our minds forever, as our loved ones do. But, in Duchamp’s mechanical age, death and remembrance took on a different cast. What are we to do with that old-fashioned hat rack? That comb? Who in the world will touch us now? Define us? What constitutes a memory? That ball of twine? That lovely ampoule of Parisian air?

By 1915, Duchamp had begun making “The Bride Stripped Bare by Her Bachelors, Even (The Large Glass)” (1915-23), which, for all its formal beauty—it consists of figures made from oil, varnish, lead foil, lead wire, and dust set on two panes of glass—remains transparent in its retinal and psychological complexity.

To supplement his income, Duchamp gave French lessons to the wealthy Stettheimer sisters, hosts of a New York salon frequented by such modernists as Georgia O’Keeffe and Alfred Stieglitz. (In 1923, Florine Stettheimer made a painting of Duchamp’s dual selves, “Portrait of Marcel Duchamp and Rrose Sélavy,” which perfectly captures his slight build and his playfulness.) After sitting out the war in New York and spending a year in Buenos Aires, Duchamp returned to France. (He would make round-trip journeys across the Atlantic many times, eventually splitting his life between France and the U.S., and becoming an American citizen in 1955.) In Paris in 1927, he met and married—very quickly—Lydie Sarazin-Levassor, a much younger woman, who recalled in a memoir:

> Marcel taught me to appreciate the beauty of raw materials. No need for exotic wood or other rare and costly materials to fit out a flat that would be pleasant to live in. A plaster wall has a splendour and delicacy of its own. . . . At first I thought his taste for natural things was a reaction against the “refined” aesthetic propounded by the recent exhibition of *les arts decoratifs*. I asked him about it: “As far as lizards

> go, I have only encountered the variety that basks in the sun. What are these *lizards décoratifs*? It is a new species? . . . Art is simply the technical knowledge that goes with a profession. Look it up in the Larousse dictionary. So what are the Fine Arts? All the arts are fine. The knifegrinder's art is particularly fine."

The marriage lasted less than a year, but in Sarazin-Levassor's reminiscence we see that what Duchamp once said about himself was true: if he had to choose between a country house, a wife, children—the trappings of convention—and art, he would choose art. Art could keep up with him.

The *MoMA* show doesn't include two of Duchamp's Joycean masterpieces: "The Bride Stripped Bare" and the magnificent "Étant Donnés: 1° la chute d'eau, 2° le gaz d'éclairage . . ." (1946-66). (They're permanently installed at the Philadelphia Museum of Art, where the retrospective will open in October.) But the exhibition's "incompleteness" makes it all the more Duchampian; it will remain in memory as a series of movements that propel our thoughts forward, commanding us to open our hearts, our bodies, our eyes, our sense of humor and of wonder. *See something! Make it new! It's up to you!*

While walking around the show one recent afternoon, I thought of the artists on whom Duchamp has had an indelible effect. And I pondered how—aside from David Hammons, in such early performances as "Bliz-aard Ball Sale" (1983), in which he sold snowballs for a dollar on a street corner (thus playing with the idea of snowballs in hell, and with the unlikelihood of a Black artist's gaining a foothold in an art world that was still overwhelmingly white)—few of those who've claimed Duchamp as a major influence have been able to question, in the way Duchamp did throughout his career, the centrality of the artist. As large as this show is, there's something purifying about it. It embodies what Louise Glück describes in her great poem "Bats": "There are two kinds of vision: / the seeing of things, which belongs / to the science of optics, versus / the seeing beyond things, which / results from deprivation." You can't see clearly if you're worried about what you might be missing. If you free yourself from the desire for acquisition and glory, your subconscious will bloom, and so will you. Freedom of thought requires you to divorce your eye from the familiar.

"L.H.O.O.Q.," 1919. Pencil on reproduction of Leonardo da Vinci's "Mona Lisa."Art work by Marcel Duchamp / Courtesy MOMA

Speaking to Tomkins in 1964, Duchamp noted, "The poor Mona Lisa is gone because no matter how wonderful her smile may be, it's been looked at so much that the smile has disappeared." He continued, "I believe that when a million people look at a painting, they change the thing by looking alone. Physically. . . . There is an action, transcendental, of course, that absolutely destroys whatever you could see when it was alive." But Duchamp's work behaves differently. His "readymades" are about defunct or useless things—things we discarded and replaced with others that we thought might help us move faster or look prettier—which are brought back to life by the viewer's vision.

We are an accumulation of desires, and how will others remember us if not through what we desired? I was very taken by "Study for 'Please Touch' "

(1947), a plaster cast of a breast, which says as much about the closeness and the remoteness of the desired object, and about how we see one another not as whole but in pieces, as Duchamp's "erotic objects" do: "Female Fig Leaf" (1950), for instance, or "Wedge of Chastity" (1954), or the funny, phallic "Objet-Dard (Dart-Object)" (1951). What are we, who are we? Body parts crying out to be completed by the gaze of another person? Our subconscious keeps moving, carrying with it eros and dreams, art and politics.

To Cabanne, Duchamp professed not to be political, but that was just another performance. Think about his feminism, his shape-shifting, his radicalization of art itself. He was fervent in his belief in possibility—in our possibility as thinking adults, if only we could give ourselves permission to stretch the rules. If we did, he told Tomkins, "there would be more imagination, more leeway, more lack of seriousness, more play, more breathing rather than working. Why should man work to live, after all? . . . I can conceive of a society where the lazies have a place in the sun." Duchamp was poking at the American bear, which measures life not in coffee spoons but by achievement. But to what end? He was always searching for the bride who would believe him, and we are that inscrutable bride, whether he knew it or not. ♦

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Books

A German Master's Modernist Epic of Postwar Amnesia and Hypocrisy

Wolfgang Koeppen's "trilogy of failure," written from 1951 to 1954, is a sprawling, polyphonic portrait of a physically and morally shattered country.

***By** Becca Rothfeld*

April 27, 2026

In a rare interview, Koeppen described his work as "a monologue against the world"—an attempt to dismantle the newly formed nation of West Germany piece by piece.Photograph by Nomi Baumgartl

"Once upon a time, this city was a home to gods," the enigmatic German writer Wolfgang Koeppen declares in his final novel, "Death in Rome" (1954). The gods in question, the jealously quibbling deities who ruled over the ancients with mercurial fervor, often came down and consorted with their subjects—but, by the time the book begins, they have fled. When the estranged members of a German family unwittingly converge on Rome for two days, they find countless reminders of the old pantheon and countless reminders of its abdication. "The angels from the Angels' Bridge did not take up the invitation of the old gods," Koeppen reports. When one character, a deacon studying to become a priest, sits "among the stone witnesses of antiquity," he is "excluded from their society." The statues

watch “dry-eyed” as he weeps for the bygone world. Their response to the indignities of modernity is only contemptuous silence.

Koeppen’s response was similar. For decades following the publication of “Death in Rome,” rumor had it that he was on the cusp of completing a novel that never appeared. “His silence—which is perceived as such—is one of the loudest things in German literature today,” his English-language translator Michael Hofmann wrote four years before Koeppen’s death, in 1996. On one of the few occasions when Koeppen broke his silence to give an interview, he described his work as “a monologue against the world”—an attempt to dismantle West Germany piece by piece—and his fiction often seems to trade in disavowals and annulments. His informal “trilogy of failure,” of which “Death in Rome” is the third installment, is rife with questions that the text answers in the negative: “Was he afraid? He wasn’t afraid.” “Was it a triumph? It was no triumph.”

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Still, one affirmation is possible in the midst of all this negation: now that the final two books of Koeppen’s peculiar trilogy have been reissued in English by the publisher New Directions, we can see that it *is* a triumph, a gem of postwar German literature that has remained obscure in the Anglophone world for too long. As Hofmann notes, Koeppen “wrote his books quickly and in little clusters, or not at all,” and he dashed off those three marvellous novels, “Pigeons on the Grass,” “The Hothouse,” and “Death in Rome,” in a single three-year stretch, from 1951 to 1954. These ribald, irreverent, cutting, rhapsodic, and ultimately devastating portraits of German amnesia and hypocrisy, with their long, torqued sentences and jostling casts of doomed characters, were difficult for Koeppen’s contemporaries to assimilate. Formally, they were a ferment of

hallucination, memory, fantasy, confession, and accusation. Substantively, they had little in common with the pacifying products of a culture that had decided, in the words of the novelist W. G. Sebald, to “proceed on its way,” after the Second World War, “almost undisturbed, as if nothing had happened.”

Koeppen knew that something had happened, and he was determined to prevent his compatriots from proceeding undisturbed. He certainly succeeded in irking them. Critics in the newly formed nation of West Germany were baffled by his polyphonic rapacity and enraged by his scorn for the country’s élite, many of whom were scarcely reformed Nazis—a fact that was considered tactless to mention. “Not to be touched with a barge-pole,” the headline of one review of “The Hothouse” declared. “People took my novel to be a mirror in which many individuals who were by no means in my thoughts claimed to recognize themselves,” Koeppen wrote in a defensive preface to “Pigeons on the Grass.” Seemingly wounded by the trilogy’s reception, he never wrote fiction again. He repeatedly promised his publisher drafts of his long-awaited new novel for the next forty-some years.

There was still occasional writing: reviews and essays and, from 1958 to 1961, a second gust of frantic activity, which yielded three travel books about Russia, the United States, and France, respectively. In 1976, he published “Youth,” a slim, fragmentary, associative recollection of his childhood, and, in 1992, the memoir of a Holocaust survivor which Koeppen had ghostwritten in the nineteen-forties was republished as a novel under his name, provoking some controversy. In the end, he did not suffer from want of recognition: in 1962, he won Germany’s most prestigious literary honor, the Georg Büchner Prize, in what was perhaps the establishment’s attempt to make belated amends. Among his admirers he counted Günter Grass.

Still, the absent novel rankled. As Koeppen might have put it: Was he satisfied? No, he was not. In his correspondence with his publisher, released as a book in German under the rather desperate title “Ich Bitte um ein Wort” (“A Word from You, Please”—as no doubt his editor often pleaded), there is

a bitter joke: a mock title page. “My Life” is the subtitle. “Wolfgang Koeppen” is the author. The title, a refusal to offer a title, is “No.”

No: it was the word that defined the century, at least in Germany. No Alsace-Lorraine, no Verdun, no revenge against the French, no Army, no Kaiser, no economy to speak of. Soon, the nation endured an even crueller string of “no”s: no degenerate art, no dissenters, no Jewish books, no Jewish shops, and, eventually, no Jews.

Koeppen lived to see the prim, bourgeois Prussia of his childhood unmade and remade by these sometimes conflicting proscriptions. He was born in 1906 in Greifswald, a zealously Lutheran city on the Baltic coast, the illegitimate child of a doctor who did not recognize him and a mother who worked as a seamstress and struggled to pay the bills. His early life, mostly conducted on the margins of respectable Greifswald society, was haphazard. He studied but did not earn a degree, worked as a cinema usher and as a junior cook, and settled for a time in Berlin, where he wrote for a left-wing newspaper from 1931 to 1934. His first two novels, the lugubrious love story “A Sad Affair” (1934) and “The Tottering Wall” (1935), were published to moderate acclaim, but both books were banned in 1936, for the venal sin of having modernist ambitions and for the mortal sin of having a Jewish publisher. In 1935, Koeppen fled to the Netherlands—perhaps in quiet protest of the Nazis, as he insinuated, or perhaps because he was having an affair with an S.S. officer’s wife, as others have alleged. Four years later, he returned to Germany, where he worked in the film industry, writing intentionally unfilmable screenplays, maybe as a way of defying Nazi rule without calling too much attention to himself.

Koeppen’s long-suffering editor once called the novel he was forever trying and failing to write “the German ‘Ulysses.’ ” That book will never be completed, but the trilogy comes close enough. Like Joyce’s masterpiece and another book often described as its German analogue, Alfred Döblin’s “Berlin Alexanderplatz” (1929), each febrile installment takes place in a single city, and each compresses its action into a one- or two-day frenzy. Koeppen’s chapters are often fractured into short sections, yet these fragments are wonderfully overfull. Their sinuous sentences span pages and veer off into wild clauses, and they are densely allusive, reeling from

Romantic poetry to Gertrude Stein to Plato, lurching from one character's point of view to the next. Headlines and advertisements blare out; lists repeat and iterate. In "The Hothouse," a wordless vocalization from Wagner's "Ring" cycle, "wagalaweia," is a frequent refrain—a fitting motif for novels that are not plotted so much as composed. Their many narratives and perspectives tend to converge, as music does, in concluding crescendos.

The principle of organization that connects each section to the next is often an echoed image or phrase: one segment in "Pigeons on the Grass" ends with an embarrassed character who "melted" out of a shop that sells wares he cannot afford, and the succeeding section begins with beer that foams "like snow." In the classic 1927 film "Berlin: Symphony of a Metropolis," one shot fades into another not on the basis of narrative continuity but on the basis of visual affinity: the swooping lines of train tracks cut to the swooping lines of telephone wires, and a traffic conductor on the street dissolves into bobbleheads in a similar posture in a shopwindow. Koeppen's technique is similarly collagist: he collects pieces and assembles them into a jagged approximation of the whole, a method that suits a world that has been physically shattered by bombs and morally shattered by atrocities.

"All we have is a supranational style, and this style is America," laments one character in another post-Second World War German-language novel, "The Death of My Brother Abel" (1976), by Gregor von Rezzori. This Americanization is already well under way in "Pigeons on the Grass." The book's fragments—there are a hundred and ten—coalesce into a mosaic-like picture of a single day in postwar Munich, where American soldiers zoom down the streets in flashy cars and German bands play American jazz in night clubs. Koeppen's jumble of characters includes a homeless dog with a string tied around his neck, a washed-up German actor playing an archduke in a nostalgic period movie, a gaggle of earnest schoolteachers from Massachusetts, and many others. Washington Price, a Black American sergeant, hopes to marry his lover, Carla, a German woman who dreams of the plasticky affluence of the States—of "the bright and beautiful world of the magazines, of the automatic kitchens, the television sets, and the Hollywood-style ranch apartment." If Carla has inherited America's vulgar dreams, she has also inherited its vulgar bigotries; after she finds out that she is carrying Price's baby, she yearns to end the pregnancy because she

does not want to give birth to a Black child. Germany's liberators cannot even liberate their own country from its system of racial hatred.

The two days related in "The Hothouse" are even more cramped and compacted. The book is set in Bonn, where the West German Bundestag was situated, and its events are undated but probably take place in the early fifties, when the *Wirtschaftswunder,* or "economic miracle," of postwar reconstruction had reached a fever pitch. The city in the book is a strange hodgepodge of affluence and poverty, of shiny new shops and ragged old ruins. But if the seat of the West German government is flush with cash, it is also overrun with barely de-Nazified politicians, lending its prosperity a sickly cast. "Even the storms seemed to be manmade here," the protagonist thinks, "even the hot tired wind felt unreal."

Of the books in Koeppen's trilogy, "The Hothouse" is the most traditional. It does not quite confine itself to one character's point of view, but it is narrated almost entirely from the delirious and disintegrating perspective of Keetenheuve, a staunchly pacifist member of parliament who has travelled to the capital for a vote about whether to rearm the country—a vote that his side is sure to lose. The leader of his party entreats him "not to become too vehement in the forthcoming debate, not to offend nationalist instincts," even though offending nationalist instincts is precisely what he longs to do.

Keetenheuve is as contradictory and inconsistent as the rest of Koeppen's characters—heroic one moment, craven the next. He often wonders whether he should have given up on politics and devoted himself to his wife, who drank herself to death in large part because he neglected her; for long stretches of the day, he absents himself from party business and translates Baudelaire in his office. But he is drawn to escapism because he is crushed by vicarious guilt and dismay at his country's failure to atone for its crimes.

In one exquisitely dizzying sequence, Keetenheuve dissociates during a meeting about public-housing policy. Parliament's plans are unambitious, and he yearns for an entirely new sort of architecture, a landscape free of Nazi taint. Where are the millions of marks that his peers have budgeted for the project? "No one had ever seen them. . . . They were on paper, they were handed on on paper," he thinks. "They remained paper, a number on a piece of paper, until they finally materialized somewhere, and became forty

marks in someone's pay packet, and a stolen fifty-pfennig piece in a little boy's hand for an Indian comic book." Keetenheuve's imagination is too novelistic (that stolen fifty-pfenning piece! The crinkled pages of that comic!) to deal coolly in the abstractions that are the currency, literal and figurative, of the new Germany. What good is his determined humanism in the face of the great humming machine of bureaucracy? No good. His side loses the vote. Scarcely ten years after the end of the Second World War, West Germany is back to politics as usual.

"Death in Rome" is the outlier in the trilogy: it is the only book not set in Germany, the only one with stretches of first-person narration, and the only one in which sections end midsentence, as if it is crumbling before our very eyes. It is also the most nakedly accusatory. There are Nazi sympathizers and casual antisemites in "Pigeons on the Grass" and "The Hothouse," but "Death in Rome" is the only book of the three to feature rabid Nazi holdouts. One of these is Friedrich Wilhelm Pfaffrath, who served as a Nazi administrator in a town where he has now been elected mayor. Perhaps his most deeply ingrained Nazi tic is an instinctive reverence for boorish authority, epitomized in the figure of his brother-in-law, Gottlieb Judejahn, a top general who only escaped a death sentence at Nuremberg by fleeing to an unnamed Arab country.

Judejahn is in hiding, training an army for a king in the desert. He has travelled to Rome on a fake passport to meet Friedrich Wilhelm, who hopes to rehabilitate him and find him a position in the new West German administration. But Judejahn has no truck with his brother-in-law's accommodationism. He remains a true believer, and in his long, vengeful harangues he rages against (and lusts after) Jewish women, rants about his carnal craving for power, and surrenders to a "red mist" of irrepressible fury. Koeppen has been accused of writing caricatures rather than characters, and it is true that Judejahn claims to have been present at virtually every major event of the Third Reich—a career that even the most enterprising fascist could hardly have managed. He may be more of a symbolic figure than a believable one, but his fantastical wickedness is apt in a book with mythic undercurrents and a wealth of classical allusions.

The younger generation of Pfaffraths are less fancifully sketched and more despairing. Friedrich Wilhelm's estranged son, Siegfried, who was captured by the Allies and sent to a prisoner-of-war camp, has yet to set foot back in Germany and yet to speak to his family. When his father learns about an experimental symphony that Siegfried has composed, he dismisses it as "full of surrealism, cultural Bolshevism, and negroid newfangledness." Judejahn is even more mortified when he discovers that his son, Adolf, is in Rome training to become a priest. Both Siegfried and Adolf have rejected the indoctrination they were subjected to as students at an élite Nazi academy; both are desperate to expiate the sins of their fathers, one through prayers that he sometimes suspects are fruitless, the other through his peculiar art.

Siegfried is a composer of twelve-tone music, like the protagonist of Thomas Mann's 1947 novel, "Doctor Faustus." (The title of Koeppen's novel is a reference to Mann's novella "Death in Venice.") He means for his bizarre symphony to summon the old pagan gods—to evoke "the child's conversation with the daemon at nightfall." His music is bleak, and it often reflects the smashed-up world in which it was composed, but it is also designed to function as a kind of excavation, to reach beneath the sediment of the recent horrors to a past free of them. Like the poet Paul Celan, who sought to renew and thereby redeem the German language by resuscitating archaic words that the Nazis had not used or corrupted, Siegfried is in search of "the memory of an Edenic garden before the dawn of mankind, an approximation to the truth of things." His music is mostly, but not entirely, without hope.

Siegfried is largely resigned to the departure of the old gods and the innocent past they represent. Still, every so often, Koeppen's creations wonder whether divinity could be lurking where they least expect it. Siegfried is not religious, but he lights a candle in a church and offers it up to an "unknown saint." Maybe this figure "is even living in our midst, maybe he's someone we pass on the street, maybe he's the newspaper vendor in the passage shouting out the headlines." On the book's first page, Koeppen asks, "And what about great Jupiter? Is he here in our midst? Could he be the fellow in the Amex office, or the rep for the German-

European Travel Agency?" In one mood, it is a ridiculous conjecture, a mockery. In another, it is a fleeting and fragile but decidedly real possibility.

For the most part, the trilogy of failure casts history as an inexorable force: "water flowing through the old Roman pipes" and sweeping us along with it, a "stream . . . noisily rushing past," a guide leading a blind man. And yet the very same characters who are most entangled in history's meshes sometimes briefly wriggle free. In one moment in "Pigeons on the Grass," the sun is setting: "The people were released from their factories and shops, and they weren't yet caught up in the demands of their ordinary lives and the expectations of family. The world hung in the balance. For a moment, everything seemed possible." Despite its cynicism, Koeppen's trilogy is full of such moments, of cracks in the edifice of things, of what you might call grace.

What is so surprising about these often disconsolate books is that they are, perhaps despite themselves, outrageously beautiful. Often, Siegfried is convinced that his music is "futile," that the only thing he believes in is "the futility of everything." But then he is assailed by the beauty that so improbably and insolently persists:

> I love Rome as it is now, alive and manifest to me . . . I love the streets, the corners, the stairways, the quiet courtyards with urns, ivy, and lares, and the raucous squares with daredevil Lambretta riders, I love the people sitting on their doorsteps of an evening, their jokes, their expressive gestures, their gift for comedy, their conversation which is lost on me, I love the bubbling fountains with their sea gods, nymphs and tritons, I love the children sitting on the marble edge of the fountains . . .

So he continues for more than a page. Meanwhile, the Jewish daughter of a man whose murder Siegfried's father sanctioned and his uncle carried out looks out over the same city, and marvels that "the Romans, well acquainted with ruin and the devastation of former splendor, believed in the everlastingness of this particular arrangement of stones on the old earth."

Who could dare love a world so cracked and sullied? Most of the time, we are not capable of it. But sometimes, in the slim space between evening and

night, between one note in a song and another, between one page of a book and the next, we discover a new power in ourselves. Listening to Siegfried's discordant symphony, Adolf discerns "the memory of a time before guilt in these sounds, of a paradisal peace and beauty, of sadness at the entry of death into the world, there was much clamor for amity in the notes, no hymn to joy, no panegyric, but still a longing for joy and praise of creation." Out of the "No" that so often muffled Koeppen, there occasionally issued a choked but audible "Yes." ♦

Becca Rothfeld joined The New Yorker as a staff writer in February, 2026. Previously, she was the nonfiction book critic at the Washington Post.

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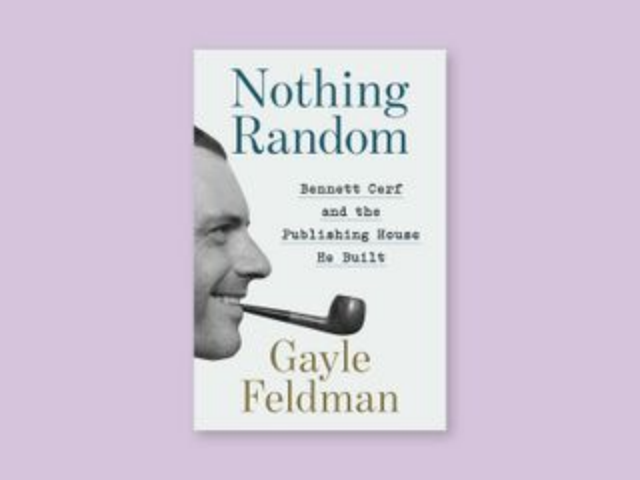
Books

Briefly Noted

“In Search of Now,” “Nothing Random,” “Of Loss and Lavender,” and “No Way Home.”

April 27, 2026

In Search of Now, *by Jo Marchant (Liveright)*. A mind-bending expedition into the science of the present moment, this book, by an award-winning science writer, examines the psychology, neurobiology, and physics behind the experience of second-to-second existence. Marchant’s references are appropriately heady: psychedelics, flow states, optical illusions, and wormholes. She writes approvingly of exotic new theories of temporal perception (such as QBism, an interpretation of quantum theory that emphasizes human beliefs and experiences) that argue against a deterministic view of the universe and instead affirm our agency: “It all comes down to the realisation that, on every scale, what we perceive and do, genuinely changes what exists in this moment, and what’s possible in the next.”



Nothing Random, *by Gayle Feldman (Random House)*. Bennett Cerf, the co-founder of the publishing giant Random House, may now be virtually unknown, but he was a major celebrity in postwar America. In this sweeping biography, Feldman reveals Cerf to be a paradoxical man: often described as superficial and unserious, renowned for writing joke books and for his tenure on the popular game show "What's My Line?," Cerf also published profound literary works by talents such as James Joyce, William Faulkner, and Eugene O'Neill—and, in doing so, transformed Random House into both a profitable business and a cultural force. Although Cerf chased fame and avoided plumbing "the depths" of his life, as Feldman writes, he could "appreciate, at times to the point of awe, depth in others."

What We're Reading

Illustration by Henri Campeã

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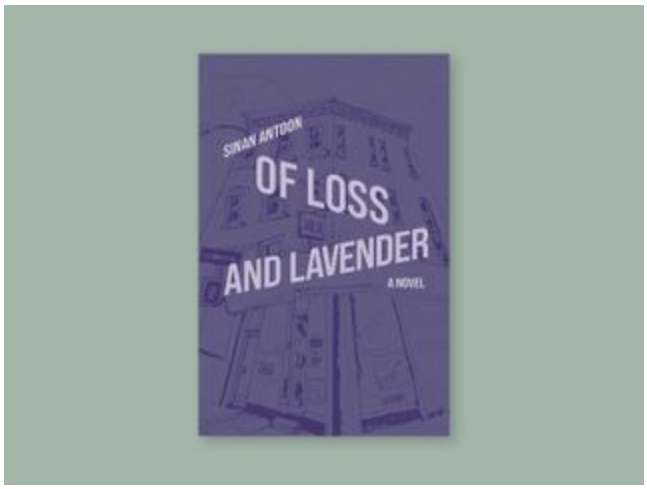

Of Loss and Lavender, *by Sinan Antoon, translated from the Arabic by the author (Other Press)*. The central characters of this contemplative novel are two Iraqi men—unknown to each other—who both immigrate to the U.S. in the wake of the Gulf War, and proceed down different paths. Sami, a retired doctor, moves to Brooklyn to live with his son's family. After arriving, he's diagnosed with dementia, and clings to memories of the home that he was reluctant to leave behind. Omar, an Army deserter, is eager to "amputate" Iraq "entirely from his memory"; as he settles into life on a farm in New Jersey, he tells people that he's from Puerto Rico. The narrative, which roams freely among its characters' perspectives, is a work of translation in every sense, as it seeks to convey, often through metaphor, the incomparable experience of exile.

No Way Home, *by T. C. Boyle (Liveright)*. This novel of quiet menace begins when a medical resident in Los Angeles, Terrence, receives a phone

call informing him that his mother has died. He soon goes to Nevada, where she lived, where he meets Bethany, a receptionist with a drinking problem. He is immediately—and dangerously—attracted to Bethany, who has a sinister ex-boyfriend who refuses to keep a distance. As the three characters grow entangled in destructive ways, Boyle's novel becomes a psychological drama full of tension, even as Terrence comes to feel that he is at an impasse.

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On and Off the Menu

The Sqirl Redemption Arc

The beloved L.A. café was brought low by a bucket of moldy jam. Now it's open for dinner.

***By** Hannah Goldfield*

April 27, 2026

When it opened in Virgil Village, in 2012, Sqirl embodied a scrappy millennial cool.Photo illustration by Jason Fulford and Tamara Shopsin

The origin story of the Los Angeles restaurant Sqirl is the stuff of a millennial fairy tale. In 2011, a woman named Jessica Koslow, just shy of thirty, ended a period of career indecision by starting a preserves company. (She'd oscillated between professional kitchens, mostly working in pastry, and TV production, including a stint at "American Idol.") Koslow made her name at farmers' markets and specialty shops, selling jars of jam in whimsical flavors such as raspberry-vanilla-bean and kumquat-chamomile. After a year, she moved into a tiny storefront in Virgil Village, a working-class, mostly Latino micro-neighborhood on the border of Silver Lake and East Hollywood. By 2013, the "sort-of cafe," as the late L.A. *Times* food critic Jonathan Gold described it in an early, glowing review, drew daily lines down the block. Tourists and locals alike were willing to wait half an hour for the privilege of ordering what is now on the menu as "famed ricotta toast"—a fat slab of lightly griddled brioche slathered in creamy cheese and striped with rainbow dollops of jam—or a sorrel-pesto rice

bowl, strewn with preserved Meyer lemon and topped with watermelon radish, feta, and a poached egg.

As is often true of gentrifying newcomers, Sqirl was thrillingly incongruous with its surroundings, a mix of low-slung apartment buildings, strip malls, and empty fenced-in lots. The menu, which had been designed to showcase Koslow's preserves, found the midpoint of hippie health food and indulgent diner classics; it adapted California cuisine, exemplified by the militant locavorism of Chez Panisse, into something more arch, casual, and world-wise. Sqirl embodied a growing feeling, even among the most jaded New Yorkers, that L.A. could be a place of scrappy creative ferment, beckoning with streaming-era writers' rooms and matcha lattes in the sunshine. In 2016, a writer for *Eater* declared it, in a seven-thousand-word feature, "the bastion of all things Californian and vegetable-forward and exciting and new"—and announced that she would soon be leaving Brooklyn for L.A.

For the first couple of months of the *COVID* pandemic, Sqirl, which had expanded across a few storefronts, fared as well as any restaurant could. A bigger upheaval arrived in July, a few weeks after Koslow posted, on Sqirl's Instagram page, a pledge to donate one per cent of the restaurant's gross sales to organizations that supported social-justice work, adding, "We stand with the Black community." An anonymous commenter called it an empty gesture and accused Koslow of various misdeeds, from disparaging Virgil Village to neglecting the well-being of her employees, many of whom were people of color. As others chimed in with similar allegations, Joe Rosenthal, a mathematician and restaurant obsessive in St. Paul, Minnesota, who describes himself as a "food antagonist," started sleuthing and sharing his findings. A former employee sent him a smoking gun: a photo of a ten-litre plastic bucket of glossy red jam blanketed in nightmarish, mosslike clumps of blue-green mold, which staff had apparently been instructed to scrape off before serving.

A mixture of moral outrage and lockdown angst turned #JamGate into national news. Koslow's second cookbook, "The Sqirl Jam Book," was published less than two weeks after the photo went viral; at the end of a paragraph about how to store homemade jam, she'd written, "You'll know to toss it when you see mold." Though food safety was a concern—a

mycologist quoted in the L.A. *Times* noted that “spores can grow quite deep into a gel as they disperse”—the layer of rot also came to feel like a pointed metaphor. Multiple employees described being put to work in a poorly ventilated kitchen space that was hidden from health inspectors until the restaurant was renovated in 2018. Two of Sqirl’s former chefs de cuisine, Javier Ramos and Ria Barbosa, claimed that Koslow took credit for their efforts and ideas. In May, Koslow had been nominated for a James Beard Award, for Best Chef: California; other former employees argued that she didn’t spend enough time in the kitchen to qualify. People who had never eaten at Sqirl sent death threats and flooded its Yelp page with bad reviews. Koslow attempted, falteringly, to defend herself, and then to apologize, and then to promise to do better, but the damage was done. As far as the internet was concerned, she was cooked.

Or was she? Koslow closed the restaurant for a single day, “because we had people outside with signs and the team needed a mental-health day,” she told me recently. A major player in the industry advised her to shut down the business entirely, reasoning that she could never recover her reputation. “I think it was something I needed to hear at the time,” Koslow said, but, she’d concluded, “there’s nothing else I want to do.” For the next five years, the restaurant chugged along with new jam-storage protocols in place, and Koslow mostly kept a low profile—until last fall, when she announced that Sqirl would be extending its hours and débuting a dinner menu. In a Substack post that teased new dishes such as *shima-aji* crudo and chicken-liver mousse with celery butter, Koslow mentioned some ideas that didn’t make the cut, and emphasized the importance of making a “glorious misstep.” “Here’s the truth,” she wrote. “Getting it wrong is part of getting it right.”

Koslow, who is forty-four, grew up in Long Beach, California, the only child of a single mother, who is a dermatologist. Through college, Koslow figure skated competitively, a pursuit that seems less surprising the more time you spend with her. She carries herself with a sense of destiny; the only post on her personal Instagram page is a picture of her with the celebrity restaurateur Nancy Silverton, captioned, “A dreamlike photo of my current self speaking to my future self at dinner.” “I’m a person who gets very obsessed with a thing—I will watch a show seven times in a row,

I will read a book seven times in a row," Koslow told me. Lately, she's been reading "a lot of Rick Rubin." At one point, she suggested we go for a walk as we talked, an idea she'd gotten from Walter Isaacson's biography of Steve Jobs, which she was listening to as an audiobook.

Koslow wears two lobster pendants around her neck, an homage to a crawfish that she saw in the L.A. River, last fall, while she was doing the Rosh Hashanah ritual of tashlik—casting away regrets by throwing stale bread into a body of water. She had read that a crawfish was a symbol of resilience. One gets the sense that Koslow's tenacious striving extends to "doing the work," or at least trying to. She cooks on the line at Sqirl several days a week, and, when she talks about the dinner menu, she is careful to credit her chef de cuisine, Sandra Felix, and her executive sous chef, Guillermo Mendez, for their contributions. She speaks adoringly of Jose (Saul) Parada, a Salvadoran man in his fifties who oversees all of Sqirl's jam-making, which takes place in a bright, health-department-certified facility, of which she gave me a thorough tour. On the street, we bumped into Anthony Trang, whom Koslow had hired to give massages to all of her managers, at her own expense. When I asked her about the events of 2020, she tended to reply in words that were nonspecific but seemed deeply felt. "It was a moment," she said. "I'm not gonna make any excuse for it. It was the moment, and we were a part of it, and we're better for it. I'm better for it, you know?"

Not everyone is convinced. Shortly after Sqirl opened for dinner, Ben Mims, a cookbook author and former L.A. *Times* columnist, wrote on Instagram, "The collective amnesia people seem to have about Sqirl always astounds me." When I reached him by phone, Joe Rosenthal wondered why restaurateurs who are caught behaving badly never seem to atone by ceding ownership to their employees. "That didn't happen with Noma, as far as I know," he said. A friend of mine, a keen observer of the restaurant world, opined that Koslow is a "perfect twenty-first century figure." "Everything was more than it should have been," he said. "Heralded more than she should have been. Shamed more than she should have been."

Koslow, a self-described "student of restaurants," talks about the dining experience as something that goes well beyond food; perfecting it requires

an auteurish sense for atmosphere and character. For many years, she has employed full-time designers to help execute the finer details of her vision, from the fonts on her granola packaging to the lighting in the bathroom. Every afternoon, before "*P.M.*" service, the staff does a full turnover, replacing the metal folding tables on the sidewalk with elegant wooden ones, set with flowers and wineglasses. One recent evening, two older couples arrived for a five-thirty reservation; they turned out to be colleagues of Koslow's husband, Ryan Erlich, and their wives. They fawned like proud parents over Koslow. "This is the girl who gets—who was it, on the 'Today' show?" one of the men said. "Matt Lauer!" his wife exclaimed. Koslow looked slightly embarrassed, then explained that, in 2016, Lauer opened a jar of Sqirl jam on TV. "I woke up in the morning to forty-five thousand dollars in sales online," she said sheepishly.

What impressed me most about my own dinners at Sqirl were the marks of Koslow's gift for world-building. There are subtle nods to the heavy-hitter institutions that she reveres: napkins with buttonholes so they can be attached to one's lapel, like they have at Hillstone, and small sheets of green stationery for doodling on, printed with a cartoon of a tuxedoed waiter, a tribute to the New York steak house Keen's. The evening menu veers more formal and European—*pommes aligot*, beef tartare, smoked-beet agnolotti—but it's threaded with sly references to the greatest hits of daytime, such as an excellent Sorrel Sour cocktail, and jam made from Jimmy Nardello peppers served with toasted sourdough.

For more than a decade, a crew of loyalists who became friends at Sqirl—a public librarian, a fitness C.E.O., more than one film producer—have met there for breakfast every Saturday when it opens, at 8 *A.M.* "I made an album of my kids growing up at Sqirl," Sarah Sugerman, an "O.G." member of the breakfast club, said one recent morning, while knitting and eating an egg sandwich. It was where her son, now in his twenties, had staged a "promposal." Koslow always wanted Sqirl to feel like "Cheers," Erlich told me, and she'd been delighted when Rhea Perlman, who played Carla Tortelli on the show, recently came for dinner. ♦

Hannah Goldfield, a staff writer covering restaurants and food culture, received a 2024 James Beard Award for her Profile of the chef Kwame Onwuachi.

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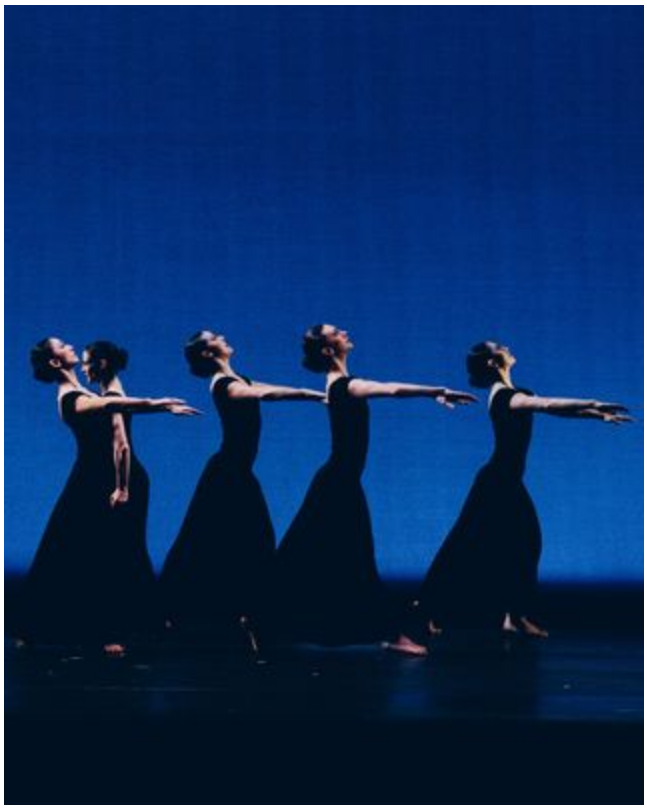
Dancing

How Long Can Martha Graham’s Dance Revolution Last?

As the company she left behind celebrates its centenary, it finds itself caught between preservation and radical tradition.

By Jennifer Homans

April 27, 2026



A scene from a reconstruction of Graham’s antiwar ballet “Chronicle,” from 1936.Photographs by Amir Hamja for The New Yorker

The Martha Graham Dance Company recently celebrated its hundredth anniversary, a remarkable feat, considering how much it has been through since Graham’s death, in 1991—a flood, financial crises, repeated closures, and an ugly, years-long legal battle over the rights to her dances which was resolved in the company’s favor only in 2005. All this had left a doomed

feeling that the work of Martha Graham, one of the most outstanding dance artists of the twentieth century, might vanish. The anniversary seemed an almost too sunny effort to banish those dark days, with a star-studded gala, a PBS documentary, a quick tour, and the launch of comprehensive video documentation of the Graham technique, culminating in five nights of performances at New York's City Center.

The programming featured some of Graham's earliest and finest dances—including "Appalachian Spring" (1944) and "Night Journey" (1947)—but, oddly, there was only one all-Graham evening, and it was billed, a bit ambivalently, as a "preview" (for whom?). Both the opening night and the rest of the run offered classic Graham works along with dances by contemporary choreographers. This "old with the new" model is by now standard legacy framing—we see it with Balanchine at New York City Ballet, for example—but it comes with a deep anxiety: Does the old work hold up nearly a century later? And what is Graham's legacy, anyway?

Graham saw herself primarily as a dancer—she made dances, she said, so that she would have something to dance. It could be said that she invented a people and a place. The people were dancers, all women when she founded her own company, in 1926. The place was the floor, which became a whole world. Drawing on the work of her peers, such as Ruth St. Denis and Doris Humphrey, she soon created a dance technique that was shockingly radical. Today we hardly notice it, because, like the idea of the Freudian unconscious—which was theorized in 1899 and became one of Graham's influences—we take it for granted.

What was this technique? One way to think of it is as anti-ballet. Ballet strives for symmetry and harmony, for spinal alignment, turnout, balance, and flow—its goal is lightness and flight. Graham bodies were rooted, with a strong center of gravity while being flexible through the spine, and she excavated areas of the body that (in the Western tradition) had been locked or hidden through convention or denial. Her goal was to mine intense emotion and hardship, to live on the earth rather than aim for the heavens.

Jai Perez (center) as the Preacher with his Followers in Graham's "Appalachian Spring," from 1944.

At the heart of her method—then and now—is contraction and release. Imagine a breath is sharply expelled, hollowing out the core until the lower spine curves and is then released, returning the body to a straight posture. There is no collapse but, instead, an expansive carving out of the pelvic region—Graham called it a "vaginal cry," which radiates up and down the body and expresses raw emotions like shock, fear, pain, and, above all in her lexicon, sexuality. The cry can throw the body into ecstasy or terror but—crucially—it is also an act of profound control. Add to this ways to fall to the floor and "recover" to the feet at lightning speed. Nothing was fixed: like ballet, the only other Western dance form I know with similar depth and range, Graham technique was developed and expanded by choreography.

Consider "Appalachian Spring." Set to music by Aaron Copland, it is a taut study of an American frontier community, featuring a Preacher, four (Shaker-like) Followers, a Pioneering Woman, and a Husbandman and a Bride (originally danced by Graham herself), whose marital bliss is

interrupted by an intimation of war. At City Center, the sets conceived by Isamu Noguchi, a Graham regular, consisted of a bare-bones home—indicated by planks, a hint of a fence, a few stairs, and a rocking chair—and the Preacher's church, comprising a simple platform and an adjacent wall. The dance was similarly abstract, with clean lines and spare portraitlike images recalling Grant Wood's "American Gothic" or John Ford's Westerns. The inhabitants of this space walk onto the stage in profile, one by one, and take their positions—on a rocking chair, against a wall. The Followers have bent elbows and knees and prayerful cupped hands, and often move with little birdlike hops around the Preacher (Jai Perez), who presides with proud posture and reverential knee-hinges to the floor.

Members of this community dance together and separately, but they are always telling a collective story. The Bride (Anne Souder) and the Husbandman (Lloyd Knight), for example, do a dance of open gestures and joyful jumps to Copland's variation on "Simple Gifts" as the Preacher watches from his platform and his Followers sit primly in a row.

At the very end of the ballet, the couple is alone onstage. She sits tall on the rocking chair, and he stands behind her, gently putting his hand on her shoulder. She places her hand on his and draws her free arm across the horizon; the couple's eyes wistfully follow as the curtain falls. No sentiment, only restraint, but the emotion is powerful and enduring. Most dances dissolve as you watch them, but "Appalachian Spring" is so clear and architectural in its design that it seems almost like a solid object. I have been watching it on and off for fifty years and still find it a marvel.

"Night Journey," with music by William Schuman, fared less well. These sets, too, are Noguchi abstractions—a stool, stepping stones, a "nonbed-bed"—but this time the dance is more narrative. It tells the story of Oedipus (drawn from the Sophocles play), who is fated to unknowingly kill his father, King Laius, and marry his mother, Queen Jocasta. Graham gives us the story from the point of view of Jocasta (a part she danced), a choice that, as the scholar Sally Banes has pointed out, shifts the emphasis away from Oedipus' impossible dilemma to Jocasta's sexual passion and repulsion for a man she instinctively knows is her son. Much has (rightly) been made of Graham's intense relationship with the dancer Erick Hawkins,

fifteen years her junior, whom she cast as Oedipus. (They married the following year.) But the life-into-art sheen of the original production cannot sustain the dance today.

The piece begins with Jocasta, danced here by Xin Ying, holding a rope above her head, about to strangle herself. At the behest of the blind seer Tiresias, she goes back in her mind to the events that drove her to this tragic end. This means that most of the ballet takes place in flashback and includes two scenes that Sophocles did not show: the moment of incest and Jocasta's suicide. Just as Graham wanted to push deep inside the body to discover hidden regions of sexuality and emotion, she is obsessed by the idea of revealing these hidden acts—but the dance struggles to convey the intricacies of the rest of the story.

Leslie Andrea Williams in "Spectre-1914," the first part of "Chronicle."

The core of the ballet is a long scene in which the bare-chested Oedipus, Lloyd Knight, clad in bikini briefs with decorative golden squiggles, courts Jocasta, who is wearing a chaste and queenly gown. Today, his Tarzan-like posturing and phallically extended legs and arms come off as cringey masculine preening. Meanwhile, she contracts her torso like a thumping

heart to show her inner passion, while also covering herself demurely with ritual branches. Finally, he falls flat on top of her, and after a brief struggle—Jocasta's unconscious repulsion—the incestuous deed is done, and they both roll over, exhausted. This open depiction of a woman's agonizing desire may have been striking in 1947, but today it feels silly and quaint, and why shouldn't it? Graham herself noted that dances quickly become dated.

"Night Journey" left me troubled, too, because it seemed suffused with reverence for Graham, whose mystique and iconic performances are baked into the choreography. This makes it difficult for subsequent dancers, however accomplished, to bring to her roles their own styles and bodies. At moments, Xin seemed trapped in a dance that had no give. The music, which Schuman composed for Graham, is full of the brash rhythmic sounds she seemed to favor. Graham once admitted that she did not like strings—they were too lush and romantic, too balletic—and preferred (even for dance class) drumlike chords that better matched her movement.

The contemporary dances interspersed between these Graham epics were disappointing. Hope Boykin's "En Masse," to music by Leonard Bernstein, meant well but lacked structure and style; Baye and Asa's "Cortege," a riff on Graham's "Cortege of Eagles," was a predictable technocratic work built around bland images of social violence. Hofesh Shechter's "Cave," to music by Âme and Shechter himself, is a "rave" for the stage in which the dancers twitch and let loose (I guess), falling into vibrating trance states with the help of lighting effects and loud music. The only exceptional dance was Jamar Roberts's short solo for Lloyd Knight, "To the Brink and Back," with percussive music by Stahv Danker, who performed his moving score onstage. Here were slow, cushioned movements, valleys and peaks, and contractions so deeply sunk into the body that you hardly noticed them. It allowed us to see Knight, who has been with the company for twenty-one years, in ways that Graham's exigencies do not always allow.

The anniversary performances were a reminder that the Graham company is caught between preservation, which is inherently conservative, and the radical tradition it wishes to sustain. Nowhere was this more apparent than in "Chronicle," a reconstruction (largely from old films and photographs) of

three fragments from a lost antiwar ballet that Graham made in 1936. It had gorgeous moments—the dancers seemed deeply engaged—but its martial music and vehement images of blood and suffering shaded into propaganda.

In Graham's life, technique and choreography were the same thing. But if we think of them as separate, the technique becomes anyone's tool. And if Graham technique is anything like ballet, it could remain a neutral staple of training—that thing we hardly notice—until another generation of artists transforms its use and meaning into something new. Graham but not Graham—or, as she herself put it, "the only thing we have is the now." ♦

Jennifer Homans, the magazine's dance critic, is the author of books including "Mr. B: George Balanchine's 20th Century."

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On Television

“Half Man” Tests the Limits of Brotherly Love

Richard Gadd’s follow-up to “Baby Reindeer” traces a decades-long quasi-familial relationship that’s thornier than any other male bond on TV.

By Inkoo Kang

April 24, 2026

“Half Man” makes the dynamic between its two leads as complicated, codependent, and, at times, troublesomely erotic as it can get.Illustration by Emiliano Ponzi

The course of fifteen-year-old Niall Kennedy’s life changes the first day he walks to school with his almost-stepbrother, Ruben. It’s 1986 and, like so many boys with spindly physiques and a love of science fiction, Niall (Mitchell Robertson) is dogged by bullies—though, in his case, the harassment is also a result of his mom’s romantic involvement with a woman, Ruben’s scowling mother. Niall, closeted and cerebral, is terrified of Ruben (Stuart Campbell), an earthy, charismatic bruiser fresh from a juvenile-detention center, but he intuits that the older boy may be his best

chance at survival. When Niall's tormentors yell their usual slurs on that fateful morning, it's Ruben who makes the next move. He shoves Niall into a wall and asks, with their faces inches apart, "Are these guys bothering you, Bambi?" They both know that Ruben is a pit bull, and that he's asking for permission to be unleashed. When Niall finally cops to the obvious, Ruben pulls out a knife and urges him to head to class alone: "You're not a witness if you don't see what happens."

The new HBO/BBC drama "Half Man" follows Niall and Ruben, who consider themselves brothers even after their mothers' breakup, for the next three decades. Set largely in a working-class neighborhood of Glasgow marked by chipped paint and dowdy patterns, the series adheres to the jagged rhythms of Niall and Ruben's relationship, skipping over years of separation or estrangement to catch them as they reënter each other's orbits, willingly or otherwise. Niall (played as an adult by Jamie Bell) might deploy his sibling as an attack dog, but he can't insure that Ruben (a newly ripped Richard Gadd) won't occasionally charge at him, too. As their mutual competitiveness grows shockingly ugly, Niall learns to turn Ruben's Samsonian strength and fury against him, knocking down the pillars of Ruben's own life.

Men, society tells us ad nauseam, are simple creatures. Even those beating the drum of the male-loneliness crisis seem convinced that the problem of men's stunted emotional lives is easily solved: more group activities, less time online. Gadd, the creator of "Half Man" as well as one of its stars, clearly believes the matter is more complicated than that—and makes the dynamic between his two leads as thorny, codependent, and, at times, troublesomely erotic as it can get. (The other male-bonding drama of the moment, "DTF St. Louis," in which one middle-aged suburban dad is credibly suspected of murdering another, is practically feel-good by comparison.) Gadd's ambitions are evident from the opening scene, when, in a framing device set in the present day, Ruben crashes Niall's wedding—an event he learned of that morning. The pair sequester themselves in a shed while guests revel outside in the sunshine. "You look gorgeous," Ruben tells Niall. "If I wasn't family, I'd get up underneath that kilt right away." He reaches for Niall's privates in a juvenile show of dominance. We soon see that Ruben has made a lifelong habit of such sexualized power plays—

and that Niall's deep-seated shame about his queerness was likely augmented by shame about his attraction to a man who calls him brother.

"Half Man" is a grimmer affair than Gadd's previous series, "Baby Reindeer," a fictionalized account of his experience being aggressively stalked by a woman for four years. The most potent material in the new show is connected to themes he explored there as well: internalized homophobia, the sexual assault of men, and the evasion of blame. In "Half Man," Gadd's treatment of these themes is richer and more mature; with the two projects, each defined by shifting notions of victimhood and culpability, he's emerged as a bard of self-loathing. Ruben, never book-smart, is aggrieved by the doors that open for Niall as a result of his academic achievements. Niall, for his part, only comes to hate himself more as gay acceptance goes mainstream, his initial distress over his sexuality compounded by humiliation at being unable to get *past* that distress. His yearning for Ruben's approval and fear of his own desires are so acute that, when the show flashes forward to Niall's wedding again, one half expects to see a woman waiting at the altar.

His soon-to-be spouse, as it turns out, is someone he met decades earlier—a reminder that, for a story with such chronological breadth, the cast of characters is surprisingly small. But the meagreness of the world befits its protagonists, both of whom become stuck in certain phases after failing to come to grips with their formative traumas. The size of the ensemble also belies its strength. Of particular note is Niall's mother, Lori (Neve McIntosh), who joins her ex-girlfriend, Maura (Marianne McIvor), in defending Ruben despite his many transgressions. As the show progresses, she treads a blurred line between offering Ruben second chances and simply enabling him, especially as his antisocial rampages repeatedly land him in prison. Her unsentimentality toward her own son, meanwhile, is funny, upsetting, and, I suspect, thoroughly British. "I've given you life," she scolds Niall. "I don't need to give you respect."

Gadd's post-penitentiary Ruben is another formidable presence, endowed with a leonine rumble that betrays his dissatisfactions, and a predatory gaze that quickly sizes up those around him. But, as the series' writer, Gadd doesn't deliver much in the way of fresh insight about troubled masculinity.

Ruben is a hurt person who hurts people, and the kind of patriarchal figure who sees it as his right to subdue members of his own family, as long as he also protects them from outsiders. The most didactic and mannered scenes are the ones that purport to explain him; for all these efforts to psychoanalyze, he ultimately feels more like a cautionary tale than a fully realized character.

But the show's plotting and Niall's exquisite complexity more than make up for Ruben's relative flatness. The many leaps in time to the wedding—to which Ruben shows up on a motorcycle, angry enough to knock his brother out with a single punch—consistently ratchet up the sense of dread, and the suspense over why or how these two have stayed enmeshed. (A flashback to Niall's university days offers a clue: alone and overwhelmed in his first week away from home, he calls Ruben in the middle of the night, whispering, "I need you," as though relapsing; Ruben arrives the next morning like a vampire who's been invited in.) The sad but realistic turns in their lives are engrossing, as is their slow convergence. If Ruben is blatantly pathological in his obsession with status, his tendency toward self-sabotage, and his inability to take responsibility, Niall is gradually revealed to be afflicted with the same qualities, albeit in a less expected package. His characterization benefits from its rootedness in a specific era, when it was more understandable that he might have been too busy trying on masks to sort out his identity—or to reckon with his complicity in his brother's crimes. Bell, whose screen roles have long radiated decency and sensitivity, channels that guilelessness once more, only to expose it as yet another façade that helps Niall to conceal his darker impulses.

Against all good sense, Niall pursues a childhood dream of becoming a writer—an aspiration he cultivates by reimagining his father, a bartender who scribbled on the side and died young, as a thwarted literary talent. His breakthrough comes with an autobiographical novel, which centers on a thinly veiled Ruben. Critics and journalists prove more interested in the book's antihero than in its author; as Ruben himself crows, "I'm your fuckin' muse." But Niall is the series' singular achievement, in part for his awareness that he'll always be a shadow to a man who has more life force than he knows what to do with. On his wedding day, Ruben asks him

whether he loves him. After dissembling for a minute, Niall gives an honest answer: “It’s the only thing I’ve ever felt.” ♦

Inkoo Kang, a staff writer, has been a television critic for The New Yorker since 2022.

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Poems

- **“Tompkins Square”**
  By Anthony Walton | “It was an evening they had planned, privately, in the sequester / of their thoughts for years before it could or should have / happened.”
- **“A Theory on the Origin of Language”**
  By Tishani Doshi | “Last night, after months away from home, / a lapwing piercing the still dark still / with its warnings.”

Poems

Tompkins Square

By ***Anthony Walton***
April 27, 2026

It was an evening they had planned, privately, in the sequester
of their thoughts for years before it could or should have
happened. They had been involved with others, and there was
satisfaction in the waiting, and tension—he had never before
acknowledged he could be content with indefinite apprehension.
Daydreaming, he took pleasure in their brief meetings on the
astral plane, entwined among the stars. Relating this while
walking, he saw her smile, and without looking at him
said only if those stars floated and burned through the saline
and spongy almonds of his amygdala. Then, suddenly aware
she may have wounded, she said that she, too, had had her
rendezvous with him, in the furthest physical crevasses
of her fleshly brain, via the electrical impulses that were her
dreams, and that was good enough. That was what was actual,
because it sprang from the facticity of her body, and it was enough.
Until it wasn't. Enough. Until the day—the afternoon—when
they could no longer pretend it was not going to happen. They
made their excuses, their exits, gently made their way toward each
other, reducing themselves—their hopes and plans and ways
of being—to a simple theatre of one man and one woman.
They reduced the stage to a cultivated garden of glances,
abstractions, euphemisms, and a chasm, the bottom of which was
a silence that swallowed all intentions. In this enactment of the
story, the garden of their imagining is also known as Tompkins
Square Park. As in the common tale, the garden is plagued
with serpents, but they need be concerned with only two,
the twins, Experience and Recrimination, who bid them fumble

and grope through inarticulate dark in the hope that their love was
a form of light, something they could read by. Something they
could learn. They resolved to be uncertain scholars of the inevitable,
but, in the concordances of language, progress is circular, if at all.
Which brought them back to each other, to feed that hunger
to know and be known, but all they could do was gesture through
the billowing space they saw and felt as a full and cerulean sky, full
of distant, glittering lights, words and stars that were like the Milky
Way they wanted to believe was love, a love that loomed—as they
sat on the bench in the park that Sunday afternoon—like a galaxy
between them. Then, remembering that there was much for them
to do, they set off for the room, a friend's empty studio, where they
worked their way to each other over the course of the evening—
him trying this, her asking for that, each coming to realize what
they had felt was substantial, was made of substance. Hours later,
they lay exhausted, spent, and nothing remained, except the hunger.

Anthony Walton is the author of the poetry collection "Celestial Mechanics" (September, 2026).

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Poems

A Theory on the Origin of Language

By ***Tishani Doshi***
April 27, 2026

Last night, after months away from home,
a lapwing piercing the still dark still
with its warnings. Language, perhaps,
began like this. A campfire. One person
to keep watch, who would have needed
something to sound danger. A word like *Tiger!*
Air strike! *Run!* And once the words entered
they were unstoppable, dragging dirt into the hallways
of our brains, pitching tents to watch sunsets over the graying
swamp. We had learned by then to make cleavers and picks,
tools to carve the scavenged flesh off bison and mammoths.
Language and violence proceeding together. It was only later,
in the flowering, armed with lorgnettes in the garden,
that we could say things like *Go and give the ass a drink*
of wine to wash down the figs. Or *Will spend time preening*
after copulation. When we lie down, you and I, our backs
against the scrape of ground in this rain-fed open country,
all the shrapnel-burst horrors of the year unable to be named
and so unable to pass from plowed fields of heart
to limb, to throat. We let go. Lift our legs to the sky
as though they could hold up the heavens. Meaning
recedes. In Armenian, a way to say I love you is
I want to eat your liver. In Arabic, *I want you to bury me*.
I want you to walk on my eyelashes. Feel the retreat
of thick sea ice collapse across our bodies. The ancestors

of lapwings—they had feathers for a million years
before ever using them to fly. Our tongues.
Monarchs in the cradles of our mouths.
Now scream. Now sing.

This is drawn from "Egrets, While War."

Tishani Doshi is the author of the poetry collection "Egrets, While War" (September, 2026).

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Puzzles & Games

- **The Crossword: Monday, April 27, 2026**
  By Will Nediger | A challenging puzzle.

Crossword

The Crossword: Monday, April 27, 2026

A challenging puzzle.

By Will Nediger

April 27, 2026

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Will Nediger is a crossword constructor from London, Ontario, who publishes puzzles independently under the name Bewilderingly.

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